

DECLENSIONS OF DARK WATER



a novel

Elian Voigt

FORMÆTRIX

Copyright © 2026 by Elian Voigt

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without prior written permission of the publisher, except brief quotations used in reviews and critical articles.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents either are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

Cover design and interior typography by Formætrix.

Set in EB Garamond.

Second Edition, Revised, 2026.

ISBN 978-1-XXXXXX-XX-X

formaetrix.com

READING PROOF — not the final typeset book.

Display type shows TeX Gyre Pagella for EB Garamond; the Aldine leaf is borrowed from DejaVu Sans. Chapter and coda openings show the designed Roman-numeral fallback in place of the nineteen staves of Vikamál, because no font available to this build covers the Unicode Runic block. Body text, measure, trim, spacing and all content are exactly as authored. See BUILD-NOTES.md.

For those who keep the grammar.

I



He empties his mother's flat the way he would open a site.

This is not a decision. He arrives on the first Saturday in February with a roll of bin bags, a marker pen, and eighteen flat-packed archive boxes bought in bulk from a supplier the department uses, and by the time he has the kettle on he has already established a working order — back bedroom first, kitchen last, nothing to leave the building unlabelled — and it is only when he catches himself writing *BEDROOM 2 / TEXTILE / NO PROVENANCE* on the side of a box of his mother's cardigans that he stops with the pen in his hand and stands very still in the middle of the room for about a minute.

Then he finishes writing it, because the alternative is a box with nothing on it.

The flat is the ground floor of a converted house on the Grantchester road, and it is small and warm and profoundly, aggressively tidy, and it takes him four weekends to establish that it contains nothing. Not nothing of value — there are the cardigans, and a good set of pans, and eleven hundred pounds in premium bonds, and a chest of drawers that a dealer in Cherry Hinton will eventually give him three hundred for. He means nothing of *her*. No letters. No address book older than the current one. No diaries, no keepsakes, no drawer of the unfileable that every human being on earth maintains. He finds a shoebox at the top of the wardrobe and his heart does something complicated and it is full of receipts for a boiler, sorted by year.

The photographs begin at roughly twenty-five. He knows this already; he has known it since he was a boy. But it is different to know it and to lay it out on a bed. There is a whole life, orderly and well documented: Elizabeth at thirty at a colleague's wedding, Elizabeth at forty holding him at a swimming gala with the pinched proud expression of a woman being photographed against her preference, Elizabeth at sixty in a garden in Suffolk. And then the sequence simply runs out at the near end, the way a road runs out, and behind it is the white of a page nobody

wrote on.

He is fifty-five years old. He is one of the four people in Britain who could reasonably be described as an authority on how communities stop saying things. And he stands in his mother's bedroom with her life laid out chronologically on the duvet, and thinks, with the clean shock of something one has been avoiding at eye level for decades: *I have never once made her tell me.*

• • •

Her coat is on the back of the door.

It is navy, wool, from a shop on Green Street that closed years ago, and it is the last thing in the flat and he has left it deliberately until last, and when he takes it off the hook the door feels different in the room. He stands with it over his arm. It is a coat. It is eleven hundred grammes of wool and a lining that has gone at one shoulder. It does not hold anything.

He hangs it back on the hook.

He tells himself he will take it next time, and there is a next time, and he does not take it then either, and in the end he hands the keys to the agent with the coat still hanging on the back of the door, and does not mention it, and drives home, and this remains the single most uncharacteristic act of his adult life.

• • •

The woman in the upstairs flat is called Mrs. Ogilvie and she comes down on the third weekend with a tin of shortbread and stays fifty minutes.

She is kind and slightly deaf and clearly lonely, and she wants to tell him that his mother was a lovely neighbour, very private, wonderful in the snow. Rowan makes tea and lets her talk, and does what he always does with an informant, which is to say almost nothing and leave the gaps open.

"She never had people," Mrs. Ogilvie says. "Not that she was unfriendly. She'd stop and talk on the path for half an hour. But she never had people in."

"No."

"Nineteen years I lived over her." She takes a shortbread. "Do you know, I couldn't have told you where she was from."

Rowan holds his cup. "What would you have guessed?"

"Oh —" Mrs. Ogilvie waves vaguely, "— north somewhere? There was a thing in the vowels sometimes, on the phone. Not often." She thinks about it. "I did ask her once. Years ago. And she said —" and here Mrs. Ogilvie's face does something interesting, a small backwards groping, "— she said something perfectly nice, and

I remember thinking what a nice answer it was, and I couldn't tell you now what it was."

She laughs at herself.

Rowan does not laugh. He is sitting very still, because he has just watched a technique he has spent his career describing, performed by a master, on a woman who did not notice it happening and has not noticed in the forty years since. A response with the correct affective shape and no informational content. Warmth as a sealant. He has published on this. He has a diagram.

"You're a professor, aren't you," Mrs. Ogilvie says comfortably. "What is it you do?"

"Languages," Rowan says. "More or less."

"Lovely," says Mrs. Ogilvie, satisfied, and Rowan hears himself do it — the identical manoeuvre, the same afternoon, in the same room — and does not correct it.

• • •

The tin is under the bed, at the back, behind the vacuum cleaner.

It is a biscuit tin, decorated with a Highland scene that has no plausible connection to anything, and it does not rattle. He sits down on the floor with his back to the bed and takes the lid off, and the lid is stiff, and comes free with a small sucking noise.

Three things.

A sealed envelope, cream, unstamped. On the face, in his mother's hand, four characters and a full stop. *for E.B. only*.

A photograph, unlabelled on the front. A young woman on a shore of black rock, wind in her hair, the surf behind her the colour of pewter, and she is squinting, and half-laughing at whoever holds the camera. She is perhaps seventeen. Rowan looks at it for a long moment as a photograph of a stranger — notes the coat, the period, the rock type, dates it loosely to the mid-sixties — and then the eyes come up out of it and find him, and the room tilts, and he puts the photograph face down on the carpet and sits with his hand flat on the back of it.

On the reverse, in pencil, one word. *Brynjavík*.

And forty or so scraps of paper, all sizes, all in her handwriting.

• • •

He takes the scraps home and it is three weeks before he understands them, and the three weeks are not idleness. He looks at them almost every night.

They are Icelandic. That much is instant. They are not, as he assumes for the first fortnight, phrases — not copied proverbs, not vocabulary, not the notes of an adult learner. He assumes an adult learner because that is the ordinary explanation and because it is bearable: a woman in her forties in a small flat in Grantchester, teaching herself the language of a country she came from, privately, the way people take up the piano. He builds this picture in some detail. He is fond of it.

In the third week he lays them all out on the floor of his own front room, in no order, because he has run out of better ideas, and he crouches over them with a mug going cold on the mantelpiece, and he sees it in about four seconds.

They are drills.

Each scrap carries one stem, run through a fixed sequence of endings. The hand is even. The spacing is even. There are no crossings-out. There is no English anywhere on any of the forty scraps — not a gloss, not a translation, not a note-to-self, nothing. A learner glosses. A learner cannot help it; the whole point of a learner's notebook is the bridge back to the language they own. These are not bridges. These are repetitions, produced at speed, by a hand that did not have to stop and think about what came next.

And then, because he cannot not, he reads the sequence.

Nominative. Accusative. Dative. Genitive.

And then three more columns.

He kneels on the carpet with his glasses pushed up on his forehead and looks at the fifth, sixth and seventh columns of a paradigm that has four, and the headings are abbreviated to two or three characters in a convention he does not recognise, and on every single scrap the seventh column runs off the right-hand edge of the paper, because every single scrap has been torn.

Not cut. Torn, by hand, along the same margin, forty times.

Rowan sits back on his heels.

He is very good at this. That is the thing he will think about later, in a rented cottage nine hundred miles north, with the sea writing on the glass: that he was very good at this, and that it took him four seconds, and that the whole apparatus of a career was available to him on the floor of his own front room. He has, sitting on the shelf above him, a monograph with his name on it about the material traces of suppressed grammatical categories. He has given the plenary. He knows precisely what it means when a paradigm is drilled past the point where the living language has cases to fill, and he knows exactly what it means when the part past the fourth column is missing, forty times, by hand.

He gets up. He puts the kettle on. He comes back and gathers the scraps carefully into a stack, squares them, and puts them in the tin with the envelope and the photograph, and puts the lid on.

He does not write it down.

That is the whole of it, and it takes four seconds and lasts thirty years, and no

one is in the room. He has a notebook on the arm of the chair, because there is always a notebook on the arm of the chair, and he does not pick it up. He carries the tin upstairs and puts it in the bottom of the wardrobe, and goes to bed, and sleeps badly, and in the morning he goes to a supervision and is, by common consent, on excellent form.

• • •

The grant proposal takes him eleven days and it is the best thing he has written in a decade.

Morphological attrition in a terminal speech community: case syncretism and lexical avoidance on the north Icelandic coast. He does not lie in it. This is important to him afterwards, and it is true: there is not a false sentence in the document. The site is genuinely under-described. The dialect is genuinely conservative. He is genuinely the correct person. Every claim is supportable and every citation is real and the methodology is sound and he has costed it to the pound.

It is simply that the document does not contain the reason.

He submits it in April. The committee meets in June. He is asked two questions, one about equipment insurance and one about whether four months is long enough, and no one asks him the third question, which is the only question, and which he has rehearsed an answer to eleven times while shaving.

The answer he prepared is: *My mother was born there.*

He never has to use it. He is not sure, afterwards, whether he would have.

• • •

Marianne catches him in the corridor outside the departmental office in the last week of term, with a coffee in each hand and her bag falling off her shoulder.

"I hear you got Iceland."

"I got Iceland."

"God, well done. Nobody gets fieldwork any more." She wedges the bag back up with her elbow. "Whereabouts?"

"North coast. Tiny place. Hundred people."

"Lovely." She is already half past him, and then she turns back, pleasantly, in the doorway, holding both coffees, and says: "Isn't your mother Icelandic?"

And Rowan hears himself say, in a tone of warm and complete friendliness:

"She left a long time ago."

Marianne says, "Well, quite," and goes.

He stands in the corridor for a moment.

It is a flawless sentence. He admires it, briefly and coldly, the way one admires a joint in wood. It is true. It answers. It closes. It does not mention that his mother is dead, or that she died eight months ago, or that he has her photograph in his desk drawer twenty feet away, or that he is going to the village she was born in, or that he has a sealed envelope in a biscuit tin at the bottom of a wardrobe with somebody's initials on it. Every one of those facts is relevant. Marianne would have been kind about all of them. She is a kind woman.

She left a long time ago.

He walks back to his room, and sits down, and does not work for twenty minutes.

• • •

He books the flights in the last week of August.

The confirmation comes through while he is standing in his kitchen with the door open on a warm evening — Keflavík, one way, hold luggage, seat 14A, a car reserved from a firm in Reykjavík with a scraped white Dacia in it that he does not know about yet. He reads the email on his phone with a glass of wine in his other hand and the smell of somebody else's barbecue coming over the fence.

Nothing has happened.

That is worth setting down plainly, because of everything that comes after: on this evening, in this kitchen, nothing whatsoever has happened. A woman died of a stroke at seventy-seven in a hospital in Cambridge. Her son emptied her flat, methodically, and found a tin under the bed containing a photograph, an envelope, and some old papers, which is approximately what one finds under beds. He is a linguist and the papers were in Icelandic and the place in the photograph has an under-documented dialect and he applied for a grant and got it. There is no mystery here. There is a bereaved man of fifty-five with a good research question and an airline confirmation, standing in his kitchen in the last of the light.

He finishes the wine and washes the glass and puts it on the rack.

Then he goes upstairs, and opens the wardrobe, and takes out the tin, and does not open it, and puts it into the top of the duffel bag that is already half packed on the spare bed — and then takes it out again, and finds a wool sock, and wraps it, and puts it at the bottom, underneath everything, where a bag would have to be fully emptied to reach it.

He stands looking into the bag for a while.

For the padding, he thinks, in English, in the nominative, and hears the sentence do its work, and goes to bed.

II



The Flybus takes forty-five minutes from Keflavík and Rowan spends all of them looking at moss.

It grows over the lava in a grey-green pelt, unbroken, kilometre after kilometre, and it is the first thing he has seen in eight months that does not require him to have an opinion about it. He rests his temple against the cold glass. Somewhere in the hold, in a duffel he packed four times, is a tin box wrapped in a wool sock. He has not thought about the tin since Heathrow, which is a lie he permits himself the way he permits himself the second whisky on a night flight, knowingly, and with a certain administrative respect for his own dishonesty.

The woman across the aisle is explaining to her husband that the moss takes a century to recover from a boot. She says it in Icelandic. Rowan understands every word, including *að jafna sig*, to right itself, to come back to level, and he feels the small warm click of comprehension that has been the reliable pleasure of his working life. Twenty-two years. He can read a saga at speed, follow a radio panel show, argue about a bill. He has never lived here for longer than a fieldwork season and he has an accent that will not come out, a flatness in the vowels that marks him at the first sentence, and he has made his peace with that. A foreign accent is only a signature. It says where the hand came from. It does not say the hand is unsteady.

He does not know yet that this is the last week of his life in which he will regard his own fluency as an asset.

• • •

The hotel is on Laugavegur above a shop selling puffin keyrings and volcanic-ash soap. The room is small and very clean and smells of lemon and dry heat. He unpacks by his method — laptop, recorder, notebooks, the empty tin — and aligns

each object parallel to the edge of the desk, and stands looking at the result for a moment before he goes down.

The clerk is perhaps twenty-five, with a septum ring and an English paperback face-down on the counter. She takes his passport and types without looking at the keys.

“Business or holiday?”

“Work.” He says it in Icelandic and she answers in Icelandic, which does not always happen, and he notes that it has happened, and is pleased, and notes the pleasure. “Fieldwork. I’m a linguist.”

“Where?”

“North. A village called Brynjavík. Small place, up past—”

“Brynjavík.” She stops typing. It is not a dramatic stop. It is the pause of a person retrieving a word from a shelf they have not visited in a while. “My grandmother grew up there.”

“Really.” He leans on the counter. This is the part of the work he is good at, the part that cannot be taught: the flat friendly opening of a door. “Does she still—”

“She died. Two thousand and nine.” The clerk resumes typing. “She talked about it. The harbour and the boats and the wall they built when she was a girl. She had a whole thing about the wall.”

“Have you been?”

“No.” She slides his passport back.

“It’s a long way,” Rowan offers.

“It’s four hours,” the clerk says, and then frowns very slightly, at the screen, the way a person frowns at a sum that has come out wrong twice. “I go to Akureyri all the time. My boyfriend’s from Dalvík.” She hands him the key card. “I don’t know. We never went. I never thought about it, actually.” She looks up, and her expression is perfectly open and mildly interested, a woman making conversation at the end of a shift. “That’s strange, isn’t it. My own grandmother.”

“People are busy,” Rowan says.

“People are busy,” she agrees, and picks up her paperback, and that is the end of it.

He goes up to the room and writes it down, because he writes everything down.

Hotel clerk, Laugavegur. Grandmother b. Brynjavík, d. 2009. Clerk has never visited despite regular travel to the same region. No stated reason. No apparent avoidance — she raised it herself, unprompted, and was mildly surprised by her own answer.

Cf. standard pattern: descendants of emigrants from declining rural districts routinely do not visit. Nothing remarkable. Filed for completeness.

He looks at what he has written. *Filed for completeness* is what he writes when

he has recorded something for a reason he cannot yet give. There are four hundred such entries in twenty-two years of notebooks, and perhaps nine of them ever came to anything, and the ratio is the discipline.

• • •

The Árni Magnússon Institute occupies a building of pale concrete and enormous windows, and Dr. Ragnheiður Ólafsdóttir occupies an office in it that is warm as a greenhouse and stacked to the ceiling with offprints in three languages. She is in her sixties, broad-shouldered, in a cardigan the colour of oatmeal, and she is so immediately, unguardedly generous that Rowan feels the small shame of a man who came prepared to be charming.

“Sit, sit. Move those.” She waves at a chair holding a decade of *Íslenskt mál*. “You are the Cambridge one. Morphological attrition.” She says the phrase in English, with relish, as though it were the name of a cocktail. “I read the Faroese paper. The one about the dative going soft in the fishing vocabulary.”

“That was ten years ago.”

“It was good. Most of them are not good.” She pours coffee without asking. “So. What are you doing to us?”

He tells her. The north coast, the peninsula, a small parish with an unusually conservative dialect. He does not say *my mother was born there*. He has rehearsed not saying it, and the rehearsal works, and he is aware of the machinery working, and hates it slightly.

“Brynjavík,” Ragnheiður says. She swivels to a shelf, runs a finger along it, does not find what she is looking for, swivels back. “Yes. Interesting little dialect area.”

“Interesting how?”

“Oh — conservative, as you say. Retentions. Some case usage that looks archaic and is probably just isolation, you know how it goes, one family with a strong grandmother and suddenly the whole fjord has a feature.” She sips. “There is a lot of it up there. The whole north-west is a museum of things that should have died in 1890.”

“Have you worked on it?”

“No.”

He waits. She does not elaborate, and there is nothing in her face to elaborate — no shadow, no evasion, only a woman who has answered a question completely.

“Any particular reason?” he asks. “It sounds like exactly your thing.”

“It is exactly my thing.” She says it cheerfully. Then she pauses, and looks past him at the window, at the flat white sky over Vatnsmyri, and for the first time in the conversation she takes slightly too long. “I nearly did. Twice. In — ninety-six, and

again about eight years ago, when we had the mapping money. Both times it came off the list.” She turns her hands over. “The first time I think there was a funding problem. The second time I do not remember. Something else was more urgent. There is always something more urgent.” She smiles. “That is what a career is, Dr. Hale. It is the list of things that came off the list.”

It is a good line. She has clearly used it before. He writes it down because it is charming, and it is only in the car, four days later, that he will take it out and look at it again.

She is helpful for another hour. She gives him three names, two of them dead, and the third a retired schools inspector in Sauðárkrúkur who will not answer his letters. She tells him where the parish records should be and where they will actually be, which are different buildings. She warns him about the road.

“It is not a bad road. It is a road that was built for a bigger place than the one at the end of it.” She writes something on a card. “Read these two before you go. Halldórsdóttir on the coastal case system, and there is a thing by Björnsson in *Íslenskt mál* — volume nineteen, I think, or twenty — comparing four of the northern parishes. Old, but it is the only comparative work anyone has done.”

“Four parishes?”

“Mm. Brynjavík and three others.” She hands him the card. “Hvalsker is one of them, I remember, because I stayed there once as a student and the guesthouse had a cat with no tail.”

• • •

The Halldórsdóttir is exactly where she said it would be.

The Björnsson is not in volume nineteen.

Rowan spends forty minutes on this, which is thirty-five minutes longer than the problem deserves, because the problem is trivial and the solutions are obvious and he works through them all. It is not in nineteen. It is not in twenty. He checks eighteen and twenty-one on the principle that a scholar misremembering a volume number is the most ordinary event in the world, and it is not in those either. He searches the index of the journal for *Björnsson* across the whole run and finds eleven articles by four different Björnssons, none of them comparative, none of them about the north coast. He searches for the four parish names. He searches for *samanburður*, comparison. He finds nothing.

He sits back. The reading room is quiet in the particular way of national libraries, a hush composed of ventilation and the small dry sound of other people’s pages.

The explanation is not mysterious. Ragnheiður is sixty-something and reads three hundred articles a year and was recalling, without notes, a paper she last

looked at two decades ago. She has confused a journal, or an author, or — most likely of all — an article she was told about and never actually read, which is a thing every scholar alive has done and none of them admits. Rowan himself once cited, in print, a monograph that turned out to be a conference abstract. He is not troubled. He is mildly, professionally amused.

He notes it anyway.

Björnsson, comparative study of 4 northern parishes, Íslenskt mál vol. 19 or 20 — not located. Journal run complete on shelf. Author index searched. Not present under any volume.

Almost certainly misremembered attribution (cf. my own Hafnarfjörður citation, 2011, which did not exist either). Will ask R.Ó. by email.

N.B. she named Hvalsker as one of the four and produced a specific sensory memory attached to it (guesthouse, cat, no tail). People do not usually invent cats.

He requests the parish holdings before he leaves, and goes to lunch, and does not think about it again until the following morning.

• • •

The catalogue lists seventeen.

He works through the slips at a desk by the window with the winter light coming flat across the wood. Parish registers, three volumes. Confirmation rolls. A visitation report from 1874. A bound run of district survey annals. A schoolbook. Two manuscript items described only as *blandað efni*, mixed material, which in his experience means either treasure or a churchwarden's laundry accounts. A hymnal. Six arrive.

The young man who brings them is apologetic in the way of someone who has delivered this news many times and has stopped finding it interesting. "Sorry. These four are showing as not-on-shelf — that usually means they went out for conservation and the record didn't get updated. These three are showing a location that doesn't exist any more." He turns the slip around to demonstrate. "See, that's a basement stack we haven't used since the refurbishment. And this one just says *deposited*, which is not a location, that's someone in 1978 not doing their job."

"And the last two?"

"Those ones are the annoying ones." He almost smiles. "They're in the catalogue and there's no accession record. So somebody typed them in off a list at some point — probably off the old card index in the nineties, when everything got keyed in — and either the books never came to us at all, or they came and were never accessioned, or the card was wrong in the first place." He shrugs. "Retroconversion.

You would not believe what is in our catalogue. We have a chair.”

“A chair?”

“A chair. Catalogued, with a shelfmark. Nobody knows.”

Rowan laughs, and means it.

“The district ones are worse, though,” the young man adds, gathering the rejected slips. “Anything that came in through the county offices. There was a burst pipe in eighty-one and a fire in a records store in Blönduós before that, and a lot of it was never listed properly to begin with. Half the north is like this. It’s not just your parish.”

It’s not just your parish. Rowan turns that over for a moment and files it, because it is genuinely reassuring, and because he notices that he needed reassuring, and that is the part worth recording.

Six of seventeen. He works through the six until the light goes. The register is a register. The visitation report of 1874 complains about damp in the vestry and the poor attendance of the fishing families in season and the state of the pastor’s fence, and is so completely, gloriously ordinary that Rowan reads all nine pages of it with something close to affection. The hymnal in the catalogue is not the hymnal; it is a Reykjavík printing of 1902 with nothing in it at all, and he checks page nine out of a habit he does not yet have a reason for, and finds *verði þinn vilji*, standard, correct, unremarkable, and closes it and thinks nothing whatever about it.

• • •

The map shop is on a side street off Bankastræti and smells of paper and electric heat, and Rowan is happy in it in the uncomplicated way he is happy in very few places.

He buys three sheets of the same coast.

The current 1:50,000, which is the one he will drive with. A 1:100,000 tourist sheet, printed the year before last, of the sort sold in petrol stations. And, from a box at the back, a 1987 survey sheet, foxed at the folds, which he buys for eight hundred krónur because he has never in his life left a shop containing an old map of a place he is going to.

He spreads all three on the hotel bed that evening.

The 1:50,000 gives the population as 113. The tourist sheet gives 96. The 1987 sheet gives 41.

He sits down on the edge of the bed.

Then he gets up and makes tea in the little plastic kettle and comes back and looks at them properly, because the first reading of anything is worthless.

The 1987 figure is thirty-eight years old and is presumably a census figure from a census taken before he finished school. The tourist sheet is derivative and lazy

and probably lifts its numbers from whatever database was cheapest. The 1:50,000 is the survey and is presumably right. Three sources, three vintages, three numbers — and the numbers do not decline. That is the only genuinely odd thing, and he sits with it, and works it out in under a minute: 41 in 1987 and 113 now would mean the village nearly tripled, which does not happen to Icelandic fishing villages, but 41 in 1987 could easily be a misprint for 141, or a figure for the settlement proper against 113 for the whole parish including the outlying farms, or — most probably — the 1987 sheet is simply using a different unit than he assumes. Rural population figures are a swamp. He has published on a related swamp.

He photographs the three sheets side by side anyway.

The roads take longer.

On the 1:50,000 the connector road from the pass to the village is drawn as a solid single-lane track, class F, with a spot height and a bridge symbol. On the tourist sheet it is dashed — unsurfaced, seasonal, the convention for a road that may not be passable. On the 1987 sheet it is not drawn at all. The village sits at the end of nothing, reachable in the cartography only by the coastal track from the east, which the 1:50,000 shows as long abandoned.

He looks at this for a while.

Roads are built. Roads are downgraded. A road that did not exist in 1987 and exists now is a road that was built between 1987 and now, which is not a mystery, it is a public works project. He is being asked to be unsettled by infrastructure.

Three sheets, same coast.

Pop.: 113 (1:50k, current) / 96 (tourist, 2024) / 41 (survey, 1987). Non-monotonic. Probable unit mismatch (settlement vs. parish) or transcription error in the 1987 figure.

Connector rd.: solid class F (current) / dashed seasonal (tourist) / absent (1987). Consistent with construction post-1987.

~~*Check date of road construction — district records, Sauðárkrókur.*~~

Have checked. There is no road construction recorded for that district between 1970 and 2003. The budget lines are complete and itemised for every year and there is nothing in them but resurfacing.

Which means either the road existed in 1987 and the surveyors left it off the sheet, or it was built without an entry.

The first of these is ordinary. Sheets have errors. Every sheet has errors. I have found errors on sheets myself, twice, and reported them, and received a polite letter.

He reads that last paragraph back and recognises, dimly, the sound of a man reassuring himself in writing, and does not know what to do about it, so he underlines nothing and closes the book.

• • •

The parish office of the national church is on the fourth floor of a building with a lift that announces each floor in a woman's recorded voice, and the woman who receives him is called Gerður and has been doing this job, she tells him, since before the computers.

She is delighted to be asked. Nobody asks.

"Brynjavík, Brynjavík." She types. "Yes. Active parish. Resident incumbent — séra Hjálmar Pétursson, installed two thousand and six. Before him séra Guðrún Ingimarsdóttir, and before her — " she scrolls, "— oh, this goes back a long way. Do you want it all?"

"How far back does it go?"

"Seventeen thirty-two." She says it without any particular reverence. "That is when the returns start. Some parishes are older but the paperwork is not."

"And it's continuous?"

"It is continuous." She turns the monitor slightly so he can see, which she is probably not supposed to do. Column after column of years and names, unbroken, three centuries of a small parish sending its numbers to the capital. "That is unusual, actually. Most of them have gaps — the wars, the eruptions, the influenza, somebody's grandmother dying and the box going in the attic. This one has no gaps."

"None at all?"

"None at all." She scrolls to the bottom. "And they are always on time. Look — the returns are due the fifteenth of January. Every year they arrive in the first week. Every year." She laughs, a short fond laugh. "I have parishes in this city that I chase for four months. And then there is Brynjavík, one hundred and thirteen people at the end of a road, and every January the first week, like a clock."

She says *one hundred and thirteen* and Rowan feels the number land against the three maps on his hotel bed, and says nothing, and thanks her.

At the lift he stops.

"Sorry — one more. Are there any records of services not being held? Cancellations?"

"Oh, they log those." Gerður brightens; this is clearly a good question. "The parishes are meant to record any Sunday without a service, with the reason. Most of them do not bother any more." She crosses to the terminal again and taps. "Brynjavík. Three."

"Three this decade?"

"Three since seventeen thirty-two." She turns and looks at him over her glasses with the pleasure of a specialist producing her best exhibit. "With the reasons written out — a blizzard, a funeral in another parish, and one in 1918 that just says *illness*, which will have been the influenza and which I find rather awful in

three letters.” She sits back. “Do you know how strange that is? I have been here thirty-one years and I have never seen a parish that logged three.”

He rides down four floors in a lift that names each one, and stands on the street in the blue afternoon dark, and finds that he is smiling.

Because it is a good detail. It is the kind of detail that makes a funding body sit up: an isolated community with an extraordinarily strong institutional continuity, a parish that has not missed a return in two hundred and ninety-three years. It is culture. It is *conservatism*, in the technical sense, exactly what he flew here to find, and the fact that a village of a hundred and thirteen people maintains its paperwork with more rigour than a parish in central Reykjavík is not sinister, it is the whole thesis, it is a community that has decided, over centuries, that certain records must be kept.

He walks back to Laugavegur through the wet light and buys a coffee he does not want and thinks: they are careful people. It will be a good site.

That is the last afternoon of his life in which *careful* means what he currently thinks it means.

• • •

The rental is a white Dacia with eleven thousand kilometres on it and a scraped wing the desk agent photographs from four angles.

He loads it in the dark of eight in the morning: the duffel, the equipment case, the box of photocopies, and, on the passenger seat where he can reach it, the 1:50,000 sheet with the route pencilled in and the warnings marked — false turnouts, a slide zone, a bridge replaced by a culvert. The tin goes at the bottom of the duffel, wrapped in a wool sock, because he cannot make himself carry it any other way.

He sits for a moment with his hands on the wheel and the engine running and the heater roaring at the windscreen.

Six documents of seventeen. A road that appears on one sheet and not another. An article that does not exist in the volume where a good scholar remembered it. Three population figures that do not resolve. A woman who has never visited her grandmother’s village and cannot say why. A parish that has not missed a Sunday in three hundred years.

Six things. He has been on eleven fieldwork sites and there is not one of them that would not yield six such things in four days — the archives of small places are made of this, of pipes bursting and clerks retiring and boxes going into attics, and a researcher who cannot look at institutional noise without hearing a signal in it is not a researcher, he is a man with a hobby. Every one of the six has an explanation. He has produced the explanations himself, unprompted, without strain. That is the job. That is precisely the job.

He pulls out into the Reykjavík traffic and joins Route One heading north, and the city gives way to suburb and the suburb to lava, and by the time he clears Borgarnes the light has come up grey over water on his left, and he is thinking about nothing much at all.

It is only somewhere past Blönduós, four hours later, on an empty straight with the mountains going blue on his right, that he hears himself, in the privacy of the car, say aloud, in Icelandic, without having decided to:

“Sex hlutir.”

Six things.

And then, because it is a habit older than his career, because he has been declining nouns in his head since he was nine years old in a house where a woman would not tell him where she was from, he declines it. Out loud. To the wind-screen. Nominative, accusative, dative, genitive. *Sex hlutir, sex hluti, sex hlutum, sex hluta.*

The last one sits oddly in his mouth. *Of six things.* Possessive. As though the six things owned something.

He turns the radio on, and it plays a pop song about the summer, and he drives north into the shortening afternoon.

III



He feels the Icelandic wind before it strikes. On the final hairpin above Brynjavík a gale broadsides the rental, lifting the left wheels, dropping them back with a jolt that travels up through his spine. Rowan grips the wheel and counts the gusts: one, two, three, four. Here they never come in pairs. He read that once, in a footnote, and filed it under local lore, and now, on the road, it feels less like folklore than like a rule someone forgot to explain.

The single lane curls along a razor's edge, salt-pitted guardrail to one side, black-rock void to the other. He hugs the rail, though instinct tells him the rail is not the danger. The danger is the place itself, too exposed, too willing.

On the passenger seat lies his 1:50,000 survey map, his thumb tracing the penciled warnings: false turnouts, slides, a collapsed bridge patched by a culvert. At kilometer forty-seven the village should appear. The odometer ticks over, 46.7, 47.0, and a fluorescent stake flashes past. He brakes onto gravel, reverses, inches forward, studies it. Too sharp. Too new. Planted eight hundred meters early. Not drift, not a surveyor's rounding. He photographs the stake, the boot-prints in the mud beside it, the flat horizon, and drives on at a crawl.

Fog rolls in like something with intent. Thirty meters of visibility, then twelve, then nothing. Another stake surfaces, then another, spaced without agreement, as if the men who set them had been quarrelling about where the road belonged. Rowan thinks: the road is only here when the ground consents to it. The thought arrives whole and unwelcome, and he sets it down where he sets down all such thoughts, in the margin, unsigned.

His GPS flickers and pins the village half a kilometer out to sea. The blue dot hops inland, hunts, gives up. He closes the app and proceeds by memory, which is the only instrument he has ever fully trusted.

A thinning of fog. A huddle of low roofs, ink-black against a grey that is not quite sky. A weather-worn sign: *Brynjavík*, and beneath it a column of figures

rather than a figure, the earlier numbers struck through and the newer ones painted smaller each time, as though the sign itself were being economical with what remained. 604. 412. 237. 158. And at the bottom, in a hand that has given up on the pretence of permanence, 113. A hundred and fifty years of subtraction, kept on a board at the roadside the way a farmer keeps a tally of lambs. He photographs it, and thinks that no other village he has worked in has bothered to show its arithmetic. Most repaint. This one strikes through and lets you count.

He parks beneath the single lit window of the community hall and kills the engine. The silence is immediate. Only the wind humming in the power lines, and under it, further down, the sound the sea makes when it is not doing anything in particular.

Outside, the houses press close, eaves almost touching. The alleys barely admit a body. The basalt cliffs stand at the back of the village like a spine, and though the geology is young, the rock feels inevitable, a thing the place has decided to lean against. He photographs the sign, the buildings, the cliffs, then compares them against the Street View he downloaded a month ago in a bright room in Cambridge. A blue house that stood thirty meters back now abuts the pavement. A playground has become gravel and a sodden bench. He paces thirteen strides from curb to stoop and writes *spatial compression* in his field book, his thumb smudging the wet ink. He shivers, and does not decide whether it is cold or arithmetic.

He checks his duffel out of habit, cataloguing: tape recorder, notepads, and, at the bottom, wrapped in a wool sock because he could not make himself carry it any other way, a small tin box. Inside the box, a sealed envelope. On its face, in his mother's hand, four characters and a full stop: *for E.B. only*.

He does not take the box out. He knows the weight of it without lifting it.

Elizabeth Hale had been reticent to the point of architecture; a woman built of what she declined to say. When he was a boy he had asked once, twice, about *before Cambridge*, about her own parents, and each time she had answered him in a way that was not an answer, a smooth grey surface that gave the question nothing to grip. He had learned, without deciding to, to read the shapes of her silences the way other children learned to read faces. He had built, over thirty years, a set of tools precise enough to translate a woman who would not be translated. He calls this his vocation. He has never once called it what it is.

He still does not know who E.B. is. He knows that his mother wrote to her once and did not send it. He knows there are forty scraps of paper under the envelope carrying a paradigm with three more columns than the language has, and a torn edge where the last of them should be. He knows he has driven eleven hundred kilometres without once permitting himself to finish the sentence that begins *a person only drills a paradigm that far if*.

He puts the duffel down. He reads the email printout: *Arrival any time after 17:00. Please come directly to office. — Thorsteinn*. He climbs the hall steps,

photographs the door, and knocks, once with his knuckles, once with his palm.

• • •

Inside, a man in navy, close-shaven, watching him. “You’re early. Good. We’ve already lost an hour to the wind.”

The office smells of cleaning solution and wet wool. Rowan signs the visitor log — *Dr. R. Hale, Univ. of Cambridge, 17:34* — while Thorsteinn watches the pen. The wall behind the desk carries maps in overlay, layer on layer of coastline, shorelines shifting inward year by year, boundaries redrawn in a hand that grows less confident with each revision.

“Subsidence,” Thorsteinn says, when Rowan asks. “Erosion. Other things.” He slides a heavy key across the desk. The tag reads a six-digit code. “Guest house first. No television. The wireless reaches, some days. Breakfast at eight. The café is simple.”

Rowan takes the key. “I’d like to speak with Edda Brynjarsdóttir.”

Thorsteinn’s fingers pause on the blotter. It is a small stall, the kind Rowan has spent his life learning to see. “She knows the stories,” Thorsteinn says. “She will not always answer. If you go, bring a gift. Salt. Matches. Good tea.” He aligns a stack of forms that are already aligned. “And you will not ask her about the water by its name. Not the sea. Not the bay. Not any word that points straight at it. Here we do not do that.”

“How do you refer to it, then?”

“We don’t refer to it.” Thorsteinn says it flatly, as a man states an occupational hazard. “We work around it. You will learn the shape of the hole by the things placed at its edges.” He stands, which is the end of the interview. At the threshold he adds, without turning: “The north edge is harder ground. Do not walk it alone.” Outside, the wind takes Rowan by the collar like a hand checking a coat for a name tag.

• • •

On the quay, four figures bend over green netting, oilskin and wool layered like strata in a cliff face. The oldest has hands that look carved by water. Beside him a woman works the twine without looking at it. And a young one, no more than twenty, smoking, his fair hair whipping loose from under a cap. Rowan waits for the rhythm of the mending, net-shuttle and pull, before he steps into it.

“Góðan dag,” he tries.

The woman nods. The old man grunts. Rowan gives his name, his purpose. “Dr. Hale. Cambridge. Here to document the dialect.”

“Second time you’ve passed,” the old man says. “Nothing much to see.”

“You can take the photographs,” the woman adds. “The colours flatten.”

The young one, the smoker, watches Rowan with more openness than the others, the way the young in a closed place watch anyone who has been elsewhere. “Everything moves here,” he says. “Boats, quotas. The village breathes. Some years the space opens. Some years it squeezes.”

“That’s Bjarni,” the old man says, in the tone of a man apologizing for weather. “He talks.”

Rowan writes *subjective spatial variation* and, beside it, the name. Bjarni.

“How do you refer to the water?” Rowan asks.

The twine twitches and stops. Finally the old man says, “We call it the west.”

“Or the fog,” the woman says.

“Or the deep,” Bjarni ventures, and grins, testing it, a boy leaning over a rail.

“The bay?” Rowan offers.

They laugh, but it is not quite laughter. “You’re not one of us,” Bjarni says. “So you can say it. It slides off you.” He says it almost with envy.

“You name what wants naming,” the old man says. “You leave the rest.” He spits into the gap between the stones. “It’s not law. It’s how it’s done.”

Rowan raises his recorder, and they give him the safe words the way one hands over ballast: *the edge, the salt, the slip. That way brings the weather, not the fish.* He notes *avoidant referents, formal weight*, and, when he plays the file back that evening, he will find a smooth blank where a certain word should sit. Not a glitch. A held breath. Later he will recognize the quality of that silence, though he does not know it yet. It is the exact texture of every answer his mother ever gave him about her own childhood: a place in the sentence where the floor had been carefully removed.

Bjarni nods toward the northmost house on the ridge. “Talk to Edda. She keeps the old grammar.” He flicks his cigarette into the water and watches where it lands, longer than a man watches a cigarette.

• • •

Her house is the last before the stone wall. The door is newer than the walls around it, the paint unweathered. He knocks once, then again, shifting the emphasis, and the door opens to a measured width.

Edda Brynjarsdóttir is smaller than the village made her sound and denser, as if she has been compressed by the same pressure that shortened the road. Her sweater is undyed wool the grey of granite. Her eyes take his measure, the package, the stance, and settle.

“Dr. Hale.” Not a question. An entry in a ledger she has been keeping a long time.

He states his name, his purpose, the gift. She accepts the tea and the salt without a tremor. She looks past him toward the water, then back. “Best to say little this early,” she says. “The weather’s undecided.” Not a warning. A note on procedure.

Inside: wool and ash and dried herbs, shelves loaded in careful balance, no mirrors. She sits and gestures him to the chair opposite. The window behind her is set at an angle that shows nothing continuous, a fragment of basalt, a slice of bay, the view deliberately broken.

He sets the recorder between them and does not switch it on. Instead he takes the tin from his bag, opens it, and slides the envelope across the table. *for E.B. only*, in his mother’s hand.

Edda reads the name. She does not react. Not a flicker, not a breath out of rhythm. She lets it lie there on the wood between the salt and the tea, and does not touch it, and does not open it. He watches her not-react with a scholar’s attention and finds, at the bottom of his attention, something older and colder, the child at the closed door, listening. He puts the child back in the margin.

He asks his prepared questions. Weather. Childhood. The shifting edge of the village. She answers in phrases that compress more than they release. “Years tighten. Some widen. My mother spoke of a winter when the distance doubled, and one when the houses pressed so close you could not lose a child in the street.”

He asks about language. “Words get thin at the edge,” she says. “The endings don’t always hold. Sometimes there’s enough. Sometimes it is nothing.” She gives him three examples, the same stem, only the ending altered, her vowels lengthening on the final syllable as if to make the sound carry a weight.

He asks, obliquely, about the word no one uses. She does not answer. Her hand closes around the tea, the knuckles whitening, and that is the answer, and he marks it.

He thanks her. She does not acknowledge the thanks; she rises to tend the stove. The interview is over. Procedure, not dismissal. As he gathers his things his eyes go, once, to the envelope, still sealed, still lying where he left it. She has not moved it toward herself. She has not moved it away.

“You’ll leave that,” she says. Not a question either.

He leaves it.

• • •

The guest house smells of salt and the dry tick of the baseboard heater. He unpacks, aligning each object parallel to the desk edge — laptop, recorder, notebooks, the empty tin. The window overlooks water that merges with sky. He transcribes: *Village compressed. Road inconsistent. Dialect avoids forbidden referent.* He types, then backspaces, every instance of *ocean* and *waterway*, settling

on *the edge, the outer margin*. He does not decide to do this. He notices he has done it.

Fog gathers against the glass and draws thin lines that bisect the view, dew beading and running in ways he does not quite watch. It is nothing yet. It is a page not yet written on. He lies down with the recorder running, and the last thing he registers before sleep is that the tide has a cadence, long troughs and clustered peaks, and that it sounds, if he lets it, like a room in which someone is choosing not to speak. He has slept in that room his whole life. He does not think to write the forbidden word. He would not have known which one it was.

IV



Thorsteinn provides the key at 08:00. The prefab was a holding pen, he explains, suitable for transients; for a scholar meaning to stay the month, the Annex is required. It stands further up the slope, grounded in the volcanic scree, its roof a heavy brow of sod turning brown in the salt air.

Rowan carries his equipment in two trips. He counts one hundred and twelve steps from the road to the threshold. The interior smells of linseed oil and dry timber, a single room partitioned by use rather than by walls: a sleeping alcove to the east, a workspace facing west. The furniture is heavy, built of driftwood and bolted to the floor. He tests the desk. It does not wobble.

He begins the setup, because method is a form of defence. He aligns the recorder parallel to the window frame, three centimeters from the edge. He stacks the notebooks by date of anticipated use. He builds a small grid of order inside the cottage's stubborn geography.

The light changes, bars of cold illumination falling across the floorboards, and he sees the wear pattern in the pine, a trough worn from desk to window and another from stove to door. Not general traffic. A loop. A patrol. He runs his hand along the desk edge and finds the wood scarred, and leans closer, and the scars resolve into cuts. Not scratches. Inscriptions.

He fetches his loupe. The markings are shallow, made with a blade that was probably dull, and he recognizes their shapes at once, though their presence here makes no sense he can hold.

-um. The dative plural ending.

He moves to the window frame, where a hand would rest, and finds another cluster carved into the sill. *-ar*. Genitive singular. The bedframe: *-in*, the suffixed article. There are no stems anywhere. The room is littered with grammatical tails, suffixes cut loose from their nouns, waiting for a subject to fasten to. He photographs each instance and labels the files by coordinate. He circles the room,

cataloguing. The carvings are not vandalism; they are corrections. They cluster over knots in the wood, at joints where the carpentry failed, as if a former occupant had tried to conjugate the room itself, to force the crooked timber into a declension it could not hold.

He writes in his journal: *Structure contains extensive marginalia. Morphology appears reactive. Prior occupants strictly codified space.* Then he sits, and the window frames the grey and the boundary where the village meets the tide, and he does not name the water. He notes only that the horizon is active.

• • •

A knock, single and dull. A woman on the slate step, in a coat of boiled wool dyed the colour of wet peat, her hair pulled back from a face that looks etched by the same blunt blade that marked the table.

“Dr. Hale. I am Sigrún Ásgeirsdóttir.”

She wipes her boots on the mat, three strokes, left, right, left, before she will step onto the floor. She sets a canvas satchel on the table, avoiding the carved edge. “Thorsteinn said you required histories. The parish annals. Nineteen hundred to nineteen forty-five. After that the records become sparse.”

She unbuckles the satchel and lifts out the black-bound volumes one at a time, squaring each to the one beneath it. Last, she sets down a small book bound in cracked calf, and hesitates over it half a second longer than she hesitated over the others.

“Séra Hjálmar sends this. He says you will want the hymnal as well as the register, since you are here for the speech and not the sheep.” A pause. “He also says he is at the parsonage most mornings and that you are not to knock before nine.”

“Hjálmar Pétursson,” Rowan says. “Installed two thousand and six.”

Sigrún’s hands go still on the satchel buckle for about a second.

“You have been to the parish office.”

“I went to a great many offices.” He hears how it sounds and does not soften it, because he has learned in three days here that softening is read as concealment. “They were very helpful. They were pleased that somebody asked.”

“They would be.” She resumes with the buckle. “There has been a resident pastor in Brynjavík since 1732. There has been a service every Sunday of that time except three, and the three are recorded, with the reasons.” She sets her hand briefly on the calf-bound book, and takes it away again. “He is a good man. He will talk to you longer than anyone else here will. Do not mistake that for the same thing as telling you more.”

“Thank you. I can make tea. I have the brand Thorsteinn suggested.”

“No tea.” She keeps her coat on. She stands near the center of the room, hands clasped, reading the space, or the density of the air in it.

“I’ve been reviewing the samples from the quay,” Rowan says, organizing her stack. “There’s a variance in how the locals address the geography.” He turns to the window and gestures at the horizon, at the iron-grey line where sky meets surface. In fluent Icelandic he says, “It’s fascinating. The way the ocean dominates the perspective, yet the vocabulary minimizes it.”

Sigrún’s head snaps up. “We do not use that construction.”

He pauses. “The vocabulary?”

“The subject.” Her voice goes flat, administrative. “You placed the agent in the water. We do not say *the ocean dominates*. We say the view is filled.”

He files it: *passive required; agent removal*. “A grammatical avoidance of agency. So if I were to describe the state of the waves—”

“Currents.”

“If I were to say the waves are rising—”

The light in the room dies.

It is not a cloud. It is an erasure. Fog hits the window with the force of a solid body, the glass white and blind in an instant, the wind that had been a constant thrum cut clean out. The silence is a seal applied to the cottage. Rowan looks at the window, then the lamp, which flickers once and steadies. His watch’s second hand still sweeps. The room feels held.

Sigrún has not moved. She does not look at the window. She is looking at his hands, and adjusting her cuff.

“The forms must be precise,” she says, her tone exactly what it was, as though the blindness of the room were a small clerical thing he has caused and must correct. “This close to the glass, Dr. Hale, you do not give action to the outside. The outside is a location. It does not act.”

The white thins to grey wisps. The wind bleeds back, treble first, then the low thud of the turf roof.

“I understand,” Rowan says, level, though his pulse has spiked and he notes the spike the way he notes everything, at a distance, as data. *Grammatical breach followed immediately by environmental obscuration.*

Sigrún nods. The lesson is not moral; it is structural. “The annals are in order. Do not read them past sunset in poor light; it strains the eyes. And the carvings.” She is at the door now, not looking back. “Do not let your fingers trace them too long. They are unfinished for a reason.” The latch, and she is gone, and the window is clear again, framing the thing it is forbidden to name.

• • •

The annals are bound in black cloth, spines blank. *District Survey, 1912*. The

paper is brittle and smells of acid and time. Crop yields, sheep counts, an influenza outbreak in November, and then the fishing reports, in which the catch is meticulously recorded — cod, haddock, weights, prices — but the source of the fish is never named. The sentences bend into the passive or stagger under heavy circumlocutions. *The nets were drawn from the grey expanse. The boats returned from the lower meridian. The yield from the westward open was substantial.*

A map folded into the back cover renders Brynjavík in fanatical ink detail, every fence line, every pen. But to the west, where the shore ends, the mapmaker simply stopped. No waves, no soundings, no depth. A blank cream void, labelled with a single coordinate: *64°N — Undesignated.*

He logs it. *Cartographic erasure. Linguistic containment.* And, because the phrase belongs to a colder discipline than the one he means to practice here, he underlines it and does not know why.

He sets the annals aside and takes up the hymnal, expecting nothing from it. Icelandic Lutheran hymnals are among the most standardized documents in Europe; the text has been fixed by synod and reprinted without meaningful variation since the nineteenth century, and he opens it the way a man opens a phone directory in a hotel room, to be doing something.

He finds the Lord's Prayer on page nine and reads it without attention, and stops in the third line.

Faðir vor, þú sem ert á himnum. Helgist þitt nafn, til komi þitt ríki, verði að þínum vilja, svo á jörðu sem á himni.

He reads it again. Then he reads it aloud, quietly, to hear whether his eye is lying to him.

Verði að þínum vilja. Dative. *Let it be done according to thy will.*

Every hymnal in Iceland reads *verði þinn vilji*. Nominative. The will is the subject. The will is the thing that does. It is one of the oldest and most stable lines in the language — it survived the Reformation, it survived Guðbrandur's Bible, it survived four centuries of orthographic reform — and here, in a parish hymnal printed, he checks the plate, in Akureyri in 1928, the divine will has been quietly moved out of the nominative and set into an oblique case, where it can be measured against but cannot act.

Hymnal, Brynjavík parish, Akureyri impression 1928. Pater Noster, l. 3. Standard text verði þinn vilji (nom.) replaced by verði að þínum vilja (dat., governed by að). Not a misprint — the setting is clean, the line is centred, the spacing is correct for the longer reading. A misprint costs a letter. This cost a plate.

Provincial variant? Check Akureyri press for house readings.

Hyper-corrective? Rural registers overuse að + dat.

Neither. Both those hypotheses predict variation elsewhere in the text.

There is none. The rest of the prayer is standard to the comma. One case, changed once, deliberately, in the only line of the prayer in which something other than the speaker is permitted to want.

He closes the hymnal and does not move for a while. He is a morphologist; he has spent twenty years being pleased by things exactly this size. He waits for the pleasure and it does not come. What comes instead is the first cold suspicion that he has been handed a document by a woman who wiped her boots three times before she would step on the floor, and that she knew what page he would stop on.

The hours compress. The light fails, first to the long northern twilight and then to dark, and he switches on the lamp, and his eyes drift to the beam above the desk where *-um* catches the light. Back to the book. Page forty-two, a sentence that ends without ending: *The storm took the boat and its crew to the—* No object. No full stop. He looks at the beam. *-um*. The dative plural. *To the [dative plural]*. The occupants did not carve these marks to damage the wood. They were storing the endings they were forbidden to speak. Offloading the grammar into the timber, the way a man buries what he cannot keep in the house and cannot throw away.

He stops at the window.

The exterior dark is total. The glass returns the room to him — desk, lamp, his own pale face — and then something else begins to form on the surface. Condensation. The room is dry; the heater cycles evenly; yet the moisture gathers, and it does not run in streaks. It clusters. He steps closer and adjusts his glasses.

The water is writing.

A curve. A vertical stroke. A crossbar. The droplets hold against gravity and shape a character. *P*. Thorn. Beside it, another cluster. *u*. Then *ng*.

Pung. Heavy. Or pregnant. Or difficult.

He does not gasp. He observes the surface tension holding the beads in place where surface tension should not, and files the improbability, and lifts his hand. The heat of his palm should break the formation, should merge and run the droplets. He brings his index finger to hover over the character.

The pane vibrates. A low frequency, barely audible, a cello string bowed too slowly, travelling the air gap into his skin. Patterned. Short, long, short. He presses his fingertip to the *P*.

The droplets do not smear. They set. The vibration spikes, a sharp closed-circuit buzz, and beneath his finger the character dissolves and reforms. *S*. Then *j*. Then *ó*. He pulls his hand back. The vibration stops. The condensation loses cohesion and weeps down the glass in ordinary chaotic rivulets, and the word it was becoming is gone before he can decide whether he wanted it to finish.

He stands in the center of the room. The lamp hums. The books lie open to their amputated sentences. His finger is wet. He is not afraid, he tells himself, and hears, distinctly, how the sentence is built to hold something at arm's length, and

recognizes the construction, because it is his mother's, because it is his. *He is not afraid.* Agent removed from the water. The fear placed nowhere, so that it cannot act.

He revises his earlier hypothesis. The cottage is not a blank page. It is a prompt. He sits and picks up his pen and does not write a conclusion. He writes a question. *System active. Interaction confirms syntax is physical. What is the required case for entry?*

Outside, the wind taps against the wall. One. Two. Three. Four. Rowan waits. The lesson is beginning, and some part of him he will not look at directly is not surprised to find that he has been enrolled a long time.

V



Rowan takes the path to the north ridge, his boots finding purchase on slate that feels brittle, as if the salt air has over-cured the very geology. The wind here does not buffet; it presses, a laminar flow that lies the grass flat against the soil. He carries his field bag — canvas, waterproofed, holding the recorder, a stack of legal pads, three pens tested for ink flow.

On the quay below, small in the fog, Bjarni is coiling line. He lifts a hand when Rowan passes — the only villager who has yet greeted him unprompted — and Rowan lifts one back, and files the fact that the young man watches the water while he coils, the way a person watches a dog he half trusts.

Edda's cottage sits low in the scree, a huddle of turf and basalt that seems less built than extruded. The door is painted a red so deep it reads as black in the twilight. He checks his watch, 14:00 exactly, and knocks, and the door opens before his knuckles can graze the wood a second time.

She is in the same undyed wool she wore on the first day, and Rowan suspects it is not the same garment but the only kind she owns. Her hands, resting on the frame, are roped with veins that suggest high pressure held a long time. "Dr. Hale," she says. It is a verification of inventory.

"Ms. Brynjarsdóttir. Thank you for agreeing to speak again." He offers the smile he perfected in Cambridge common rooms — disarming, deferential, slightly worn.

She steps back, letting a wedge of light spill onto the stones. "The weather holds. Come in before the pressure drops."

Inside, the air is dry and smells of burnt peat and something sharper, ozone or metal filings. The room is a masterclass in compression. Shelves on every vertical surface, jars, folded linen, tools whose purposes have eroded from memory. A single paraffin lamp burns on the central table, its flame motionless in its glass chimney. The envelope is nowhere in sight. He does not ask. She gestures him to

a chair of heavy timber, back straight.

He begins his ritual — unzip the bag, remove the recorder, check the battery, align the device equidistant between them, notebook to the right, pen uncapped. He feels the familiar hum of academic extraction. He is here to document, to classify, to save. It is a story he tells himself about why men like him go to the ends of coasts, and he has told it so often it has the smoothness of truth.

“I appreciate your time,” he says, and his voice sounds too round in the damped acoustics. “Thorsteinn says you’re the custodian of the older forms.”

“Thorsteinn manages the maps.” Her vowels are drawn out, stretched like wire. “I manage the speech.”

His eye catches the ceiling beams above her, old drift-timber dark with smoke. Carvings, like the Annex, but denser. The wood is not scarred; it is annotated. He recognizes the declension markers — *-um*, *-ar*, *-i* — and, crowded into the grain like refugees seeking high ground, stems he does not know.

“You’ve marked the beams,” he says, pointing with his pen. “Mnemonic aids?”

“Structural reinforcement.” She does not look up.

He notes it — *informant views grammar as architectural* — and presses record. “Let’s begin with the fishing terminology. The specialized lexicon for the tools, the nets, the hooks. How has the vocabulary shifted since the herring collapse?”

She folds her hands and waits two beats. “The collapse was not of herring. It was of counting.” Her voice lacks the melodic rise and fall of standard Icelandic; it is flat, rhythmic, engineered, built in blocks of sound. “When the nets went down, we pulled up weight. But the weight had no name. To name a thing is to fasten it. We had no fasteners for what came up.”

He writes quickly. *Lexical gaps*. “So you borrowed terms? Coined new ones?”

“We widened the old ones. We stretched the vowels to hold more water.” She demonstrates — the word for net, but the vowel stays in her throat and resonates, turning the monosyllable into a four-second hum that he feels behind his sternum.

He looks past her to the window on his left. The glass is clear. He half expects it to cloud, the way the Annex glass clouded, and is aware of expecting it, and disciplines the expectation away. Instead his eye goes to the floor near the hearth, where a low draught has worked the peat-ash into fine spirals, tight and repeating, the same loop over and over, as if the room exhales in a hand he is beginning to be able to read.

“Fascinating,” he says, confident again on the ground of description. “Phonological lengthening as a marker for mass. Applied to all nouns, or only those tied to extraction?”

“Only those that touch the boundary.” She watches the digital counter turn. “You are recording the sound. The sound is only the casing.”

“We can keep to morphology, if you prefer.” A slight irritation. He wants data, not metaphysics. But the data is coming, wrapped in the metaphysics, and he is not

yet willing to admit it comes no other way. “How do you distinguish the shallow catch from the deep?”

“Depth is not a distance.” She leans forward, and the lamp flame stretches upward though there is no draught. “It is a case. We use the dative for the bottom. We use the genitive for the surface.” She pauses. “Because the surface belongs to the wind. And what belongs to a thing is genitive. But the bottom is not owned. The bottom is *given to*. So it takes the dative. You see — it is not arbitrary. It is only consistent.”

He writes it, and against his training the consistency snags at him, because it is consistent, because the rule reaches down and holds its own logic the way a keystone holds a span. *Spatial relations mapped to case. Vertical axis: genitive surface, dative floor. System internally coherent.*

He turns to a clean page and rules it, because a thing this shaped wants a grid, and because ruling a grid is what he does with his hands when his mind has begun to move faster than he is comfortable with.

	SURFACE	COLUMN	FLOOR
case	genitive	—	dative
sense	<i>of</i>	—	<i>given to</i>
holder	the wind	—	unowned
attested	yes	—	yes

He looks at the middle column for a while.

An empty cell in a paradigm is not a mystery; it is the most ordinary thing in comparative morphology. Paradigms have gaps. English has no past participle for *stride* that anybody will commit to. What makes him sit back, tapping the pen against his thumb, is that this gap is not a defect. The other two columns are built around it. The system does not fail to describe the middle. It declines to.

Vertical axis, prelim. Two attested terms, one prohibited.

~~*Gap = attrition. Middle term lost, remaining terms reanalysed.*~~ — Against: attrition leaves debris. Lost forms leave doublets, hypercorrection, disputed usage among elderly speakers. There is none here. Informant produced the two attested cases without hesitation and refused the third without hesitation. That is not a hole in a system. That is a system with a designed hole.

Note also: she did not say we do not have a word. She said we do not speak of the middle. Absence of vocabulary vs. prohibition of use. Different phenomena. Different diagnoses.

“And the middle?” he asks. “The water column itself?”

Her eyes snap to his. “We do not speak of the middle. The middle is transit. Transit requires silence.”

He smiles, a reflex of intellectual satisfaction, and files it — *taboo keyed to verticality* — and does not notice that the ash-spirals on the floor have stopped turning in a circle and begun to draw, very slowly, the same open shape twice, side by side, like a pair of parted lips.

• • •

At half past three she stands up and puts a pan on the stove without asking him anything, and Rowan understands that he is being fed and that declining is not among the available moves.

It is fish stew, and it is very good, and it is served in bowls that do not match. There is rye bread from a tin and butter with too much salt in it. She eats quickly, the way people eat who have spent their lives around work, and does not talk while she does it, and the silence in the room is different from the silence of the interview — looser, less load-bearing, the ordinary quiet of two people at a table.

Afterwards she pours coffee and sits back and says, unprompted:

“You want the stories.”

“I want whatever you’ll give me.”

“Everyone wants the stories.” She turns her cup. “The collectors came in nineteen sixty-five and they wanted the stories. They came again in seventy-one. My mother gave them the hidden people for two afternoons and they went away very pleased.”

“And were they true? The hidden people?”

Edda considers this longer than he expects.

“The country has the stories,” she says. “All of it. Every farm from here to Höfn will tell you not to move that rock because of who lives in it, and they will tell it to you with a straight face and half of them half mean it, and it is a fine thing and I would not take it from anybody.” She sets the cup down. “But ask them why. Ask a man in Selfoss why you do not move the rock and he will say it is bad luck, or his grandmother said so, or that a bulldozer broke once at Kópavogur. He has the instruction and he has lost the reason, so he keeps it as a story, because a story is what an instruction turns into when nobody remembers what it was for.”

“And here?”

“Here we have the reason.” She says it without any pride at all. “So we do not need the story. We do not have hidden people in Brynjavík, Dr. Hale. We have a rule about what may be given a house and what may not, and the rule is grammatical, and the rock is one of the places we apply it. The rest of the country turned that rule into a small frightening family who live under a stone and take

offence.” Something moves at the corner of her mouth. “It is not a bad translation. It is just a translation.”

Rowan writes very fast for about a minute.

“The landvættir,” he says. “The land-spirits. Four of them, the dragon and the eagle and the bull and the giant, one at each quarter, guarding the country. That’s in Heimskringla, it’s on the coat of arms, it’s on the coins in my pocket—”

“It is four boundaries,” says Edda. “And a rule about who may approach from which direction, and in what case. Somebody put a face on each one so it could be remembered by people who were not going to be taught the grammar.” She shrugs, a small economical movement. “That was well done. It has lasted a thousand years. Ours has lasted a thousand years too and it has needed a hundred and thirteen people working at it every month, and theirs needed a picture on a coin. I am not saying we chose better.”

“Second sight,” Rowan says. “*Skyggni*.”

“Noticing which case a thing is in before it has finished arriving.”

“Dreams that tell you a name.”

“The only place a name is safe to say.” She looks at him. “Where did you think the dreaming came from? You may not speak the name of a dead man on this coast. So he comes into the dream and says it himself, and you wake with it in your mouth, and you have committed nothing, because you did not say it, you were told it.” A pause. “That is not a superstition. That is a workaround.”

He has stopped writing. She notices, and does not comment.

“And the naming of children?” he asks. “The taboo on repeating a name?”

“No taboo. The opposite.” She refills his cup without being asked, which is the closest thing to affection she has shown him. “You are obliged to reuse them, and you must reuse them in order, and you must not skip. Every child in this village carries a name that has been in it before.” She sets the pot down. “There are eleven names. That is what there has always been. When one goes out of use we are short, and being short is a thing we notice.”

“Eleven for a hundred and thirteen people?”

“Eleven *keeping* names.” She says the word flatly, in the local form, and it is the first time she has used it in front of him. “The rest may be called whatever their mothers like. My mother wanted a Kristjana and got me instead.”

• • •

She tells him about her mother’s winter without his asking for it, which he will realise later was the only unprompted gift of the entire afternoon.

“Nineteen thirty-four,” she says. “I was not born. She was nine.”

She was nine, and in January of that year the distance from the church door to the harbour wall doubled. Not in one night — over eleven days, by degrees, so

that a child sent for bread in the morning came back later than she should have and could not explain why, and was scolded, and the next day was later still, and by the ninth day the schoolmaster was keeping the children at the school because it was no longer reasonable to send a nine-year-old the length of a village that had become forty minutes long.

“Nobody was frightened,” Edda says. “That is what she always came back to. Nobody was frightened, because everybody was busy. There is a great deal to do when a place gets bigger — the water has to be carried further, the boats are further off, the old people cannot get to the hall. It was eleven days of extremely tedious inconvenience and everyone was too tired at the end of it to be afraid.”

“And then?”

“And then it came back. Over about a month. Less neatly than it went.” She turns her cup a quarter turn. “Two of the houses did not come back in quite the same relation to the others, and there was an argument about a boundary that ran until 1961.”

Rowan sits with that.

“Your mother told you this as a story,” he says carefully. “Or as an event?”

“She told it to me the way you would tell a child about the year the roof came off,” Edda’s eyes come up. “Which is what it was. And do you know what the useful part is, Dr. Hale? Not the eleven days. The eleven days are the part that would go in your paper.” She leans forward slightly. “The useful part is the argument about the boundary, because it went on for twenty-seven years, and because both families were right.”

• • •

The interview pivots. He feels the momentum is his. “I want to come back to the water itself. In the village I noticed a reluctance to use the standard noun *hafið*. Instead I heard *the slip, the edge*.”

“Names are addresses,” she says. Her thumbs press together until the nail beds whiten. “You do not shout an address unless you want a visitor.”

He nods. *Name taboo. Sympathetic magic*. Standard anthropological fare, and he pushes past it. “But syntactically — the ocean functions as an agent in your folklore, doesn’t it? Does the sea take the boats? Or are the boats lost to the sea?” He watches her for the reaction to the active construction. “The sea,” he repeats, clarifying, testing. “The sea rises. The sea claims.”

The reaction is not emotional. It is electrical.

The paraffin flame gutters — does not dim, but detaches from the wick, floating a centimeter as a blue sphere before slamming back down into yellow. Simultaneously the wind outside stops. It does not fade. It cuts. One moment the cottage is

under a gale, the next the walls are silent, the roof still, and Rowan's ears pop with the change of pressure.

Edda's spine locks against the chair. Her eyes narrow, not with fear, with calculation. "Stop," she says. A flat line.

"I apologize. Did I offend?"

"You constructed it wrong." She exhales, a hiss. "You gave it the nominative. You made it the actor."

"I was asking a theoretical—"

"There is no theoretical here." The wind returns, changed, a low rhythmic thud against the north wall, like a heavy hand testing the turf. "The grammar is the physics. If you say it rises, you give it the knees to stand."

He writes — *informant displays acute distress at nominative assignment* — and marks it with an asterisk, and is aware, distantly, that his hand is steadier than the rest of him. "Let me rephrase. How would you describe a storm surge? Water coming into the village."

She smooths the wool of her sweater, recalibrating, her lips moving silently over syllables. "At the boundary," she says slowly, "there is an accumulation."

"Passive voice," he notes.

"Locative," she corrects. "We locate the water. We do not let it move. There is water at the door. Not *the water comes to the door*."

"Because if it comes?"

"Then it has intent. And if it has intent, it has memory."

The recorder crackles, a wet tearing sound, like fabric ripping under water. The meters redline for a fraction of a second. "Interference," he says, tapping the device. "RF noise off the coast."

"It is not noise. It is the unbinding." She looks at the black box the way one looks at a trap that has snapped. "We use the instrumental case for the tide. *By means of the tide, the boat is lifted*. Never *the tide lifts the boat*."

He nods, engrossed, categorizing — an ergative shift, agency stripped from nature to survive it, a trauma encoded in syntax, brilliant, publishable. "And if someone breaks the rule? A child? An outsider?"

The static bursts again, louder, a high shriek that cuts off the instant he finishes the word *outsider*. Edda does not flinch. She watches the window, where the glass, still clear, has begun very faintly to breathe a film onto itself, but she does not look at it as if it were remarkable. "If the rule is broken," she says, without affect, "the sentence must be finished by something else."

He feels a chill that has nothing to do with the draught and attributes it to the damp.

• • •

“There is a form,” she says, “used by the line-men when the fog was thickest. To be sure the voice was still a human voice. It requires the breath to be held in the middle. You must not breathe between the subject and the verb. If you breathe, the gap lets the wet in.”

“I’d like to document it.”

She closes her eyes and begins, low, vibrating in the lower throat, a sequence of long vowels and glottal stops. “Áaaa... rrrr... unn... nnn—”

The air in the room tightens. The recorder screams — not feedback, a wall of white noise, absolute, the peak-lights locking on, the counter scrambling forward and back at once. He grabs the device and hits stop, and the screaming ceases, and the room rings.

“Interference,” he says, his heart going hard against his ribs. “High-frequency burst. A trawler’s radar.”

Edda opens her eyes and regards the machine with mild curiosity, as one regards a trap. “The machine does not like the forward construction.” He puts on the headphones. Nothing but a roar of static that sounds, strangely, organic, like the crushing of millions of shells.

“Can you repeat it? Slower — I need the phonemes.”

“I cannot say it slower. The speed is the lock.” She considers him. “But I can say it backward.”

“Retrograde phrasing? Inverted syntax?”

“I mean backward. Behind the verb, where it is safe.” She sees he does not follow. “Forward is the future. To say a thing forward is to invite it toward you. We do not want the future here; we want the present to hold. So the dangerous nouns go behind the verb, in the place the sentence has already passed. What has already passed cannot arrive.” She says it plainly, and he hears the rule close on itself again, discoverable, load-bearing: the direction of a phrase is the direction of time, and time is the thing they will not let move.

She speaks again, the melody inverted, the vowels clipped, the consonants striking the air like flint. “Und... hrafn... i... ver—” The recorder spins silently, the levels bouncing green. It captures it cleanly.

He breathes out. “That got it.”

“Placement,” she says, and stands, signalling the end, her joints moving as if calcified. He packs, thrilled — *temporal orientation linked to syntactic directionality* — and at the door his eye sweeps the window one last time.

The glass is no longer transparent. From frame to frame it is fogged, but the fog is not random; it has organized into rows of tight angular script, thousands of tiny weeping characters that mirror the carvings on the beams. The window is a page, and the text is dense and frantic and unmistakably grammatical.

He pauses, hand on the latch. “You might check the insulation on that frame. The buildup is significant.”

“It is just the residue,” she says, turning to the stove. “Of what we spoke.”

He steps out into the cold, and the transition jars him. The light has failed. The landscape is a blue-black bruise. He walks down the slate path, structuring the paper he will write, and reaches the bottom of the ridge, and stops.

The road is gone.

The tide has not risen so much as surged. Water laps the stone wall of the nearest sheep pen, fifty meters inland from where the shore lay two hours ago. It is smooth, glassy, sliding over the grass without a sound. It does not crash. It occupies. He checks his watch; the charts do not predict this. He looks toward the village, where the hall lights burn and a figure crosses a window and a car crawls the upper track. No one is running. No one is looking at the water that has swallowed the lower road. The village carries on, ignoring the inundation, the way a family carries on around a subject that has been agreed, without a meeting, to be closed.

He stands at the new waterline. The water touches the toe of his boot. It feels deliberate. He pulls his coat tighter and begins the climb, stepping carefully, so as not to disturb the syntax of the rising dark.

VI



The procession does not march; it filters. Like groundwater through shale, the villagers of Brynjavík seep up the incline toward the basalt platform that overhangs the bay. There is no coffin. The coffin is already in the ground in the high churchyard, under a Lutheran service of unremarkable correctness that Rowan attended an hour ago and could have attended in any parish in Iceland: the hymn, the reading from Corinthians, the three handfuls of earth, Séra Hjálmar in his ruff and cassock saying the words in a warm unhurried baritone while the wind worked at the pages. Nothing in the churchyard was strange. That is what Rowan cannot get past. Nothing in the churchyard was strange, and then the entire congregation walked out through the lych-gate, turned west instead of down, and climbed toward the water without anyone appearing to have decided to.

The body has been committed. The grammar of departure is still pending.

He had asked Hjálmar about it on the path, quietly, the way one asks a question one suspects is rude. The pastor had considered the horizon for a while.

“The burial puts him with God,” he said at last. “That is settled. That was settled at the graveside and I do not think it can be unsettled by anything we do on a rock.” He shifted his grip on the prayer book, which he carried against his chest the way Rowan has begun to carry the tin. “What is not settled is where he is. Where the body is. Where the name is. Those are different questions from the question of the soul, Dr. Hale, and the Church has never claimed the second one.” A small dry smile. “It has occasionally claimed it in other countries. It did not get much thanks.”

“And the parish permits this? The second service?”

“The parish *is* this,” Hjálmar said, without any edge at all. “I bury them. Then I walk up the hill with them and I stand at the back and I hold my tongue, because the part that happens on the rock is not mine and I am not good at it.” He looked at Rowan directly for the first time. “I am fifty-one. I have been here nineteen years.

I could not tell you where the one ends and the other begins, and I have stopped regarding that as a failure of scholarship.”

He counts eighty-nine heads, which is most of the village and all of the part of it that matters today; the rest are children too young to hold still and the two Sigurjónsdóttir sisters, who have not spoken to each other since a dispute over a mooring in 2009 and who cannot be relied upon to stand in the same line. He adjusts the gain on his recorder, sheltering the microphones from the salt wind with a fur windshield. The silence of the group is not emptiness. It is held breath, pressure behind a valve. This is not grief as he has known grief. No weeping, no black veils, no bowed heads. The postures are upright, braced. They have come to see that a debt is settled before the day closes.

He knows a version of this silence. Eight months ago he stood at the edge of another committal, in a crematorium chapel in Cambridgeshire that smelled of lilies and warm dust, and did not weep either, and was privately relieved that no one required it of him. His mother had left instructions so spare they were almost a grammar of their own: no service, no address, the ashes to the college garden, and — in a line he had read four times — *nothing said over me that I would not have said myself*. He had honoured it. He had said nothing. He had thought, at the time, that this was a kindness he was doing her. He watches the villagers brace against the wind and revises the thought, and files the revision, and does not look at it again.

They gather on the shelf of volcanic rock, planed level by centuries of ice. The sea below is a churning grey slurry, heaving against the cliff with a rhythm that is dangerously close to a heartbeat. It does not crash. It thuds. A man steps to the edge, weathered, his knuckles bleached by cold and work. He does not look at the water. He looks at the horizon, that smudge where grey meets grey, and raises his hands, palms down. The suppression gesture.

The speech begins. Vikamál, low and guttural. Rowan’s headphones fill with it, long open vowels stretched thin to accommodate the wind, and he watches the waveform crawl green across his screen. The speaker is reciting the Sæfangi, the Sea-Holding, a lattice of datives and instrumentals, a way of giving without naming, of placing the dead into the category of matter rather than identity. *From the bone, the salt. To the salt, the weight. By way of the drift, the return.*

He writes: *Agent removal complete. Objectification of the deceased prevents nominative claim.* The crowd breathes in sync with the caesuras. They are the redundancy. If the speaker fails, the weight of their listening should hold the line.

But there is a gap in the line. Edda stands ten meters off, near a jagged outcrop, coat buttoned to the chin. She does not watch the speaker. She watches the water, a patch of foam swirling at the cliff base. She is the one checking the sum.

The speaker’s voice rises toward the knot that ties the ritual shut. He speaks of the gathering. “*Hérna kemur... safnið—*” He falters.

It is microscopic, perhaps two hundred milliseconds, a stutter on the suffix. He means to cast *safn* — the gathering, the collection — into the singular instrumental, a mass noun, indivisible. But his tongue trips and adds a syllable. “...*safnanna*.” Genitive plural. *Of the gatherings*. He has split the single mass into countable parts. He has implied there is more than one return, more than enough to go around.

To an outsider it is a cleared throat. To the system it is a breach. Rowan sees it before he hears it. Edda goes rigid — not a flinch, a seizure, as if a current has run through her spine. The cords at her throat stand out and vibrate. Her lips shape a correction, a counter-sound to null the plural, and she does not speak it. She clamps her jaw. She knows: to overlay the error now would be to confess it to the listener below, to admit the grammar can be bent. Her silence is terrible. It is a masonry block dropped into a well.

The speaker pales; he knows too. He rushes the last words, smearing the consonants, trying to lose the mistake in the noise of the gale, and steps back from the edge wiping his hands on his trousers as if to clean off the wrong ending. The villagers do not gasp. They shift — a collective adjustment of weight, shoulders closing the gaps between them — and they look at their boots, and they do not look at the sea. Rowan glances down at the churning water. It does not look angry. It looks attentive. It looks like it is counting.

• • •

The wind does not build. It arrives.

At 02:00 the Annex takes a single percussive blow. Rowan wakes — not from sleep but from the shallow drift of his own notes — and goes to the window, the cold glass shivering against his fingers. Outside, the storm is taking the village apart.

It is not a rage. It moves with a precision that defies weather. It bypasses the fragile glass of the greenhouse; it leaves the loose shingles of the hall. It goes for the storage sheds along the eastern perimeter. He watches the wind peel the corrugated roof from a net-drying hut — not tear it, unstitch it, the sheets lifting in sequence, one, two, three, folding back like the leaves of a book being read. A gust hammers the chimney of the old salting house and the bricks tumble inward, filling the throat of the hearth, while the rest of the roof stands untouched. A boathouse flush against the tide loses its eastern wall entire, the frame stripped clean, the boats inside exposed to spray — and the oars racked along the far wall do not so much as rattle.

He counts the strikes. They are rhythmic. They fall on the things that hold things: sheds, lockers, boundaries. The storm is attacking the idea of keeping. He remembers the error on the cliff. *Safnanna*. The plural of the hoard. The

sea is correcting the inventory. The word for what he is watching wants to be a bureaucratic one, and he lets it come once, because it is exact, and then he lets it go: the sea is not auditing anything. It is grieving in the only grammar it has, which is weight and water, and it has been told there is more than enough, and it does not agree.

He stays at the glass until the wind drops, as suddenly as it came, at 04:15. The silence after is heavier than the noise. The village lies grey and open under the first light, smoke rising from the fallen chimney like a flag of surrender.

Then, thin and human, cutting up through the quiet from the direction of the harbour: a shout. Then another, and the particular ragged pitch of men calling a name.

• • •

He is down the hundred and twelve steps before he has decided to go.

At the harbour mouth the water is still heaving from the storm, and a small skiff — someone had gone out too early, or never come in — is broadside to the swell, half-swamped, its mooring line parted and streaming. A figure is in the water between the boat and the quay wall, and the figure is Bjarni. Rowan knows the fair hair even flattened black. The young man is not swimming. He is being moved, lifted and dropped by the swell against the barnacled stone, one arm hooked over the parted line, his face going under and coming up and going under, and each time it comes up it comes up lower.

Three villagers are on the quay. One has a boathook. None of them has gone in. Rowan understands, in a flat instant that he will turn over for weeks, that they are not frozen by fear. They are calculating grammar. To call his name across the water is to hand the water a nominative, a handle. To reach for him and fail is to give the sea a completed action. They are trying to find the phrase that saves him without naming him to the thing that has him, and the phrase is taking too long.

Rowan has no such phrase. He has only the old, crude, terrestrial grammar of a body going toward another body. He goes down the weed-slick steps, takes the boathook from the man who holds it — the man lets it go with something like relief and something like horror — and wedges himself at the waterline, and reaches.

“By the line,” the man behind him says, urgent, in Vikamál. “Not by the arm. Give it the rope, not the name.” And Rowan understands enough now to obey: he does not shout Bjarni’s name, does not reach for the boy himself, reaches instead for the streaming mooring line and hooks it and hauls, so that it is the rope that is subject and object of the sentence, the rope that is pulled, the rope that pulls, and Bjarni only a weight the rope happens to bear. The distinction is absurd. He makes it anyway. The swell lifts them both and he leans back against it with everything

in his legs, and the old man is beside him now with a grip on his coat, and the woman has the line behind, and they draw the rope in and Bjarni with it, three, four, terrible seconds, and then his other hand comes up over the stone and closes on nothing and then on Rowan's wrist.

They land him on the quay like a catch. He is grey-white, his lips gone the colour of the water, and he coughs up brine in long convulsions, more of it than a chest should hold, and the woman turns his head so it runs into the gaps between the stones and not back down. No one says his name. No one says the word for what nearly happened. The old man says only, quietly, in the passive that Rowan is learning is a kind of mercy here, "*He is kept.*" Not *he is saved*. Not *he lives*. Only that he has, for now, been kept on this side of the boundary.

Bjarni opens his eyes. They find Rowan crouched over him and hold there, and something in them has changed — not gratitude, or not only. There is a new blankness at the back of the boy who talked too much, a stillness the water has left in him the way it leaves salt on stone, a thing that will not wash off. He tries to speak and what comes out first is not a word but a note, low, held, one of the long resonating vowels Edda made in her throat, as if the sea has taught him a syllable on the way down and he has brought it back. Then he closes his mouth on it, deliberately, the way the others close their mouths, and Rowan watches the village's discipline enter a person in real time, watches Bjarni become, in the space of a breath, quieter, older, marked.

"Don't take him to the hall wet," the old man says. "Dry clothes first. The wet remembers." They carry him up between them, and Rowan carries part of the weight, and the weight is enormous and specific and entirely of this world, and for once he does not reach for a phrase to keep it at a distance. He simply carries it, and finds, when they set the boy down by a stove and the danger has passed, that his own hands are shaking, and that he is glad of it, glad of the plain animal fear, because it is his, and it names nothing, and it is the truest thing he has felt since the crematorium garden.

• • •

Later, in the debris field, the air smells of wet soot and split pine — the smell of a flooded archive. He keeps his camera in his pocket; the lens feels too aggressive against the quiet industry. The villagers work in a silence that is almost structural, a silence that holds the space up. No calls for hammers, no warnings about nails. A man lifts one end of a beam; a woman is already there for the other. A nod moves a load, a glance stops a shovel. They move with heavy deliberate caution, as if the air itself might shatter under a careless vowel.

He watches three men repairing the dry-stone wall of the salting yard. The wall was not knocked down; it burst outward from within, the stones splayed in a fan.

He notes the angle. *Expulsive force. Internal pressure.* He steps closer, meaning to ask about the mortar — and a hand closes on his shoulder, heavy, calloused, immovable.

Arnar Jónsson. The harbour master looks as though he has not slept in a week; the lines around his eyes are cut deep with salt. He smells of diesel and old wool. He does not look at Rowan. He looks at the wall, at the men slotting a block back into the breach.

“Do not ask them,” Arnar says, a rumble that barely moves the air. “They are concentrating.”

“On the mortar?”

“On the case. They have to close the sentence before the tide turns.”

Rowan adjusts his glasses. “The damage is very specific. The boathouse, the shed. Nothing residential. It looks almost curated.”

Arnar takes a pouch of tobacco from his pocket and rolls a cigarette with shaking fingers. He does not light it. “The speaker slipped,” he says. Not an accusation. A report, a mechanic noting a sheared bolt.

“I noticed. A phonological stutter on the final declension of *safn*. I have it recorded.”

Arnar turns his head slowly and looks at Rowan with a pity that is devastating in its mildness. “It wasn’t a stutter.”

“Then what was it?”

“The sea heard the wrong ending.” He says it the way an engineer says the load exceeded the rating. “It heard plural. The sea does not like plural. Plural means we have enough to spare.” He pockets a lighter he never meant to use. “We do not have enough to spare. We nearly spared one this morning, in the harbour.”

Rowan says, because his training says it for him, “You believe the performance failure produced a collective expectation of punishment, and the community read the storm damage as targeted—”

Arnar looks at him, and for a moment the distance between them is not intellectual but nearly biological. “Dr. Hale. You think the words describe the storm. You have it backward.” He turns to go, boots crunching wet gravel. “The words are the weather. Yesterday we asked, by accident, for the roof to be taken. And the boy this morning — the sea was only reaching for the nearest handle we left lying out.” He walks toward the quay.

Rowan looks down at his notebook, at the neat rows of phonetic symbols. His pen hovers over the page where, an hour ago, in a warm room, Bjarni had coughed up the sea and then swallowed a vowel rather than let it out. He does not write *ritual entropy*. He does not write anything. He caps the pen.

The sea is flat now, disturbingly calm, the waves against the jetty small and evenly spaced, breaking with a soft hiss-thud, hiss-thud. He listens. The rhythm is the cadence of the funeral chant, stripped of the error, looping. Hiss-thud. Noun,

verb. Hiss-thud. Subject, object. He reaches for his recorder and touches the cold casing in his pocket and hesitates. If the sea listens to endings, then recording it is not observation. It is a dialogue. And he does not know the case for *listener*, or whether it is safe to be one. He leaves the recorder in his pocket and steps back from the edge, retreating toward the Annex, while behind him the villagers seal the wall and lock the silence back inside the stone.

VII



The dawn arrives not as an event but as a gradual desaturation of the dark. The sky over Brynjavík is the colour of wet slate, indistinguishable from the water except by texture; the sky is smooth, the water grained with the restless geometry of the tide.

Rowan finds Arnar Jónsson where the basalt shelf descends into the foam. The harbour master stands ankle-deep in the kelp and drift, his back to the horizon. He does not look like a man expecting company. He looks like a piece of the shoreline that has detached itself to run a maintenance cycle.

Rowan approaches, boots on the scree. He holds his notebook to his chest, the recorder primed but hidden. He has learned from the funeral. He does not brandish the device; he lets it listen from the dark.

“Good morning.” The greeting feels too round, too whole for the hour.

Arnar does not turn. He is working a length of green nylon, his fingers finding a fray, excising it with a small knife, the motion surgical. “The wind,” he says. He does not finish. He does not say *is cold* or *has died*. He acknowledges the noun and lets it hang, unanchored.

“I wanted to ask about the repairs. The wall’s holding?”

Arnar nods. He lifts a cracked plastic float, turns it to show the fissure, names nothing, sets it in a crate. Then he says, unprompted, which he has not done before: “Not the proper time for it. The wall.”

“There’s a proper time?”

“The Keeping.” He gestures with his chin up the coast, an economical sweep that takes in the sheds, the wall, the boundary stones, the whole inventory of the place. “Fourth Saturday. Everyone. The walls, the nets, the roofs.” He works the knife along the fray. “Doing it now is doing it twice. But it will not keep until the fourth Saturday, so.” A shrug of the shoulders that is almost an apology to the schedule.

“Every month?”

“Every month.” Arnar says it the way a man confirms that the bins go out on a Tuesday.

“And that’s enough?”

“For a wall.” He sets the float down. “Not for the rest.” He looks up the coast, and something in the set of his shoulders shifts — not solemnity, Rowan will think later, but the particular weariness of a man contemplating a large annual task in the wrong season. “The Great Keeping is at the turn of the year. That one is different. That one is the whole boundary, every stone, and the reading.”

“The reading of what?”

“The names.” Arnar picks up the next float. He does not elaborate, and Rowan has learned enough not to push a man who has already given three sentences more than his quota.

Rowan writes it down. *Monthly maintenance day, universal participation — walls, nets, roofs. Plus annual observance at midwinter: full perimeter + recitation of names (list? genealogy? necrology?). Ask Sigrún re: parish overlap.* He underlines *universal*, and files the whole thing under folk custom, under the sort of thing a village does because a village has always done it, and does not yet think to ask what a hundred and thirteen people are maintaining when they walk a boundary in the dark and read a list of names aloud to nobody. “The stone,” he says. “The placement holds.” He picks up a net shuttle, traces its spine with his thumb, mimes filling it — does not say *shuttle*, does not say *needle*, draws its long figure-eight in the air and points to the pile of mending. “For the tear.”

Rowan notes it — *nominal substitution via gesture* — and hears, under his own clinical shorthand, something he recognizes and does not want to. His mother, at the end of a telephone line, describing a hospital appointment without once using the word for the thing being appointed. The shape drawn in the air around the absent noun. He had thought, then, that she was protecting him. He wonders now whether she was protecting the word, keeping it from fastening to her by refusing it a nominative. He did not have the grammar for that suspicion until this coast handed it to him.

“You use a specific weave?” he asks.

Arnar looks at him. His eyes are pale, rimmed red with sleeplessness. “The pattern.” He makes a chopping motion, distinct from the weaving. “To stop the run.”

They walk north along the shore, away from the quay. The tide is low but the rock is wet far above the line, black testimony to how high the water reached in the dark. Arnar keeps to the landward side, his body between Rowan and the drop. They pass an iron ringbolt rusted the colour of dried blood. Arnar touches it — not with affection, with verification. “The mooring.” He looks up the cliff, away from the bay. “The winter. Fifty years.” He traces a horizontal line at hip height,

then drops it to his knee. “The level.”

Rowan writes *subsidence record* and thinks: the man is a living archive, and the index is encrypted, and he has met this filing system before, in a woman who kept her whole history in a drawer she would not open in front of her son.

“Arnar,” he ventures, stepping over a fissure. “Thorsteinn mentioned your wife. That she knew the older weather chants.”

Arnar’s stride halts mid-step, then completes with a heavy, deliberate placement of the heel. He turns — not to face Rowan, but ninety degrees to the south, putting his shoulder to the sea and his face to the granite wall of the cliff. He stares at a patch of yellow lichen. “She always—” The sentence hangs. The wind picks at the loose threads of his sweater. Rowan waits, expecting a memory. *She always loved the rain. She always sang.*

“The nets would—” Arnar tries again. He lifts his hands, palms open, shaping a wide encompassing circle that collapses inward.

“She mended them?”

Arnar closes his hands into fists and drops them. “The morning,” he says. “The coffee.”

He refuses the possessive. He refuses the past-tense verb. To say *she drank* would be to place her in time, and time implies an end. To say *my wife* would be to claim her, and claims are audible to the water at his back. Rowan reads the side-on stance as a trauma response, a physical aversion to the environment that took her, and writes *grief-induced aphasia; emotional load prevents syntactic completion* — and then his pen stops, because the phrase is a lie of the exact kind he specializes in, and he knows it. This is not aphasia. This is precision. Arnar can say her. He is choosing, syllable by syllable, not to, because he has calculated what a name costs here. Rowan has spent his life mistaking that choice for an inability, in this man, in himself, in the woman who raised him inside a silence he called, on his grant forms, *the reticence characteristic of her generation.*

“It’s alright,” Rowan says softly. “We don’t have to speak of her.”

Arnar traces the shape of a flower in the air, then erases it with a flat palm. “The voice,” he whispers. “Sometimes. The glass.” He turns back to the path, shoulder locked as a barrier, and nods — not points, a chin-lift, a finger might read as a vector — at a jagged spire of rock fifty meters out. “The break. The water.” He spirals his index finger, a vortex in the empty air.

“The currents are dangerous there.”

“The water,” Arnar repeats, firm, correcting the attribution of danger. “Does not—” He stops. He swallows the verb. *Does not kill. Does not forgive.* He walks on. The silence he leaves is not empty. It is load-bearing. It holds the cliff up; it keeps the tide from rushing into the gap where the sentence should have ended. Rowan follows, recording the sound of their boots on stone, and does not yet know that the rhythm of their footsteps is the only grammar keeping them dry.

• • •

They go out at six the next morning, because Arnar is going out anyway and does not object when Rowan appears at the quay, which is as close to an invitation as the man has in him.

The boat is a nine-metre plastic thing with a wheelhouse the size of a telephone box, and it is called *Vonin*, the hope, and Arnar has never once said the name aloud in Rowan's hearing; when he refers to it at all he says *the boat*. The season's quota is on a laminated card taped inside the wheelhouse door, and the figure on it is, Rowan gathers over the next four hours, an outrage, a personal insult, and a subject on which the harbour master of Brynjavík holds views of some duration.

He gets more words out of Arnar in the first hour at sea than in the previous three days on land.

Not about the water. About the system. About the quota being tradeable, which means saleable, which means gone. About the four boats that were here in 1994 and the one that is here now. About a man in the south who owns the right to catch fish in this bay and has never seen it and never will, and about how that is entirely legal, and is not theft in any sense a court would recognise, and is.

"Half the coast is the same," Arnar says, adjusting the throttle. "It was not our weather that took the boats."

It is the most sustained piece of ordinary political grievance Rowan has heard in this village, and it arrives in complete sentences, with subjects and active verbs and no hedging whatsoever, because the Ministry of Fisheries is not listening from below.

Then he cuts the engine on the drift, and the talking stops, and does not start again for two hours.

Rowan watches him read the weather. There is no instrument involved. Arnar looks at the water four times in twenty minutes — not at the sky, at the water — and on the fourth look he starts the engine and turns for home, and at that moment the bay is flat and the sky is the same nothing it has been all morning.

The squall arrives forty minutes later, when they are tied up and Rowan has both hands round a mug in the shed.

"How?"

Arnar coils a line. "The chop was wrong for the wind." A shrug. "More coming in than the wind was making."

Rowan writes it down. Then he stops, and looks at what he has written, and crosses out *intuition*, and writes *differential* — because that is what it is. A man reading the gap between two quantities and inferring a third from the size of it. It is not mysticism and it is not instinct. It is the identical operation Rowan performs on attested and unattested forms, and Arnar does it on open water at six in the morning with one hand on a throttle, and has been doing it since he was a boy, and

would not have a word for it if asked.

• • •

Arnar's cottage is an exercise in subtraction. The exterior is rough basalt, indistinguishable from the scree; the interior is planed smooth, scrubbed to the grain. The heavy door seals with the finality of a vault. The room smells of scalded milk and dried peat. Rowan stands dripping on the mat, cataloguing. It is furnished for one, yet the geometry insists on two. The table is pushed to the wall, one chair tucked in, the other rigid in the corner holding a stack of charts. Above the hearth, two hooks: one holds a damp oilskin; the other is empty, the iron dark against whitewashed stone. He looks at the empty hook a beat too long. He has an empty hook of his own — a coat still on the back of a door in Grantchester that he could not make himself give away, that his rational mind knows is only wool and cannot possibly still hold her shape, and does.

Arnar does not ask what he wants. He lifts the kettle — the gesture is the noun — and sets it on the burner, takes down two mugs. Clink. Clink. “The cold,” he says, and taps a mug.

“Thank you.” Rowan sits. The room is not just quiet; it is sanitized of pronouns. No photographs. No knick-knacks. Only tools.

“I’ve been studying the village records,” he says, opening to a fresh page. “The census shows decline, but the physical footprint seems fluid. Buildings on the old maps that aren’t here, and the reverse.”

Arnar watches the steam. He stands with his hip to the counter, blocking the line of sight between the table and the window. “Before the last—” He stops. He makes a downward sweeping gesture. *Storm? Surge?* He leaves it open.

“Before the event,” Rowan supplies.

Arnar nods, a concession. “Houses stood.”

“Your houses?”

“Houses,” Arnar corrects. He looks at the floor. “The foundation. The clay.” He locks his fingers and pulls them slowly apart. “The ground—”

“Subsidence. The ground gave way.”

Arnar shakes his head. He picks up a length of twine, holds it up. “The ground,” he says, and twists it into a loop, “did not hold.” He refuses the active verb. The ground did not collapse; it failed to maintain the state of holding. A subtle distinction — to Arnar, the difference between a tragedy and a sentence.

His fingers move with terrifying precision, looping the end over the standing part. “For the wind,” he says, tightening. A modified bowline, the loop doubled. “When the air—” He gestures at the window. “When the air pulls.” He ties another, a spiral of hitches around the rope’s core. “For the net. When the weight—” He leaves it dangling. *When the weight is a body.*

He does not stop there.

He ties eleven, and he ties them in an order, and it takes about twenty minutes, and it is the longest sustained act of communication Rowan has had from him. There is no commentary. Each knot goes onto the table in sequence, left to right, and where two are related the second is set slightly below the first, so that what accumulates on the scrubbed pine is not a row but a shape — a branching, with a trunk and two limbs and a place near the end where three of them cluster very close together.

Rowan watches the shape arrive and feels the back of his neck go cold, because he has drawn this. Not this object; this diagram. He has drawn it forty times on whiteboards in three countries. It is a stemma. It is what a morphologist draws when they are showing which forms descend from which, and where the branches split, and which cousins sit so close together that students confuse them.

“Arnar.”

“Mm.”

“Who taught you the order?”

Arnar’s hands do not stop. “The order is the order.”

“No — I mean, when you were taught. Was it one man? Over how long?”

A pause of three or four seconds while a hitch is set.

“My father,” Arnar says. “Eleven winters. One a winter.” He seats the knot and looks at it. “You do not get the next one until the last one holds in weather.”

One a winter. Rowan does the arithmetic without meaning to: a boy starting at seven has the full set at eighteen, which is when he would first be put in a boat alone, which is precisely how long a morphological paradigm takes to become automatic in a first-language speaker. This is not a folk pedagogy. It is a syllabus, and it has been costed, and somebody a long time ago worked out exactly how much a child can hold per year and then held to it for four hundred years.

“And if a boy is quick?” he asks. “If he could take two in a winter?”

“Then he waits.” Arnar puts down the twine. “The quick ones are the ones you lose.”

Rowan leans forward. He recognizes the spiral; it matches the diagram he drew of the Sæfangi, the encirclement. “You’re mapping the tension. The knot is a grammatical modifier. It distributes the load.”

Arnar looks at him. “The knot stops the slip.” He sets the knotted twine on the table between them like a specimen.

Rowan glances at the window. The stove’s heat has begun to work against the chill of the glass, and fog gathers in the corners and creeps inward — not uniformly. It streaks. The condensation forms short horizontal dashes. Hyphens. A page of text in which every word has been redacted. A single droplet, heavy, rolls down the pane tracing a shape too much like a comma, a pause where none should be.

“The insulation’s poor,” Rowan notes. “You get a lot of buildup.”

Arnar turns and sees the glass. He does not reach for a rag. He crosses to the window with the measured step of a priest approaching an altar and lifts his hand, palm flat and dry. He wipes the glass — does not scrub, erases. One long horizontal stroke, left to right. Then another below it. He is completing the lines the moisture is trying to write; he is finishing the redactions himself. He is censoring the window. “The view,” Arnar says, his hand pressed to the cold pane. “Needs—” *Clearing? Closing?* “Needs salt.” He turns back, wipes his damp hand on his trousers.

Rowan does not write *compulsive cleaning ritual*. He watches a man he has begun, against every rule of his profession, to love a little, hold a page of the sea’s handwriting flat under his palm until it gives up, and he understands that this is what the whole village is: a hand held against the glass, erasing faster than the water can write. He has done it himself. He did it over his mother’s grave, where he said nothing, and called the nothing a kindness.

Arnar pours the water and sets the pot down but does not pour the tea. He waits, looking at the empty hook. “The tea,” he says finally. “Wait.” Rowan realizes he is waiting for the boil to subside, for the water to go passive before he will let it be consumed.

“You’re very precise, Arnar. With your words. With your hands.”

Arnar touches the knot. “The sea,” he says, barely audible. “Does not—”

“Does not what?”

Arnar looks at the empty chair. “Forget.” He says it without a subject. Just the verb. He pours the tea, and the sound of the liquid hitting the ceramic is loud, and it sounds like a sentence ending.

• • •

He learns about the wife in pieces, across that week, and never once from Arnar.

Her name is on the harbour rota from 2011, still pinned in the shed because nobody has taken it down: *Kristbjörg*, in the Saturday column, eleven Saturdays, in a round unhurried hand.

She is in a photograph in the community hall, in a group of fourteen at the opening of the slipway, second from the left, laughing at something outside the frame.

The mugs in the cottage are a set of six, and four of them are chipped in the same place, which means they have been washed by the same hands in the same sink in the same order for a very long time, and two of them are not chipped at all.

And there are the two hooks by the hearth.

Rowan noticed the empty one on his first visit and read it, correctly, as the obvious thing. What he notices on his third is that Arnar hangs his own oilskin on

the *left* hook, every time — and that the left hook is the bad one. It sits behind the door swing. It is four inches lower than it should be. A man reaching for it has to lean and turn his shoulder, and Arnar leans and turns his shoulder, every day, twice a day, for however many years it has been.

The right-hand hook is at shoulder height, perfectly placed, and empty.

He is not preserving it. Preservation would be sentiment, and there is no sentiment in this room — no photograph, no keepsake, nothing that could be called a shrine, nothing an outsider could point at. He is simply not using it. Day after day, deliberately, at a small daily cost to his own back, the way a man does not use a word.

And Rowan, who has stood in this room before and looked at the empty hook and thought about a navy coat on a door nine hundred miles south, revises the whole reading, because he had it sentimental and it is not sentimental. He had been telling himself for eight months that what he could not do was give the coat away. That is not what he could not do. He could not take it down and hang his own there.

It was never grief. It was the same operation. Leave the hook empty, leave the noun out of the sentence, and pay for it yourself, twice a day, quietly, forever, rather than let the thing be handled.

He does not mention the hook. He hangs his coat over the back of a chair.

Arnar sees him do it. Something in the man's face moves, once, and settles.

"The chair is fine," he says.

• • •

The walk back to the guest house is a navigation of small accumulated errors. Rowan measures his progress not by distance but by discrepancy. The village has not changed, yet it does not fit the map in his head. The tide line on the harbour wall, two meters below the coping yesterday, now crusts the concrete a half-meter from the top, dry, white, as if the water held that height for hours unseen. At the lower path a volcanic boulder, pocked with gas bubbles, sits in the center of the gravel track. He stepped around this rock yesterday, on the left verge. Now it blocks the way, having moved three meters inland without a furrow behind it.

He looks back. Arnar stands in his doorway, a silhouette in the dark stone, watching Rowan, or watching the space between Rowan and the water. "Arnar," Rowan calls, pointing. "This has moved."

Arnar leans against the frame, half in shadow. "The location," he calls back, carried effortlessly by the damp air, "is not fixed."

"But the rock. It's heavy. It implies force."

"The sea," Arnar says. He looks up, checking the grammar of the clouds. "Remember what we—" He stops. He closes the door. The latch is a period at the

end of a paragraph Rowan has not finished reading. *Remembers what we forgot? What we took?*

He climbs to the Annex. The wind is low in the dried grass, sibilant. Sss. Sss. Inside, he does not light the lamp. He stands in the dark, breathing stale air, the room pressurized. He is bone-tired, the fatigue of a man who has been treading water for days. He sleeps in his clothes.

The dream is not a narrative. It is a diagram. He hovers above the coastline. Below him the ocean is not water but syntax. The waves are long rolling clauses that gather from the deep and approach the shore in the nominative — subjects seeking an object. He watches a wave curl: the crest is the verb, propelling the mass; as it breaks it declines, giving its energy to the land in the dative, the foam hissing up the beach in spiral genitive markers, possessive loops that try to circle the rocks and claim them. *Of the stone. Of the sand. Of the man.* The tide withdraws in the passive. *The sand was taken. The stone was eroded.* He sees the pressure gradients as lines of force that answer to the intensity of grief; where the water is deepest the grammar is most compressed, dense with unsaid nouns.

He wakes to the grey luminescence of pre-dawn fog against the glass. The silence is absolute, yet the room is vibrating. He sits up and looks at the window.

The glass is opaque. The condensation is thick, white, organized — not random moisture but rows of jagged angular script, lines that start strong and trail into nothing. Hooks without bait. Stems without flowers. *Th. Wh. Sh.* He crosses to it, floorboards cold under his socks. The patterns are intricate. He sees the shape of Arnar's knot repeated a hundred times in the droplets. He sees the spiral of the genitive. He sees the sharp vertical stroke of the command. He raises his hand — not for the camera, not for the notebook. The need to document has been replaced by the need to answer.

He presses his fingertips to the glass. The vibration travels up his arm, low and rhythmic, not the wind, not a truck on the road. A cadence. Da-dum. Da-dum. Da. The rhythm of a heart, or of a sentence waiting for a full stop that never comes. The glass is singing the part of the conversation Arnar refused to speak. Rowan stands with his hand on the cold wet text, feeling the pulse of the sea against the thin barrier of the room, and understands. He does not know the words yet. He recognizes the syntax. It is the language he was raised in. It is waiting for him to answer, and he has been not-answering it his whole life.

VIII



The schoolhouse sits on a rise the village has quietly receded from, stranded in withered heather. It is not a ruin. Ruins imply a surrender to nature, a softening of lines. This building is a rejection — black basalt blocks squared with punishing precision, hunched against the skyline, its slate roof pulled low like the brim of a hat worn by a man who does not wish to be recognized.

Rowan climbs, boots slipping on wet scree. The wind here is different. Down in the village the gale shoves, physical and boisterous. Here the air streams around the stone corners with a thin high whistle that sounds disturbingly like inhalation. Sigrún walks two paces behind, a scarf of grey wool swallowing the lower half of her face, leaving only her eyes, rimmed red, moving from the clouded horizon to the heavy oak door. She does not look at the windows, whose glass is mostly gone, leaving dark rectangular sockets that observe their approach with bureaucratic indifference.

“The key,” Rowan says at the threshold.

She fumbles in her coat with hands that shake at a specific frequency and produces an iron key, heavy, pitted with orange rust. She holds it out but does not move to insert it. “It has been closed since ninety-four,” she says, muffled by the wool. “The Ministry consolidated the district. They said the heating was unsustainable.”

“And the curriculum?”

“Unsustainable,” she repeats.

The mechanism grinds — metal teeth on grit — but the bolt throws. The door swings inward on hinges that scream and then settle into a sullen silence, and they step into the air of 1994. Dry, cold, chalk dust and dead flies. The silence is not empty; it is suspended. Dust motes turn in slow hypnotic gyres in the shafts of grey light. Rowan moves forward, disturbing a layer of silt that has lain unbroken for thirty years, leaving dark accusatory prints. Sigrún stays near the door, arms

crossed tight, compressing herself into the smallest possible volume.

“We shouldn’t be long,” she whispers.

He unzips his jacket, the sound tearing the quiet, and moves down the corridor, walls the peeling institutional green of sea-sickness. He stops at the first display, a chart pinned with rusted tacks. *Declensions of the Strong Nouns*. Yellowed, curling like dried skin. The standard four cases — Nominative, Accusative, Dative, Genitive — faded but legible. But below the Genitive the paper has been surgically removed. Not torn. Cut, with a blade, perfectly straight. He moves to the next: *Usage of the Definite Article*, the bottom third — where the irregular, ritual forms would be listed — excised, the wall behind it a brighter green, a phantom limb.

“Sigrún,” he says, not turning. “Who cut these?”

A pause. The wind finds a gap in the roof tiles and moans, dropping an octave, a vowel trapped in a throat. “The inspection board,” she answers from the shadows. “In eighty-two. They said the walls were cluttered. They said the charts should reflect the examinable material.”

He touches the edge of the paper. “They removed the Sæfangi. And the Hrim-fall.”

“They removed the clutter.” Flat, rehearsed.

Rowan walks deeper into the hall. The amputation is systemic. A painted mural of the local fauna — puffins, arctic foxes, seals — has been altered: the seals painted over with grey blocks, leaving only the rocks they rested on. A rule for the address of weather phenomena has been whitewashed, the paint thick and hurried, a bandage over a wound that would not stop. He stops outside a classroom door, its glass pane shattered, the shards inside. The wind through the gap is making a resonance, the draught catching the jagged edge and producing a sibilant hiss that modulates with the gusts. *Sssss. Uuu. Thhh*. It sounds like a child sounding out a word they are forbidden to speak. On the floor the dust is disturbed — not by feet, by the draught, swirled into perfect tight spirals, the genitive loops of his dream. The building is breathing, and in its exhalation trying to decline the air.

“This isn’t a ruin,” he murmurs, photographing the sliced chart. “It’s a scoured field.”

At the end of the corridor there is one more.

He almost walks past it. It hangs where the light is worst, between the cloak-room pegs and a fire notice from 1988, and it is a chart of the same species as the others — ruled columns, a heading in the same institutional hand, the paper gone the same nicotine colour.

The bottom third has been removed.

He puts his thumb on the cut and stops, because the cut is wrong.

The others are thirty years old. Their cut edges have aged with the rest of the sheet: the same yellowing, the same brittleness, a faint brown line of oxidation along the exposed fibre where three decades of damp air has worked at it. This

edge is clean. The exposed fibre is paler than the sheet around it. The paper has been opened recently enough that it has not yet caught up with itself.

He gets the loupe out and puts the light of his phone on it at a raking angle, and the fibres along the edge are crisp and standing.

Not 1982. Not 1994. Two years, perhaps three.

Someone has been in this building — which is locked, which has one key, which Sigrún carried up the hill in a shaking hand this morning and had to be asked twice for — and has stood in the dark at the end of this corridor and cut a section out of a chart on a wall in a school that has had no children in it for thirty-one years, and has taken the piece away, and has not mentioned it.

He photographs the cut. He photographs the wall behind it, which is a brighter green.

He does not call out to Sigrún, and he is careful, walking back down the corridor, to arrange his face.

Because there are two readings and he cannot get between them. Either somebody in this village is still, quietly, thirty years after the Ministry finished, removing the dangerous parts of the grammar from where a person might see them — or somebody came up here in the dark and cut out the one panel that still had a form on it that nobody living could otherwise reproduce, and took it home, and put it somewhere safe.

Suppression or rescue. The same blade, the same wall, the same two inches of missing paper.

“Dr. Hale,” Sigrún calls, her voice cracking. “The office is to the left. Please.” Her silhouette against the daylight of the open door looks terrifyingly small, a figure in the mouth of a cave she knows holds a bear.

• • •

The office smells of mimeograph ink and damp wool, dominated by a desk of oak veneer peeling back to reveal the particle board beneath. On the surface, preserved in a stasis of neglect, sit the Skólanámskrá — the curriculum ledgers, bound in black oilcloth, the years painted on the spines in white correction fluid. He approaches as if it were an altar.

He pulls 1965. The hand is copperplate, severe and beautiful. *Week 42: Dative Declensions of Coastal Nouns. Focus on current and drift. Week 43: The Aflending (Unbinding). Usage in calm weather only.* The grammar is complete, the lessons practical and integrated, the teacher’s notes mundane. *Jónas struggles with the vocal length. Gudrún is excellent.*

He reaches for 1978. The hand has changed — hurried, slanted. *Week 42: Common Coastal Terms. Standard Icelandic Forms. Note from Ministry: Ritual*

cases designated Archaic/Folklore. To be moved to supplementary reading. Not for examination. A red pen has struck out Aflending. In the margin, a different hand: Hard to explain to parents. Dropped.

He opens 1982. Stiffer pages, standardized curriculum. *Week 12: Modern Icelandic Syntax. The Passive Voice. Note: Remove reference to Sæfangi. Confuses the students regarding subject-object relationships with inanimate nature.* And then the margins begin to speak. In 1965 they were blank. In 1982 they are crowded. *Oct 14: Windows rattled all lecture. Hard to hear. Nov 2: Roof leak in north corridor. Wind is loud. Nov 10: Fog inside the vestibule again.*

He arranges the books in a chronological arc across the dusty desk and pulls the last, 1991. The curriculum is clean, modern, safe; Vikamál reduced to a single hour of “Local Heritage,” the grammar drills gone. And the margins are screaming. *Sept 4: Storm took the playground fence. Sept 12: Damp is ruining the books. The ink runs. Oct 1: Cannot keep the classroom warm. The draught speaks. Oct 20: Stopped the lesson. The noise was too much.* He runs his finger down the page. The correlation is linear. The week the Hrimfall was struck from the plan — a heavy black *OMIT* — the margin note three days later reads: *Boiler failure. Frost inside the walls. Pipes burst.*

“It tracks,” he whispers. “The erosion isn’t only cultural. It’s physical.”

Sigrún grips the doorframe, white-knuckled, her other hand picking at a loose thread on her cuff, a darker grey than the wool, unravelling with each twitch. “They wanted modernization,” she says, thin and reedy. “They wanted the children to get jobs in Reykjavík. To speak like people on the television.”

His finger rests on an entry from 1988. *Sea water in the basement. Source unknown.* “Sigrún. Look at the dates. Every time a form was removed, the building took damage. Did no one see it?”

She looks at the ledger, then away, to a calendar still turned to November 1994. “We saw the weather. We thought it was the climate changing. We thought it was bad luck.”

“But it’s one-to-one. Here. You stopped teaching the containment forms for the tide in March eighty-nine. The quay flooded in April.”

“It was a wet spring.” She pulls the thread. It snaps.

Rowan hears the academic in his own skull reciting its catechism. *Correlation is not causation.* The teachers, stripped of a cultural identity, projected anxiety onto the weather; they noticed the storms because they felt exposed; a psychosomatic loop. He has spent his career building rooms like that, rooms with a locked interpretation, so that nothing gets in that he has not first labelled. But his finger rests on a note from 1993, in a shaking hand: *I can no longer teach the words. When I say them, the windows crack.* He closes the book. The dust puffs up in a small dry cloud.

“Let’s look at the classroom,” he says.

Sigrún does not move. She stares at the desk as if the books are radioactive. “Yes,” she says. “The classroom is where we finished it.”

• • •

The classroom is a box of grey light. The west windows face the bay but the salt spray has rendered them a cataract. Rows of desks sit in strict formation, laminate scarred by generations of bored carving — initials, hearts, crude ships. Rowan sits at the teacher’s desk on its small dais; Sigrún takes a student chair in the front row. The difference in height makes him uncomfortable, re-enacting a dynamic he does not want. Behind him the chalkboard is a landscape of erased equations and sentence diagrams, faint white ghosts of letters clinging to the slate, wiped but not gone.

“The ledger said you were head teacher in the final years.”

She has unwound her scarf. Her face is pale, the lines around her mouth cut deep. She looks not at him but at the blank of the blackboard. “I signed the orders.”

“The Ministry sent the directives. You had to comply.”

“The Ministry sent paper.” She clasps her hands in her lap. “I did the teaching.”

The wind thuds against the glass. “Why did you stop? Really. You knew the forms. You knew their history. You could have kept them as oral tradition, off the exam.”

She laughs, dry and brittle. “History. Tradition.” She shakes her head. “You think of it as heritage, Dr. Hale. Something to put in a case in a museum.” She looks at the empty chair beside her. “They asked me,” she whispers.

“The Ministry?”

“The children. Twelve years old. Sharp. Modern. Satellite television. Science textbooks that explained the tides were the moon’s gravity, not the breath of a giant.” She leans forward, her eyes wet but not weeping, reliving a specific defeat. “I would put the *Sæfangi* on the board. *Hafinu* — to the sea. *Hafsins* — of the sea. And then the ritual form, *Sævangur*. And a hand would go up. ‘Teacher, why do we use that one? It doesn’t follow the rules. It makes the sentence longer. What does it do?’ ” She spreads her hands. “What could I tell them? Could I say, ‘If you don’t use this suffix, the water will come into your bedroom’? They would laugh. They would tell their parents I was teaching ghost stories. I was a modernized educator, Rowan. I had a degree from Reykjavík.”

She looks at her hands. “So I lied. I told them it was just an old way of speaking. Poetic. Optional.”

“And then?”

“And then they asked, ‘If it’s optional, why do we have to learn it? It’s hard. It’s boring.’ ” She slumps, the energy leaving her. “And I didn’t have an answer. Not

a modern one. So I stopped. I stopped because I was tired of trying to explain a lock they couldn't see to children who only believed in keys they could hold."

"Was it one child?" Rowan asks. "Or the room."

Sigrún is quiet long enough that he thinks she has not heard.

"Ásdís Helgadóttir," she says. "Second row, by the radiator, because she felt the cold."

She says the name the way one produces a document from a drawer one visits often.

"She was not a difficult girl. That is the thing people always assume — that it was some clever awful child who liked to catch teachers out. She was kind. She was a serious child, and serious children ask the serious question, and the serious question was: *Miss, if it worked, wouldn't somebody outside know?*"

The wind pushes at the window.

"I want you to understand how good that question is," Sigrún says. "I have had thirty-one years to find a flaw in it and there is not one. If the forms hold the water back, then Reykjavík would know. The university would know. Somebody would have measured it. There would be a paper, and a grant, and men in coats." A short breath. "And I stood in front of twenty-two children and I could not tell her the true answer, which is that they *did* know, once, in six places on this coast, and that five of them stopped, and that we have all the evidence anyone could want and it is a hundred and fifty years of nothing happening here and things happening elsewhere, and that no method on earth can turn that into a proof."

"What did you tell her?"

"I told her it was a very good question." Sigrún's mouth twists. "Which is what a teacher says when she has lost."

"Where is she now? Ásdís."

"Reykjavík. She is a radiographer." The twist becomes almost a smile, and it is terrible. "She comes at Easter. She is a lovely woman. She brings her children and they run about on the slipway and she has no idea, none at all, that she is the reason, and I would sooner cut my hand off than tell her." Her hands tighten in her lap. "It was not her fault. She was eleven. She asked the only question there was."

Rowan stares at her, and it is the banality of it that lands. The defence of the village was not dismantled by a cult or a monster. It was dismantled by pedagogical convenience, by the exhaustion of a teacher facing a room of bored children asking *is this on the test*. And under that, quieter, a recognition that turns his stomach: this is precisely how his mother's history was lost. Not to catastrophe. To the small daily refusal to explain a thing that cost too much to say plainly. She, too, had decided that some grammar was better dropped than defended in front of a child who would only ask what it was for.

"You removed the grammar," he says, "to save yourself the embarrassment of explaining it."

“I removed it,” she says, “because I couldn’t bear to teach them a language I wasn’t allowed to tell the truth about.”

She looks up at the chalkboard, and for a moment Rowan thinks she sees something written there. “And now,” she whispers, “the weather asks the questions. And no one knows the answers.” He wants to tell her it was not her fault. But the deficit is absolute, and he has spent his life learning that some silences are the only honest response, and he keeps this one. The only sound in the room is the wind, which is no longer whistling. It is listening.

• • •

They exit into a silence that feels stunned, the wind dropped, a vacuum pressing on the eardrums, the grey afternoon flattened of depth. He feels a desperate need to catalogue the confession before it evaporates, and reaches for his notebook.

“Dr. Hale.” Sharp. She is five meters off, staring at the ground near the north wall’s foundation. There is a pool of water there. When they entered, the ground was dry — frozen scree, dead heather. Now a depression is filled with dark glassy water, a perfect circle a meter across, sitting in the earth like a lens dropped from a telescope.

“Where did this come from?” He crouches. “A burst pipe?”

“Don’t touch it,” Sigrún says, backing away.

He leans over. The surface is unnervingly still — no tremor, no ripple. It reflects the grey sky, the basalt wall, his own face. He stares at his reflection. The reflection stares back. Then the reflection blinks. Rowan has not blinked. He freezes. The face in the pool shifts, the mouth opening slightly as if about to speak, the water perfectly flat while the image inside it moves independently of the source. The reflection’s eyes drift left, toward the village. Vertigo, the earth tilting. The pool is not reflecting him; it is observing him. On the surface a film of oil or dust coalesces into lines, curves — genitive markers. The water is trying to spell *Min*—

“Sigrún?” He turns. She is walking away, rigid, frantic, hands pressed over her ears. As she passes the corner she speaks — not a scream, a mutter into her collar. “*Vatnið heldur... vatnið þegir... engin orð... engin nöfn*—” *The water holds. The water is silent. No words. No names.*

The syllables hit him like a pressure change in a descending cabin. His ears pop. A high whine drills into his skull, instant and painful. The air around the pool vibrates, blurring the sight. He looks back and for a second the reflection is gone; the pool is just dirty water in a hole. But the silence has broken. The sound of the sea, distant and heavy, comes crashing back into the world. He scrambles up, backing away from the circle, heart hammering, and runs after her, leaving the schoolhouse and its new unblinking eye to watch the empty moor.

He catches her at the foot of the path. She is not running now. She has stopped at the cairn marking the schoolhouse boundary — a waist-high stack of basalt, each stone placed by some predecessor whose name is not on it. She is breathing through her teeth, her hands shaking so the keychain rattles in her pocket.

“Give me your notebook,” she says.

He hesitates — Cambridge instinct, the document is the proof — then hands it over. She does not open it. She turns to the page she knows is there: his transcript of her confession, the columns of dates and amputated suffixes, the line where he wrote her name at the top. *Sigrún Ásgeirsdóttir, head teacher, 1989–94*. Below it the dotted line he prepared for her signature. She holds the pen out, and for a moment he thinks she means to sign. She does not. She tears the page out cleanly, along the perforation. She does not crumple it; that would still be an object. She folds it twice, kneels at the cairn, slides it into the gap between two stones at the base, and seats a fist-sized rock across the gap. The page is gone. No one will read it. The cairn now holds a name that was almost spoken aloud.

“You don’t write it,” she says. “Not with my hand on the page. The eye looks for signatures. Don’t feed it mine.” She hands the notebook back. The remaining pages feel lighter than they should. “You should burn the recorder,” she adds, calmer now. “You won’t. So at least don’t play it back here.” She walks the rest of the way down alone, slower, picking her steps as if the path were something she has just renegotiated.

• • •

The community hall is a bunker of light against the gathering dark. Inside, the air is thick with wet wool, strong coffee, and the metallic tang of fresh blood. Yellow lamps cast a jaundiced glow over the long tables where the day’s work is being finished. He enters still shaking from the schoolhouse, needing normalization, needing to see ordinary people at ordinary things. He finds them. Twelve villagers stand around the central table, sorting the catch. Metal bins in a row. Fish sliding across the gutting table — cod, haddock, pollack. Knives flashing wet and efficient. Slit, gut, slide.

He nods to Arnar, who is sharpening a fillet knife with a rhythmic shhh-shhh against a stone. Arnar nods back, eyes on the blade. “Good catch?” Rowan asks.

“Variable,” Arnar says. Not *the sea gave us a lot*. “The volume is high.”

A woman at the end of the table picks up a haddock and turns it over. Rowan stares. The fish has two dorsal fins — not side by side, stacked, one perfectly replicating the other, as if the noun had been pluralized by mistake. The woman does not gasp. She clicks her tongue — mild annoyance, like finding a bruise on an apple — and tosses it into a red bin marked with a black X. “Too many doubles today. The count is off.”

He looks into the red bin. It is a charnel house of grammatical errors. A cod whose scales run backward, tail to head. A flounder gone perfectly spherical, swollen with fluid. And on top, a large grey pollock, its mouth open. He grips the edge of the table. The teeth in its jaw are not needle-sharp piscine teeth. They are flat, white, rectangular. Human molars.

Bile rises in his throat. “That—” He points, his finger trembling. “That fish has human teeth.”

The table does not stop. A knife comes down, severing a head. Thwack. An older fisherman, his face a map of broken capillaries, wipes a bloody hand on his apron and looks at the fish, then at Rowan. “The sea gives back what it remembers.” He says it the way one says *the postman brings the mail*. A statement of logistics.

“But that’s—it’s a biological impossibility. It’s mutation. You have to report this. The environmental agency—”

“We sort,” the woman interrupts, lifting the pollock by the tail without looking at the teeth. “We burn the ones that remember too much. We eat the ones that are quiet.” She drops it into a smaller bucket by the door with a heavy dull thud.

No one is horrified. They are resigned, checking gills, eyes, fins, quality-controlling a reality that is coming apart at the seams. He listens to their low talk. *The west side brought the heavy ones. The drift was full of echoes. This one is mis-set. Burn it.* They never say *caught*. They never say *ocean*. They never say *monsters*. The horror is not in the bin. The horror is the lack of surprise. The village has adapted. Without the grammar to hold the boundary, the definitions of species have gone porous, and they are filtering the sea’s nightmares out of their food supply, one fish at a time.

He steps back, away from the blood and brine, and watches Arnar slide a knife into a cod, opening it to see whether the inside is written in the language of fish or in something else. And Rowan knows, with a quiet sickening certainty, that he can no longer only observe. The schoolhouse is open. The sea is sending its memories back to be eaten. And somewhere under all of it, unwatched, is the recognition that he did not come here to study any of this — that he came carrying a sealed envelope and a photograph of a black coast, and that the debt he is standing in the middle of has his own name somewhere on the ledger.

IX



The list goes up on the hall wall at six in the morning and Rowan's name is on it.

He has come early because he assumed there would be a beginning — a gathering, an announcement, some point at which the day is declared to have started — and there is not. There is a hall with the lights on and the urns already going and forty people in work clothes reading a sheet of A4, and the sheet has been typed on a computer, badly, in a font somebody chose in about 2004, and it is headed *FJÓRÐI LAUGARDAGUR* and then the date.

Two columns. Names on the left. Tasks on the right.

Hale, R. — north wall w/ Ingi & Steinunn.

He reads it three times. Nobody has mentioned this to him. Nobody has asked whether he is free, or whether he would like to help, or whether a visiting academic would prefer to observe; he has simply been put on the list between Guðjón and Halla, in alphabetical order, in the same font as everyone else. He is aware of a feeling in his chest that he does not immediately identify, and it takes him most of the walk to the north wall to recognise it as the specific warm foolish pleasure of being picked for a team.

He does not, at any point that day, examine what it means that he did not have to be asked.

• • •

The sisters are at opposite ends of the village.

He works this out at about half past seven, in the way one works out a piece of local physics, by noticing an absence. Guðrún Sigurjónsdóttir is on the north wall with him; Kristín Sigurjónsdóttir is, per the sheet, on the roof detail at the curing house, which is nine hundred metres away and around a headland. He mentions it

to Steinunn, who is seventy and has hands like a bundle of dry sticks and who is currently outworking him three stones to one.

“Mm,” says Steinunn.

“Is that deliberate?”

“It’s the list.” Steinunn seats a stone, sights along the course, and takes it out again. “It has been the list since two thousand and nine.”

“What happened in two thousand and nine?”

“A mooring.” She sets the stone back, differently. “I do not have an opinion.” A pause of perhaps four seconds. “Kristín was wrong.”

Rowan laughs before he can stop himself, and Steinunn’s face does not change at all, and he understands that he has been given something.

• • •

The north wall is a dry-stone field boundary a hundred and forty metres long and it is, Rowan discovers over the following four hours, an absolute bastard.

There is no mortar. There is no cheating. Each stone has one orientation in which it will sit and forty in which it will not, and the difference between a course that will stand for sixty years and a course that will come down in March is invisible to him and apparently obvious to everyone else. Ingi — forty-ish, enormous, a man built like a door — watches him wrestle a block for two minutes and then reaches over and turns it ninety degrees and it drops into the gap with a small final click, like a word arriving in the right case.

“Ah,” says Rowan.

“You will get it,” Ingi says, which is generous and untrue, and goes back to his own section.

By nine his back has opinions. By ten his hands have split at the knuckles in two places and he has stopped noticing. The wind is coming off the water in long cold pushes and the work is warm and stupid and entirely absorbing and he has not thought about morphology, or his mother, or the tin, since about a quarter past seven.

They talk while they work. Not about the wall.

The talk is about quota, which is a disaster; about the price of diesel, which is a scandal; about a man in Húsavík who sold Ingi a winch; about whether the school bus should be made to wait the extra four minutes at the junction, which is apparently a live constitutional question in this village and on which Steinunn holds views of some force. Somebody’s daughter has got into a programme in Akureyri. Somebody’s boat needs a gearbox. There is a long, detailed, and to Rowan completely opaque account of a dispute about a fence in 1998 which ends with Ingi saying “and that is why we do not ask Þórarinn about fences,” and both women nodding as at a settled point of law.

At eleven a boy comes along the wall with a thermos and a bag of kleinur, distributing them to the work parties with the self-importance of an appointed official, which he is; his name is on the list too, near the bottom, *Kári* — *kaffi*, *allar sveitir*.

He is nine. He has a cowlick that will not lie down and a card trick he performs for Rowan while the adults drink, which does not work. He performs it again more slowly. It does not work again.

“That is the best one I have seen today,” Rowan says.

“It works at home,” says *Kári*, unbothered, and moves on down the wall with his thermos.

• • •

At noon they eat in the hall, all of them, at trestle tables, and it is the loudest room Rowan has been in since Reykjavík.

There is lamb soup and rye bread and butter and a vat of coffee, and there are dogs under the tables, and someone has brought a cake because it is Ólöf Magnúsdóttir’s sixtieth and the cake says so in wobbling blue icing. Ólöf is made to stand up. Ólöf does not want to stand up. Ólöf is made to stand up anyway, and a version of the birthday song is sung with what Rowan can only describe as aggressive incompetence, four different keys and at least two different sets of words, and Ólöf sits down going red and pleased and immediately begins criticising the cake.

Rowan sits between Ingi and a woman whose name he does not catch and eats two bowls of soup and is asked, at length and with genuine curiosity, about English weather, English house prices, and whether it is true that in England you must pay to see a doctor. He explains the National Health Service. There is a general and forceful opinion about America. Someone wants to know if he is married and he says no and the follow-up question does not come, and he notices the follow-up question not coming, and is grateful.

Across the hall Sigrún sits with her soup untouched, wrapped in the grey scarf, watching the room.

Their eyes meet once. She looks away first.

• • •

After the meal he is reassigned. The sheet has a second column for the afternoon and he is now *Hale, R.* — *afritun*, which he has to ask about, and which turns out to mean the back room.

Four people sit at a table under a strip light with a stack of paper between them, copying.

They are copying by hand. There is a photocopier in the corner of the room with a cover over it, plugged in, working; Rowan checks later, and it works. What they are doing is transcribing — from soft old notebooks and loose sheets and two things that are unmistakably nineteenth-century — onto new lined A4, in ballpoint, slowly, checking each other's lines.

And they are not throwing the old ones away. The old ones go into a second stack, squared, in order.

"What happens to those?" Rowan asks.

"They go in the cupboard."

"With the others?"

"With the others."

He looks at the cupboard, which is an ordinary steel-doored office cupboard, and he thinks about how many fourth Saturdays there have been since 2004, when this photocopier was presumably bought, and about how many there have been since ballpoint, and paper, and the hall.

"Can I ask why you don't photocopy them?"

He asks it lightly, of the table generally, and he gets four answers.

Guðjón, who is sixty and does not look up: "The machine does not make a copy. It makes a picture of a copy."

The woman opposite Guðjón, without hesitation and slightly impatiently, as though the question were a bit slow: "Because then nobody has read it."

The young man at the end, who is perhaps twenty-five and whose handwriting is the neatest at the table: "I don't know. This is how we do it." He shrugs, entirely without embarrassment. "It's four hours."

And Halla Kristjánsdóttir, at the head of the table, who does look up, and who considers Rowan for a moment over her glasses: "Because the hand has to go the same way the hand went."

Rowan waits. Nobody amends anyone. Nobody says *well, what Halla means is*. Four mutually incompatible accounts of the same practice have been laid on the table and all four of them are apparently fine, and the copying continues, and someone asks whether there is more coffee.

He picks up a pen and is handed a notebook, and copies for two and a half hours, and finds — to his considerable irritation — that the woman opposite Guðjón was right. He has read every word. He could not have told you a line of it if he had photographed it.

Monthly communal maintenance. Universal participation, allocated in writing, no exemptions observed — including for the visiting researcher, who was rostered without consultation and did not think to object.

Manual transcription of textual material, retention of superseded copies. Four informants, four incompatible rationales, no observable discomfort

at the incompatibility. Cf. orthodox practice in most literate ritual traditions, where the explanation is precisely the part that is not standardised, because it is not the part that is being transmitted.

The practice is the transmission. The reasons are decoration, and the village knows it, and I am the only person in this room who needed to ask.

• • •

The boundary stones are last, and they are done in an order, and the order is not geographical.

Rowan works this out following a party of nine up the eastern slope in the failing light. They do not walk the perimeter as a perimeter; they go to the third stone, then the first, then the seventh, then the fourth, in a sequence that everybody knows and nobody consults a list for, and when he asks Ingi why, Ingi says “that is the order,” which by now Rowan has learned to hear as a complete answer.

At each stone: clear the growth back a hand’s width. Check the set with a boot. Repack if it has lifted. Somebody says a short thing — four or five syllables, flat, unceremonious, in the local grammar, delivered in the tone of a man reading out a serial number. Then the next stone.

The children come. That is the part Rowan does not expect. The whole afternoon’s children, six or seven of them, are up on the slope in the cold with the adults, and they are not being minded; they are being included, in the specific way that means somebody has decided which child is old enough for which stone.

At the north gatepost, Kári is put in front.

His grandmother stands behind him — Halla, out of the copying room now and up the hill in a coat like a tent — and she puts her hand over his hand on the cold stone, and says the form once, and waits.

Kári says it. He gets the ending wrong.

“Again.”

He gets it wrong the same way.

Halla does not correct the word. She moves his hand slightly on the stone, an inch to the left, and says the form again herself, and this time when Kári repeats it, it is right, and Rowan — standing four metres off in the wind with his hands in his armpits — understands that he has just watched a case ending taught as a physical location. Not *say it like this. Stand here and it will be like this.*

“Góður,” says Halla. Good.

Kári goes scarlet to the ears and turns away fast and pretends to be extremely interested in the fence.

Rowan writes nothing down. He is not sure, afterwards, whether that was respect or whether he simply did not want to be a man with a notebook in that par-

ticular minute.

• • •

The eleventh stone is on the western spur, and when they reach it they do the growth and the set and the repacking, and then they stand for a second, and then they move on.

Rowan is three paces past it before it registers.

He stops. He looks back at the stone, and at the party going on ahead of him in the dusk, and he counts back through the afternoon — third, first, seventh, fourth, ninth, second, and so on, ten stones, ten short flat unceremonious things said in ten places — and at the eleventh nobody said anything at all.

He catches up to Ingi. “The last one.”

“Mm.”

“Nobody spoke.”

“No.” Ingi keeps walking.

“Is there — ” Rowan picks his way, because he has been here long enough now to know that the wrong question closes a door for a month. “Does that one not take a form?”

“It takes one.” Ingi steps over a rill. “We do the stone.”

“But not the form.”

“Not that one.” And then, because Ingi is a kind man and can hear that Rowan is not being a journalist: “Nobody has it. Þórunn had it. She died in — ” he thinks, “— ninety-one? Ninety-two.” A shrug that is not indifference; it is the shrug of a man discussing a part that is no longer manufactured. “So we do the stone.”

“And that’s — all right?”

Ingi considers this seriously, walking, for about ten metres.

“The stone is most of it,” he says.

Rowan looks back once more. In the last of the light the eleventh stone is indistinguishable from the other ten: cleared, checked, repacked, sitting exactly where it should sit, maintained to a standard that would satisfy any inspector in Europe. There is nothing wrong with it. There is nothing wrong with any of it. Forty people have spent eleven hours doing careful, skilled, unpaid, uncomplaining work on a village that they are keeping in excellent order.

And a woman died in ninety-one or ninety-two — nobody on this hill can tell him which, and it does not appear to matter to any of them — and took four syllables with her, and the village noted it, and adjusted, and did not stop, and has been doing the stone without the form for thirty-four years, and there is not a person on this hill under the age of fifty who has ever heard the eleventh stone spoken to.

Sigrún is at the back of the party, twenty metres down the slope, not climbing

well. She has stopped, and she is looking up at him, and she has seen exactly which stone he is standing next to.

Neither of them says anything. There is nothing to say that either of them does not already know, and they both have the discipline for it now, and that shared discipline is the most intimate thing that has passed between them since the school-house.

She turns and starts down. After a moment, so does he.

• • •

There is coffee in the hall afterwards, and there is a great deal of it.

The urns come back out. The *kleinur* reappear. The dogs, who have had an outstanding day, lie flat under the tables like dropped coats. Somebody has put the radio on. Ólöf's cake is finished, aggressively, by committee. There is an argument at the next table about the gearbox which appears to have been running since roughly lunchtime and which both parties are visibly enjoying.

Séra Hjálmar comes in at seven with paint on his hands and paint in his eyebrows, having spent the whole day on a ladder doing the hall's south elevation, and is heckled about the colour. He defends the colour. The colour is, Rowan gathers, the same colour it has been for forty years, and the heckling is also the same, and the pastor's defence of it is word-for-word the defence he mounts every year, and everyone including the pastor knows this, and it is done with great relish on all sides.

"Dr. Hale." Hjálmar drops onto the bench opposite with a mug. "They put you on the wall."

"They put me on the wall."

"How are the hands?"

Rowan turns them over. Hjálmar laughs — a real one, loud, from the chest — and Rowan finds that he is laughing too, properly, for the first time in he does not want to calculate how long, at nothing, at the state of his own hands, in a hot noisy room that smells of wet wool and coffee and paint.

It is the happiest he has been in eight months.

He is aware of it while it is happening. That is the part he will come back to, later, on the rock, in other weather. He is aware of it while it is happening — that he is sitting in a hall in a village of a hundred and thirteen people at the end of a road that maps disagree about, with his hands wrecked and his back seized and a name typed on a list on the wall in a font somebody chose in 2004, and that he is happy, and that nobody in the room requires anything of him except that he pass the milk.

• • •

He walks back to the Annex at nine with Kári's grandmother's voice still somewhere in his ear.

The night is clear and enormous and the cold has real teeth in it now. Below him the village is lit up in patches, the hall windows yellow, a few kitchens, the pastor's ladder still against the south wall because he will do the second coat tomorrow. From up here the whole place could be held in two hands.

He is tired in a way he has not been tired in years. His shoulders have stopped being shoulders. He is going to sleep for nine hours and wake up unable to move.

And somewhere on the climb, without deciding to, he starts going back over the day the way he goes over an interview, and he arrives, near the top, at the thing that has been sitting under all of it.

Nobody said any of the words.

Not one. In eleven hours, across forty people and two meals and a hill in the dark, nobody said *tradition*. Nobody said *custom* or *heritage* or *the old ways*. Nobody said *ritual* — not ironically, not defensively, not once. Nobody explained anything to anybody. No adult took a child aside and told it why. He has done fieldwork in eleven communities and in every single one of them somebody found him within the first hour and started explaining the culture to him, proudly or apologetically or with an eye on the recorder, and here he has spent an entire day inside the thing and not one person has described it, because there is nothing to describe; there is a list on a wall and a wall on a hill and a stone that gets cleared and checked and repacked, and four hours of copying, and a birthday cake.

He stops on the path with his breath going white.

The list. *Fjórði laugardagur*. Forty people, every month, for as long as anyone can name — and he thinks, with the particular chill of a man doing arithmetic he was not looking for, about what a village would have to be maintaining to justify eleven hours a month, every month, for three hundred years, from every single adult, without exemption, without complaint, and without anyone ever once being told what it was for.

Then he thinks about the eleventh stone.

He stands there for a while in the dark, above the yellow windows, with his ruined hands in his pockets.

Then he goes in, and eats bread and butter standing at the counter because he cannot face cooking, and sleeps for nine hours, and wakes up unable to move.

X



The maps are the only thing in Brynjavík that anyone has ever tried to explain to him.

He notices it on the Sunday, climbing the hall steps very slowly, with three folded sheets under his arm and a back that has strong opinions about yesterday, and the noticing has an edge on it that it did not have a week ago. Eleven hours on a hill and nobody described anything. Two minutes in Thorsteinn's office on his first evening and the man was already explaining — subsidence, erosion, other things, the whole apparatus of causal account, offered unprompted to a stranger who had not asked.

Rowan had taken it, at the time, for administrative courtesy.

He is beginning to suspect it was loneliness.

• • •

“Hale.” Thorsteinn does not look up. “Sit. Move the folder.”

The office is warm and smells of the same cleaning solution, and it is, Rowan sees now, the only room in the village organised on principles he recognises. Box files labelled on the spine in a consistent hand. A wall planner. A stapler in a drawer with other staplers. It is the office of a competent man in his forties who is, by any standard the outside world would apply, extremely good at his job, and who has not had a promotion in sixteen years because there is nowhere for him to be promoted to.

Rowan puts the three sheets on the desk and unfolds them, one over another, and does not say anything.

Thorsteinn looks at them for perhaps four seconds.

Then he says: “Which figures.”

“Population. And the connector road.”

“One-one-three, ninety-six, forty-one.” He says the numbers the way a man says his own telephone number. “And the road is solid, dashed, and absent.” He puts down his pen. He is, Rowan realises, not surprised at all; he is something much worse, which is pleased. “You went to the map shop on Bankastræti.”

“I did.”

“Everyone goes to the map shop on Bankastræti.” He stands and crosses to a filing cabinet, and it is not a dramatic movement, but there is a quality of appetite in it, of a man reaching for something he has been waiting a long time to hand to somebody. He comes back with a lever-arch file four inches thick and drops it on the desk between them.

The label on the spine says *KORT — FRÁVIK*.

Maps. Discrepancies.

• • •

There are three hundred and eleven entries and they go back to 2011.

They are on a form. Thorsteinn made the form. It has fields: source document, publication date, publishing body, feature, expected value, observed value, first noted, re-checked, notified, response. The handwriting in the early entries is round and rather generous. By about 2016 it has tightened. In the last two years it is small and upright and extremely regular, the hand of a man who has decided that his handwriting is one of the things he can still control.

“Start at the tabs,” Thorsteinn says. “The tabs are the ones I have been able to get an answer on.”

There are nine tabs.

Rowan reads for forty minutes and Thorsteinn lets him, and makes coffee, and does not hover, and it is the most professional courtesy he has been shown by anyone in Iceland.

The file is superb. That is the thing that keeps arriving. It is genuinely, unambiguously superb — the observations are dated, the sources are cited to edition and printing, the re-checks are performed at intervals and logged, the negative results are recorded as carefully as the positive ones. There are photographs, numbered, cross-referenced. There are two entries where Thorsteinn has written, in the response field, *my error — misread scale bar*, and left the entry in.

Rowan has sat on three funding panels. He would have funded this.

Entry 44. District sheet, 1987 impression. Connector road from the pass: not shown. Expected: shown. Observed: absent. Notified: National Land Survey, 2012. Response, 2013: *thank you for your correspondence; the 1987 sheet is superseded and no correction will be issued to a withdrawn impression.*

Entry 45. Query to district roads office: date of construction, connector road. Response: no construction recorded 1970–2003. Re-queried 2014, 2017. Same response, twice, from two different officials.

Entry 46. Query to district roads office: if not constructed, when first maintained? Response: resurfacing budget lines exist continuously from 1961.

Rowan puts his finger on that one.

“They resurfaced a road that was never built.”

“For fifty years.” Thorsteinn sits back. “Every year. There is a figure. It is a small figure and it is in the accounts and nobody has ever queried it except me.”

“What did they say when you queried it?”

“That it is a legacy line and the coding predates the current system.” He says this without bitterness, which is somehow worse. “Which is true. It does predate the current system. Everything here predates the current system.”

• • •

Tab six is the stake.

Entry 208. Kilometre marker 47, connector road. Surveyed position established by GPS 14/05/2019, cross-checked against 1:50,000 sheet and against the 1961 alignment plan. Stake set 14/05/2019.

Entry 209. 22/05/2019. Stake found 780 m south of set position. No disturbance to ground at set position. No drag marks. Ground at new position undisturbed except by stake.

Entry 211. Re-set 23/05/2019, concrete collar.

Entry 214. 09/06/2019. Stake found 810 m south of set position. Concrete collar found at set position, intact, empty.

Rowan reads that twice. *Intact, empty.*

“I photographed it,” Thorsteinn says. “Photograph two-two-one. The collar is intact. You cannot pull a stake out of a set collar without breaking the collar or the stake. The stake is also intact. It is eight hundred metres away in undisturbed ground.”

“What did you conclude?”

“That somebody in this village is very good at concrete.” He shrugs. “I did consider it seriously. There are perhaps four men here who could do it. It would take a night and a mixer and a reason, and I have never been able to find the reason, because it does not benefit anybody. The stake is not a boundary. It is not planning. It is a distance marker on a road with nine vehicles on it.”

“And the third time?”

“The third time I reported it.” Something in his face closes. “An inspector came from Akureyri in September. A good man. Thorough. He spent two days.

He found the stake at kilometre forty-seven, correctly positioned, in a sound collar, and he measured it three times, and he wrote a report which said that the marker was correctly positioned and that the reporting officer might be under strain.”

Rowan says nothing.

“It was not correctly positioned,” Thorsteinn says. “I measured it myself the morning he left. It was eight hundred metres south.” He turns his coffee cup a quarter turn on the desk. “That is in the file too. Entry two-two-six. I wrote it down and I did not notify anybody, and that is the last entry I notified anybody about. There are eighty- five entries since.”

• • •

They walk down to the harbour at three because Thorsteinn wants to show him the tide gauge, and on the way, without any particular ceremony, he gives Rowan his history.

Hafnarfjörður. A two-year contract in 2009, taken because there were no jobs and because it was a two-year contract. He met Vigdís in the second month, which is a thing that happens, and married her in the second year, which is a thing that happens less.

“And she is not here,” Rowan says.

“She is in Egilsstaðir. She has a boy who is eleven and is not mine and that is entirely all right.” He says it evenly, and Rowan believes the evenness about eighty per cent. “She left in 2016.”

“Can I ask why?”

Thorsteinn walks a few paces.

“Because I would not learn it,” he says.

It is the first crack. It is a hairline.

“The speech?”

“She tried for three years. Her mother tried. They are patient people about this, you will have noticed — they do not push, they do not lecture, they simply keep leaving the door open, month after month, and it is unbearable.” He puts his hands in his pockets. “I have Icelandic. I have good Icelandic. I run this district in Icelandic. And they wanted me to sit in a kitchen at forty years old and be taught to say a word wrong on purpose.”

“That’s not quite what it is.”

“I know what it is.” Sharp, and then immediately regretted; he lifts a hand. “Forgive me. I know what it is. It is a dialect with an unusual case system and a body of oral formulae, and it is interesting, and you are the right man to write about it and I hope you do.” He stops at the top of the harbour steps. “What I would not do is pretend that saying it correctly keeps the water out. Because that is

what she wanted. Not the words. She did not care about the words. She wanted me to *believe* it, and I would not, and after seven years that turns out to be the whole marriage.”

The bay below them is grey and flat and perfectly ordinary.

“I do not think she was stupid,” Thorsteinn says. “I want to be clear about that. She is the least stupid person I have ever met. She has a master’s degree.”

• • •

The tide gauge is bolted to the harbour wall and it is a good one, and its record does not agree with the tide tables, and Thorsteinn has sixteen years of that too.

He shows Rowan the graphs on his phone, standing in the wind. The divergence is not random. It is not noise. It correlates with nothing meteorological — he has checked barometric pressure, wind fetch, the lot — and it is small, four or five centimetres, except on about nine occasions a year when it is not small at all.

“What’s on those nine days?”

“Nothing.” Thorsteinn puts the phone away. “I have been through the parish diary, the school calendar, the weather, the fishing log. There is no pattern. Some of them are funerals. Some of them are Tuesdays.”

Rowan thinks about a fourth Saturday and does not say it, and the not saying it is so easy, so smooth, so exactly the shape of every silence he has been trained to admire, that he stands in the cold with his ears ringing slightly.

He could tell him. It would take one sentence. *Cross-reference your nine days against the fourth Saturday of the month and against the turn of the year, and tell me what you get.* Thorsteinn would do it that night. He would do it properly, with the rigour of the best empiricist in the district, and by morning he would either have nothing — or he would have the thing he has been building toward for sixteen years, handed to him by an outsider, in a form he could not dismiss.

Rowan says: “It’s a good dataset.”

“It is a very good dataset,” Thorsteinn agrees, “of an effect that does not exist,” and laughs, briefly, and it is the worst sound Rowan has heard in Brynjavík.

• • •

He asks about the Keeping on the way back up, because he cannot not.

“Oh, I go.” Thorsteinn seems mildly surprised at the question. “I was on the roof at the curing house. Every month.”

“You do the work.”

“Of course I do the work. It is eleven hours of the entire adult population doing free maintenance on the public building stock.” He gestures at the hall as they pass

it, at the south elevation with its second coat drying. “Do you know what that is worth to a district budget of this size? I costed it. It is eleven million krónur a year of labour I do not have to find.” He almost smiles. “I would fight anybody who tried to stop it. It is the single most functional institution in this village and it is the only reason the fabric is still standing.”

“And the boundary stones?”

“The boundary stones are a folk custom and they take forty minutes and they keep the old people happy.” He holds the door. “I have no objection to folk custom. I have an objection to folk custom being cited at me in a planning meeting.”

Rowan goes through the door.

Sixteen years, he thinks. Three hundred and eleven entries. A tide gauge and a form he designed himself and a photograph of an intact empty collar. This man has assembled, alone, unfunded, and against active institutional discouragement, the most complete evidentiary record of the phenomenon that exists anywhere in the world — and he goes up on the roof every fourth Saturday and comes down again and files the paperwork, and in sixteen years the one connection he has never made is the one between the two halves of his own life.

He is doing the Keeping. He has been doing it the whole time, in a register that has no power in it: maintaining a boundary by documentation, month after month, meticulously, without exemption, because he cannot bear the alternative.

Rowan does not say this either.

• • •

The map comes out at half past four.

It is the erosion map, and it is three metres wide, and it goes on the long table with weights on the corners, and it is beautiful work. Thorsteinn has drawn it himself over two winters: the coastline at 1912, 1961, 1987, 2009, and now, in four colours, with the survey control marked and the sources keyed in a legend in the bottom right.

“The inspector is Tuesday,” he says. “It needs a quorum by then. Nine signatures.”

“How many have you got?”

“Four.” A pause. “Two of those are the Sigurjónsdóttir sisters, which took eleven days and cannot be repeated.”

He gets a pen out of the drawer. He does not push it across. He sets it down beside the map, which is worse.

“You have a doctorate,” he says. “You are on a national research grant. You have been here five weeks and you have walked every metre of that shoreline with a survey sheet in your hand, which I know because I have watched you do it.” He

straightens a weight that does not need straightening. “An independent academic signature is not a quorum signature. It is better. If a Cambridge linguist signs as an observing witness to the survey positions, the funding office in Akureyri stops treating this as a village complaint.”

Rowan looks at the map.

“It would be improper,” he says.

“It would be—”

“No, listen. I’m not being delicate.” He puts his hand flat on the table beside the coastline. “I’m not a surveyor. I have no qualification in geodesy or coastal process. If I sign that as a witness to survey positions and anybody in Akureyri looks up what I actually am, the document becomes weaker than it is now, not stronger. They will see a linguist certifying a landform survey and they will discount the whole file. Including your file. Including sixteen years.”

Thorsteinn is quiet.

“That is a good argument,” he says at last.

“It’s a true one.”

“I did not say it was not true.” He looks at Rowan with a directness that is entirely new, and Rowan understands that he has miscalculated, that this is the best-trained mind in the village and it has spent sixteen years learning to hear exactly this, the fluent correct unanswerable reason. “I said it was good. There is a difference and you know it better than anybody who has ever come here.”

The room is very quiet. Outside, gulls.

“Is there a second reason?” Thorsteinn asks.

And there it is, on the table, between the 1912 coastline and the 2009 one, and all Rowan has to do is pick it up.

The second reason is that he does not believe the map. Not the measurements — the measurements are impeccable. He does not believe the *premise*: that there is a line of any date, drawn in any colour, keyed to any control point, which describes where this coast ends, because he has stood on a hill and watched a village hold a boundary in place with eleven hours a month and a set of syllables, and he has watched them do the eleventh stone without the form and he knows what that will cost, and to put his name on a piece of paper asserting that the edge of Brynjavík is a measurable and stable feature of the physical world would be, at this point, a lie he can no longer tell.

Five weeks ago he would have signed it in a second and thought nothing.

“No,” Rowan says. “There’s no second reason.”

Thorsteinn nods slowly. He picks the pen up off the table and puts it back in the drawer, and closes the drawer.

“All right,” he says.

• • •

Rowan leaves at ten past five and stops in the corridor to put his coat on, and through the half-open door he can see Thorsteinn at the wall behind the desk, where the overlays are.

He has a fresh sheet of tracing paper. He is pinning it over the others — there are eleven or twelve under it now, the whole coastline in strata, each one a little further in — and he is squaring it up, and his hands are steady, and he takes a pencil and begins the new line along the top from the northern headland, working down, the way he has done every autumn for sixteen years.

Adding a layer. Nine signatures needed and four in hand and an inspector on Tuesday, and a man alone in an office at five in the evening drawing this year's edge over last year's edge over the edge before that, in a hand that will be smaller than last year's, and the whole stack getting thicker, and every single line on it correct, and not one of them holding anything.

Rowan buttons his coat and goes out into the dark.

He tells himself, on the path, that he was right. That he had no qualification and no standing and that a false signature would have done the man active harm. Every word of it is true and he assembles it carefully as he walks, the way he has assembled such things his whole life, and it holds all the way to the Annex door.

Then he thinks: *cross-reference the nine days*.

One sentence. He could have given him one sentence.

He stands with his hand on the latch for a while in the cold, and then he goes in and does not light the lamp.

XI



He spends the morning collecting hymnals, and tells himself it is fieldwork.

It is not difficult. The village lends books the way it lends salt — without ceremony and without asking why. He knocks on eleven doors between nine and one, and in every kitchen he is given coffee he does not want and a hymnal he does, and in most of them a child is sent to fetch it from wherever hymnals live, which is variously a dresser, a windowsill, and in one house a biscuit tin on top of a refrigerator. At Halla Kristjánsdóttir's he is fed dried fish and asked, at length and with real interest, whether it is true that in England the water comes out of the tap already warm. Kári has cracked the card trick since Saturday. It now works, twice, and the second time is better than the first, and he accepts Rowan's applause as no more than the settlement of an outstanding debt. On the wall behind him hangs a school photograph: fourteen children on the steps of a building in Húsavík, ninety minutes each way on the bus that comes at seven — the bus about which Steinunn, as the whole village is aware, holds views.

By afternoon he has eleven hymnals on the Annex table, spanning a hundred and six years of printings: Akureyri 1928, Reykjavík 1945, Reykjavík 1972, a 1991 reissue, two undated, one with a Danish imprimatur so old the paper has gone the colour of weak tea. Three different presses. Four different centuries of orthographic convention. Two of them were bought in Reykjavík within the last decade, by people who drove to the city and walked into a shop and paid for them off a shelf.

He opens them in sequence to page nine, or its equivalent, and lays them in a row.

Verði að þínum vilja.

Verði að þínum vilja.

Verði að þínum vilja.

Eleven for eleven. Including the two bought in the city, which cannot possibly

have left the press that way, and which he checks twice, and then a third time with the loupe, looking for the erasure, the scraped fibre, the pen-stroke, and finds nothing — the paper is undisturbed, the ink is press ink, the kerning is machine-set and correct for the longer line. These books were not altered after printing. They were printed like this. Books that were bought in a shop in Reykjavík, off a shelf, from a stack of identical books, and carried three hundred kilometres north, and opened here.

11/11. Presses: Akureyri, Reykjavík (×3 houses), Copenhagen (?), 4 unattributed. Span 1928–2019.

Local overprint. Someone in the parish orders a custom-run. — No. Two acquired retail, Reykjavík, 2014 and 2019, by Halla K. and by Þ. Sveinsson, independently, neither of whom has any reason to lie about where a hymn book came from and neither of whom found the question interesting.

I am misremembering the standard text. — No. Verified against my own recollection, against Sveinsson's account of hearing it said otherwise on the radio, and against the fact that Sveinsson, asked to recite it, produced the dative and then laughed and said that is not how they say it on the radio, is it, with the mild amusement of a man noting a regional word for a bread roll.

Remaining hypothesis, which I do not like: the alteration is not in the books.

He sits for a long time in the failing light with eleven open books in front of him, and does not write the next line, because the next line is that a text does not have to be edited if the coast will simply not permit the other reading to arrive intact — that the books came north in the nominative and were, somewhere along the road, declined.

He thinks of a fluorescent stake set eight hundred metres early. He thinks of a GPS pinning a village half a kilometre out to sea. He closes the books, one after another, and stacks them, and squares the stack, and finds that his hands want to align it parallel to the desk edge, and lets them.

• • •

The fluorescent tubes overhead hum with a frequency that scratches at the back of the skull. It is 19:00. The community hall is at capacity, though the capacity has shrunk with the years: a hundred and ten chairs in concentric semicircles facing a heavy oak lectern, set out from a stack that used to run to three hundred and now stops, unremarked, at a number nobody has had to reconsider in a decade. Outside the wind is a theoretical pressure against the north wall, muffled by the insulation

Thorsteinn commissioned three years ago against a cold that was never the real problem.

Rowan sits in the back row, notebook open on his knee, recording the ambient detail: the smell of damp wool drying in the heat, the scuff of boots on linoleum, the way the villagers hold their bodies, tight and contained, knees pressed together as if to minimize the air they displace. Thorsteinn stands at the lectern looking eroded, his jacket over the back of his chair, his shirt wrinkled at the elbows. He holds a sheaf of government forms — Relocation Grant Application, Form 4B — and a red pen, tapping it against the paper, dry and percussive.

“We need to finalize the zone definitions,” he says, his voice pitched slightly too high for authority. “The inspector arrives Tuesday. If the erosion map isn’t signed by a quorum, the funding for the retaining wall is frozen.”

A thick-set man in the second row clears his throat. “The line isn’t where the map says it is, Thorsteinn. The survey’s from July. The shingle has moved.”

“The survey is the legal document.” Thorsteinn runs a hand through his hair. “It doesn’t matter where the shingle is today. It matters where the surveyors put the stake. We just need to sign that we agree the stake exists.”

“But the stake is gone,” an older woman says from the corner, knitting something grey and endless, not looking up. “The tide took it on Thursday.”

He closes his eyes. “Then we assume it is still there. For the paperwork.”

Rowan watches the tension gather in the administrator’s shoulders. Here is a man trying to impose a grid on a fluid, to conjugate the village into a stable tense, and Rowan feels for him with an intimacy that surprises him, because he has spent his own life doing the same thing to a grief that would not sit still and let itself be surveyed.

“We cannot sign a lie,” the woman says. Her needles click. “To sign a lie is to invite a correction.”

“It is not a lie. It is bureaucracy. It is how we get the money to pour the concrete. Do you want the concrete, or do you want to keep watching the path fall into the—” He stops, catching the word before it slips. “—into the bay.” The room shifts, a rustle of coats. *Bay* is permitted, barely. A euphemism, a polite fiction.

An elderly fisherman stands near the front, leaning on a driftwood cane polished smooth by salt and palm-oil. Rowan recognizes him as the man who would not speak to him on the quay that first day. “The concrete will not hold,” the fisherman says, gravel rolling in a drum. “You are trying to bribe the winter with receipts. You are filing forms against hunger.”

“I am filing forms against the incompetence of the district planning office!” Thorsteinn shouts, and the outburst cracks the room’s controlled fatigue. He slams his hand on the lectern; the red pen jumps. “I am trying to keep the road open. To keep the power on. While you sit here and talk about hunger and correction and refuse to tell me where the water line is because you’re afraid of a grammar rule

from the nineteenth century!”

“It is not a rule,” the fisherman says, calm. “It is a negotiation. And you are shouting at the other side of the table.”

“There is no other side!” Thorsteinn steps out from behind the lectern, small against the vast dark map of the coastline pinned behind him. “There is us, and there is the physics of the North Atlantic, and that is all there is. Just because old women whisper to the fog does not mean the fog is listening.”

Rowan stops writing. The ink bleeds into the paper in a dark bloom. The air thins, as if the oxygen were being drawn quietly off.

“Sit down, Thorsteinn,” the knitting woman says. “You are tired. The tongue slips when the body is tired.”

“My tongue is fine.” He is shaking now — not with fear but with the vibration of a structure pushed past its rating. “I am the only one here speaking clear Icelandic. The only one trying to save this place from its own silence.”

“The silence saves us,” the fisherman says, pointing his cane at the map. “You mark the boundary. You do not name it.”

Thorsteinn rips the map from the wall. Thumbtacks ping against the floor. He shakes the paper at the room, the inked coastline dancing. “It’s water!” he yells.

The fisherman freezes. The needles stop. Thorsteinn steps forward, panting, and looks at the fisherman, then at the window, where the black reflection of the room hangs against the night. “It is just water,” he says, and he uses the nominative, and Rowan hears the case land like a struck bell. *Petta er bara vatn*. He names it. He gives it a subject. He reduces it to a neutral substance, a thing that can be held and measured and contained. “It rises because of the moon. It falls because of gravity. It does not think. It does not remember. It is just water.” He drops the map, and it flutters face-down to the floor.

Silence. Not the silence of a pause but the silence of a deletion. Rowan’s ears pop. The fluorescent hum continues, distant now, as if transmitted from another room, and the pressure in the hall drops the way it drops in a house when a door somewhere has been opened onto a much larger space. No one moves. The fisherman stares at the air in front of Thorsteinn as if expecting it to split. The knitting woman studies her hands and waits.

Thorsteinn looks around, expecting rebuttal, argument, the ordinary friction of a meeting. “Well?” he demands. “Correct me.”

No one speaks. To correct him would be to repeat the error. The fisherman sits and lays his cane across his knees, aligning it carefully. The knitting woman folds her wool and stands. The villagers look past Thorsteinn now, at the walls, the ceiling, the shelter itself, the way people in a listing ship look at the hull. Thorsteinn wipes his mouth, and his eyes find Rowan, and confusion flickers across his face as he understands, all at once, that the silence is not agreement.

“The meeting is adjourned,” he whispers. He reaches for the red pen, misses the

cap, tries again, misses, and leaves it uncapped. Rowan closes his notebook. He does not record the breach; to write it would be to archive it, and he has learned, this week, the difference. He stands, his knees unreliable, and the villagers file out without speaking, moving like water toward a drain, and Thorsteinn remains, staring at the bright rectangle on the wall where the map used to hang, a window onto a time before the boundary was drawn.

• • •

Rowan opens the door onto a night that has stopped entirely. No surf. No flagpole rope. The darkness toward the harbour is thick and waiting. The sentence has been spoken; now the listener will parse it.

At a quarter past eight he stands on the concrete promenade that skirts the inner harbour, and he switches on his flashlight, and the harbour is moving. Not violently — there is no cracking pavement, no scream of rebar. The quay is simply descending. As he watches, a galvanized bench sinks; the concrete beneath its bolts loses its solidity and the surface closes over the seat, and then the backrest, and then it is gone. The bollards retract into the ground like pistons. And where the modern surface sinks, something older rises to meet it: dark timber, tarred, rough-hewn, joined with wooden pegs, so that wood and concrete occupy the same coordinate in two different drafts of time. This is not erosion. It is revision. The quay is reverting.

Salt bleeds from the retaining wall and crystallizes in the cold air, and white geometries bloom between the stones — not random efflorescence but ordered, angular, the shapes he has learned to read. Case endings. The wall is diagramming, in salt, the sentence that used to bind it, and the sentence is being un-said, and so the wall is going back to what it was before the sentence held it. He reaches for his recorder. The red light blinks once and dies into silence.

The modern breakwater dissolves. Rocks surface where the charts have shown open water since 1890. He understands, with the slow cold clarity that has replaced his curiosity, that the old map was not a plan. It was a memory, and the sea is choosing to remember it.

He tries to write, and his hand forms *The*— and locks. The definite article. He crosses it out and tries *It*, and *it moves*, and the nausea recedes, and he understands that even his own language has begun to take sides, that the reaching, agentive constructions his discipline is built on will no longer pass his hand without a toll. He puts the notebook away.

Arnar Jónsson steps into the edge of the flashlight's beam. "It goes back," he says.

"The concrete liquefied," Rowan whispers.

“It was not remembered.” Arnar does not say the word Thorsteinn said. “To name it is to deny that it has a will. And what has no will has no boundary. It does not want to be kept.” He watches the black timber surface out of the mud. “That is my grandfather’s rack. Lost in forty-two.” A pause. “You should go to Thorsteinn. He will need witnesses.”

“For what?”

“For the end of the sentence.”

“When does it stop?”

“It does not reach the present,” Arnar says, and there is no drama in it, only the fatigue of a man reporting a tide. “The present falls back to meet it.” He walks toward the oldest rocks, and the ground hums underfoot, a low seismic note, a system quietly overwriting itself, and Rowan stands at the edge of it and feels, for the first time, that he is not in the file at all — that he is watching a page be rewritten and is himself only a smudge of ink in the margin that the new draft has not yet decided what to do with.

• • •

At eight in the morning the village remains, but the angles are wrong. Rowan enters the community hall to find the villagers standing outside the office, listening. From behind the frosted glass of the door comes a voice, broken into pieces. “*Nom... nom... in... a—*”

Thorsteinn sits at his desk, immaculate, the papers squared, every sheet inked solid black. “*Sub... ject—*” He looks up. There is terror in his face, but it is a terror without connection to anything, a man frightened by the inside of his own skull. “*The—*” he tries. He cannot reach the noun. The pages under his hands are filled edge to edge with suffixes. Nominative endings, endless, a subject rehearsed a thousand times without ever arriving at the thing it was meant to name.

Rowan reaches for the word *diagnosis*, and it slides out from under him, and the loss is sudden and physical, a stair that is not there in the dark. The contagion is close. Thorsteinn writes *W* again and again until the paper tears. “*Is—*” He is trying to rebuild the sentence from its smallest parts, the way a man with a shattered hand tries to make a fist. The villagers wait, not unkindly, the way people wait outside a room where something is being finished. Rowan backs out. He needs to hear a complete sentence, spoken by someone, before he forgets how one is made. Behind him Thorsteinn keeps carving the nominative into the desk with the uncapped pen, trying to name the thing that has already, patiently, finished naming him.

XII



In the morning he goes to look at the house where his mother was born, and there is grass.

Edda told him where it stood, weeks ago, in a sentence so flat he did not understand at the time that he had been given anything: *past the western markers, where the ground goes soft*. He walks out at eight with the survey sheet and a compass, over the boundary line, past the stone Arnar planted, into the part of the map that the village has stopped speaking.

The ground is soft. The air is colder here by a degree he could measure if he had brought a thermometer, and he did not, and he notes the omission the way he notes everything.

He finds the site by triangulation, from the church tower and the northern headland, and stands on the coordinate.

Grass. Not a footprint of stone, not a hollow, not the rectangular darkening in the sward that a foundation leaves for two centuries in any field in England. Not rubble. Not the nettles and elder that grow on old human ground everywhere in the world because human ground is rich. Just the moor, green-grey and uninterrupted, running unbroken over the place where a kitchen was, in which a woman was born in March 1948, and in which she presumably learned to walk, and at some table in which she was taught to decline a coastline.

He crouches and puts his hand flat on it.

He is a rational man in a cold field with his palm on some grass. He knows it. But he has excavated at four sites and he knows what land does with a house, which is that it remembers it badly and forever, and this land has not remembered it at all.

He stays about ten minutes. He does not take a photograph, and cannot afterwards say why, and suspects it is because a photograph of nothing is a document that proves the wrong thing.

• • •

Séra Hjálmar has the registers out on the vestry table before Rowan finishes asking.

“I wondered when.” He is unembarrassed about it. “You have been here six weeks and you have not once asked me for a name. Every researcher asks for a name in the first fortnight. It is always a grandmother.”

“I wasn’t sure I wanted it.”

“No.” Hjálmar opens the volume. “Which is why I did not offer.”

The register is a beautiful object, half-leather, the ruling still crisp, and the hand of the 1940s incumbent is a small upright copperplate that must have taken him twenty minutes a line.

3. mars 1948. Bryndís Ásta Guðmundsdóttir.

Rowan sits down.

It is not a shock. He has known the shape of this for eight months and the fact of it for three weeks. What it is, is the first time his mother’s name has been written down in front of him by somebody who was not her, and there is a difference between knowing a thing and seeing it ruled into a column between two other children, and the difference goes through him at the sternum like cold water.

Bryndís Ásta. Two names. She used neither of them for fifty-seven years.

“Confirmed,” Hjálmar says, turning forward, “1962. Fourteen. Here — with eleven others, which was a large year.” His finger moves down. “And she is in the communicant roll for sixty-three, sixty-four, sixty-five.” He turns another leaf. “And then here.”

The 1966 page. Halfway down, in the margin beside her name, in the same small upright hand, four words and a date.

Rowan reads it and does not recognise the construction.

It is not *brottflutt* — moved away, the standard notation, which appears twice on the same page against two other names, both with destinations. It is not a death entry; deaths are ruled in red and there is no red here. It is not a transfer of parish. It is a phrase he can parse word by word and not as a whole, and after fifteen seconds of trying he does what he has spent his life training himself not to have to do, which is to ask.

“What is that?”

Hjálmar looks at it for a while.

“It says the line is not finished,” he says.

“Whose line?”

“Hers.”

“Meaning she had no children? She had a child. She had me.”

“Then it does not mean that.” Hjálmar closes his hands on the edge of the table. “Dr. Hale, I will tell you exactly what I know, which is less than you want. That

notation appears in this book nine times in two hundred and ninety-three years. I have checked. I checked in my second year here, because I found one and could not read it either.” He turns the volume slightly so the light falls better. “It is not ecclesiastical. It is not in any handbook. Three of the nine are in hands from before 1800. It is not something a pastor invented; it is something pastors were told to write.”

“By whom?”

“That is the part I do not know.” He says it simply. “I have written the phrase in this register twice myself, in nineteen years, both times because I was asked to, both times by someone who did not explain, and both times I did it, and I would do it again, and I could not give you a defence of that which would satisfy a synod.” He almost smiles. “Fortunately the synod has never asked.”

Rowan looks at the four words against his mother’s name.

“What happens to the other eight?” he says. “The other eight people. Where do they go?”

Hjálmar turns the pages and finds them, one after another, and reads out the subsequent entries in a level voice, and there is nothing sinister in a single one of them. Two died here, old, decades later, with ordinary red-ruled entries. One married in 1811 and is in the register four more times for four children. One emigrated to Canada in 1888. One is a man who lived his whole life in this parish and died in 1954 and whose funeral, per a marginal note, was very well attended.

They are ordinary lives. All of them.

“It is not a curse,” Hjálmar says. “I am going to say that plainly, because you have gone white. It is not a sentence passed on anybody. Whatever it records, the people it was written against went on and had lives and several of them had long ones.” He closes the book gently. “It records something that was left open. That is all I can tell you and it is all I have ever been able to tell myself.”

• • •

The school ledgers are still on the desk in the schoolhouse office where Rowan left them, arranged in their chronological arc, gathering a fortnight of new dust.

He came here the first time for the curriculum. He read 1965 for the structure of the syllabus and the teacher’s marginalia and the shape of the attrition, and he transcribed four pages of it, and he noticed the personal notes only as texture — *Jónas struggles with the vocal length. Gudrún is excellent.* — and he did not read them, because they were not what he had come for, and because he did not know there was anything in this building with his own blood in it.

He opens 1965 and goes through it line by line with his finger.

Week 9. Week 14. Week 22.

Week 31: Dative declensions, coastal nouns. Bryndís Á. has the length. Better than mine at that age — she does not push it from the throat, it simply arrives. Þórdís says the same and Þórdís does not say such things.

Rowan stops. He reads it four times.

Better than mine. The head teacher of this school, a woman with thirty years in the room, writing in a working document about a seventeen-year-old.

Week 36: Bryndís Á. took the second clause on Saturday, at the north stones, in front of everyone. Fifteen and a half seconds. Nobody had to carry her. Guðmundur cried, which he will deny.

Week 38: The broadcast people come Thursday from Reykjavík. Þórdís has said Bryndís is to do the paradigm. She is the only one who can do the whole of it without stopping and it is right that it should be her. I am proud enough to be ashamed of myself.

Week 39:

The entry for week 39 is four words long.

Þórdís has withdrawn her.

Nothing else. No explanation, in a ledger which for thirty-eight weeks has explained everything, including the weather and Jónas's throat and the price of chalk. The hand does not shake. It simply stops, and the next entry, week 40, is about a broken window and is entirely normal, and Bryndís Á. does not appear in the ledger again, not in week 41, not in week 47, not in the summary at the year's end.

She was seventeen and she was the best in the village and eight weeks later she was gone from the country.

• • •

He finds the reel because Sigrún tells him where to look.

She is in the schoolhouse, in the blanket, at the child's desk by the window, and she is worse than she was a fortnight ago in a way that neither of them will mention. He tells her what he has found and she listens with her eyes closed.

"The broadcast," she says. "Yes. They came about every four years, the collectors. Dialect survey. We were on the list because we were remote." A dry breath that might be amusement. "We were extremely cooperative. We gave them sheep words for twenty years."

"There's a copy here?"

"There is a copy of everything here. The school kept the second reel; that was the arrangement, they took one and left one." She lifts a hand an inch off the blanket and points it at the corridor. "Store cupboard. Bottom shelf, under the county maps. And there is a machine, and it will not work, because there has been no power in this building since two thousand and four."

"I have a converter and a battery pack."

"Of course you do," says Sigrún.

It takes him ninety minutes. The reels are in flat card boxes labelled by year in a hand he now recognises from the ledgers, and 1965 is where she said it would be, and the machine is a Danish thing the size of a suitcase which has been maintained — he notes this, he cannot help noting it — with a small can of oil that is on the shelf beside it and which has been used, at some point, by somebody, in a building nobody has taught in for thirty-one years.

He carries it all to the classroom and sets it on the teacher's desk and runs it off the battery pack, and Sigrún makes him lace the tape twice because he does it wrong the first time.

• • •

There is four minutes of a man from Reykjavík establishing the date, the place, the equipment, and his own name, in the flat confident radio Icelandic of 1965.

Then a girl says her name.

"*Bryndís Ásta Guðmundsdóttir. Sautján ára.*"

Rowan puts both hands on the desk.

It is not that it sounds like her. It does not sound like her. The voice on the tape is high and quick and completely unguarded, a girl's voice with a coast in it, and his mother's voice was low and English and sanded flat and he never once in fifty-five years heard her produce a vowel like the one in *sautján*. There is no recognition in it at all.

Except that the pause is his mother's pause. Before she says *ára* — years — there is a fifth of a second that he has heard ten thousand times across a kitchen table, and it is not hesitation, it is placement, a woman putting a word down exactly where she means it to go, and he sits down slowly on a child's chair with his hand over his mouth.

The recordist asks her to give the paradigm.

She gives it.

She is astonishing. Rowan has listened to perhaps nine hundred hours of elicited speech in his career and he knows within eight seconds that he is listening to something he will not hear again — not the fluency, fluency is common, but the *placement*, every ending landing in the same acoustic position, the vowel lengths so regular he could set a metronome against them, and no strain anywhere. She is not performing. She sounds bored, in the specific way of a very good seventeen-year-old doing something easy in front of adults.

Nominative. Accusative. Dative. Genitive.

And then she keeps going.

The fifth column. The sixth. He does not have names for what she is doing but he can hear the architecture of it, the same stem carried into cases that his discipline does not admit exist, and the recordist says nothing because the recordist has no idea, and the tape hiss goes on, and Rowan sits in a cold classroom in the dark with his eyes shut and listens to his mother do at seventeen the thing he has spent thirty years building instruments to detect.

Then the seventh.

She goes wrong.

It is not a stumble. That is the thing he will not be able to put down afterwards. There is no catch in the breath, no false start, no correction, no rise in pitch. She produces a form, cleanly and in tempo and with the same bored competence as everything before it, and the form is wrong — and he knows it is wrong the way he knows a bell is cracked, from the shape of the sound and not from any rule he could cite, because he has no rule, because there is no published description of the seventh case of anything.

She finishes the column. She says *takk*. The recordist thanks her warmly and says it was very good.

The tape runs on for another forty seconds of room tone.

And in the room tone, faintly, at the edge of the microphone's reach, somebody — a woman, older — says one short word, and it is not on the transcript sheet in the box, and Rowan rewinds it eleven times and cannot get it, and on the twelfth he stops trying, because Sigrún has opened her eyes.

"Did you hear that?" he says.

"I heard it."

"What is it?"

Sigrún looks out of the window at the flat grey. "I was three years old," she says. "I am not the person to ask." A long pause. "But that is Þórdís, and she is not surprised."

• • •

He sits with it until the battery pack dies.

He can construct two accounts and they fit the evidence equally.

In the first, a girl of seventeen at the end of a long recording, under the eye of a man from the capital and a room of adults who are proud of her, on the seventh and hardest column, at the outer limit of a system that perhaps four people alive can hold, makes an error. It happens. It happens to everyone. Þórdís withdrew her from the broadcast two weeks later because a custodian does not put a girl on a public reel making errors in the deep cases, and the entry in the ledger is four words long because the head teacher was disappointed and disappointment is not

minuted. And a girl who had been told her whole life that she was the best, and who found out on tape in front of the village that she was not, left the country eight weeks afterwards and did not come back, and that is not a mystery, that is the oldest story there is.

In the second, she did it on purpose.

Rowan turns the two of them over for a long time in the dark classroom. The evidence does not choose. The tape does not choose; a deliberate error, produced by someone that good, would sound exactly like an error produced by someone that good, and the whole point of being that good is that nobody in the room can tell. Þórdís's word in the room tone is consistent with dismay and consistent with recognition and he cannot hear which it is and never will.

What he has, at the end of it, is not an answer. It is a demonstration.

His mother, at seventeen, in this village, could hold the whole of a grammatical system that no linguist has ever described, and had been handed it by the woman who owned it, and was, by the assessment of every adult who heard her, the best in the line. And then something happened in the seventh case, and she stopped, and a pastor wrote four words in a margin that mean *something was left open*, and she went to England and became a woman who worked for a county council drawing boundaries on maps of a country she had no history in, and married and had a son and answered his questions with a warm grey surface for thirty years, and died, and left him a tin with forty torn drills in it and a sealed envelope addressed to the only other person alive who was in that room.

And on a table in a cottage on the north ridge, six weeks after he slid it across the wood between the salt and the tea, there is a sealed envelope with four characters and a full stop on the face of it, in that same hand.

He wants it. That is the plain fact of the evening and he sits with it in the cold and does not dress it up. He wants to walk up the ridge now, tonight, in the dark, and ask for it back, and take it somewhere with a lamp, and open it.

Edda has not offered. She has not mentioned it once in six weeks. She did not move it toward herself on the first day and she did not move it away, and Rowan understands, sitting in a dead classroom with a dead tape machine in front of him, that this was never a woman deciding whether to accept a letter. It was a woman deciding whether the person who brought it was going to be able to hold what was in it, and it is six weeks later and she has not decided yet.

Tonight he can hear the fifth of a second before *ára* sitting inside that handwriting. The same placement. The same woman putting a thing down exactly where she meant it to go, and then not sending it for forty years.

He does not go up the ridge. He packs the machine instead, and helps Sigrún down the hill in the dark, which takes a long time and which neither of them remarks upon, and at her door she says, without any preamble:

"She was kind to me. When I was small." Her breath is short. "I do not know

what happened to her either. Nobody would ever say. But she used to carry me on the boundary walk when my legs gave out, and she sang, which nobody does.” She fumbles the latch. “I thought you should have one thing about her that is not in a book.”

XIII



The fog does not lift; it only dilutes, thin enough to admit solid bodies while keeping the light for itself. Rowan stands at the Annex threshold, watching the coastal track. The landscape is monochrome — black basalt, grey scree, white mist — and then a colour error appears. A figure climbs the incline, not with the villagers' low hip-swaying negotiation of gravity but with vertical purpose, stepping over stones rather than around them. The jacket is chemical yellow. Gore-Tex rasps against itself, a sound too sharp for this place.

He wipes the condensation from his glasses and measures the arrival. Two minutes. The figure resolves into a woman with a padded camera bag heavy with lenses and a smartphone held aloft, hunting a signal that died ten kilometers south. She stops ten meters off and exhales, and the vapour disperses at once, where the locals' breath clings.

"Dr. Hale?" Her voice is clear and high, stripped of hesitation, the voice of a presenter. It hits the turf wall and does not resonate; it bounces.

"Yes. Hale."

She bounds the last steps and offers a hand in a fingerless glove. "Brynja Þórhallsdóttir. Thorsteinn said you were up here. I parked by the quay, or what's left of it. The road situation is a nightmare." Her grip is dry and firm.

He switches to Icelandic, the local dialect weighted on his tongue now without his choosing it. "You are Edda's granddaughter."

"Yes." She answers in Reykjavík standard — clipped vowels, sharp consonants, clean nominatives without a second thought. "Haven't been back since I was twelve. Place hasn't changed, has it? Just sunk a bit." She raises her phone and photographs the grey void where the bay should be, the artificial shutter absurdly loud. "I'm here because the project moved up. The council thinks your village will be gone by next winter. They want a full package before the budget closes."

He hears the pressure under the professional tone: if she comes back empty-

handed, it will not only be the village that disappears from someone's ledger. "What kind of package?"

"Oral histories, dialect features, environmental footage." She taps the bag. "And—" She hesitates, the first hesitation he has heard. "—Edda. I need her voice on record. I promised them. I promised myself, too." There it is, he thinks: not grant-speak but obligation dressed as work, and he knows the costume well, having worn it across an ocean.

"You mean to film."

"High fidelity. The stories, the songs, the layout. It's cultural data. If we don't hold it, it evaporates." He looks at the yellow jacket, fabric designed to shed weather, and thinks that she is dressed like an astronaut and believes the suit is protection rather than insulation from consequence.

"The elders are protective of the spoken forms," he says carefully. "They do not welcome copies."

Brynja laughs, light and airy. "Oh, I know. Grandma Edda is the worst for it. 'Don't write it down.' 'Don't fix it.' Quaint. But folklore dies when it stays oral. If we don't record it, it's just noise in the wind."

The mist curls around her boots and seems to recoil from the synthetic yellow, as if the fabric refuses to be absorbed. "The language here isn't representational," he says, lowering his voice. "It acts."

She waves a hand, an efficient dismissal. "Semantics, Doctor. You linguists romanticize syntax. I need footage and interviews. If I can get Edda to recite one of the storm forms on camera, the council signs off and I'm done." *Done.* The word lands wrong in his body. Nothing is done in Brynjavík. Only held.

"I'll walk you down. But I can't promise they'll speak."

"They'll speak," she says, already turning for the path. "Everyone wants to be remembered. That's human nature." She descends quickly, her silhouette cutting a hard line through the soft grey. Too fast. Too clear. A sharp bright thing entering a place that has spent a century teaching itself to blur.

• • •

On the basalt shelf she levels her tripod with a spirit bubble and mounts a sleek black mirrorless camera, the lens wide enough to swallow the bay. She checks the exposure. "The light is flat," she murmurs. "But the texture is incredible. Look how it doesn't quite reflect the sky." He stands three paces back, hands in his pockets, fists clenched. The tide slides over rock with a silence that feels enforced.

"Rolling," she says, and pans from cliffs to horizon. On the little screen the image is crisp — basalt sharp, foam clean — until the frame crosses the line the villagers will not name. The image does not blur. It tears. Ribbons of ragged

colour shred the horizon, sky and water swapping places in jagged blocks, as if the machine cannot decide which is subject and which is object.

"Damn it." She stops recording. "Magnetic interference off the volcanic rock. Fixable."

"It's the line," Rowan says. "It isn't fixed."

"It's a camera, Rowan. It doesn't have a philosophical crisis. It has a signal-to-noise problem." They move inland. A fisherman — Einar, a glass eye catching the flat light — stands by the drying racks. Brynja smiles, clips a small microphone to his lapel. "Tell me about the winter of seventy-nine. In your own words." Einar's eye flicks to the red tally light. He speaks, but his syntax contracts, articles dropping, verbs shortening, speech pared down to slip past a recording head without catching. "Cold came. Sheep died. Ice lay."

"And the sea?" she asks, too casually. "How was the sea?"

Einar freezes, his gaze going past the camera. "The west," he whispers. "Was heavy."

"I'm getting hum," Brynja frowns into her headphones. "Say that again? The bottom just dropped out of the frequency." Rowan hears it without headphones — not electrical but subterranean, something dragging across the floor of the spectrum, lower than any diaphragm should be able to reach.

"Let him go," Rowan says. Einar unclips the microphone with shaking fingers and walks away as if leaving a line of fire.

"Wind shear," Brynja mutters, making a note. "Tricky environment." She heads for the lowest cottage in the scree. Edda's door is shut, the windows dark though it is midday. "Grandma will be the centerpiece," she says softly, almost pleading now. "If I can get her to recite the Sæfangi on record, the model is complete."

The air tightens. "Do not ask her for that case," Rowan says.

"It's for the archives. It's for her." She raises a hand to knock, and the door opens. Edda stands compressed in the frame — not frail, dense — her eyes fixed on the lens, not on her granddaughter. "Hi, Amma," Brynja says, gentling. "Just a short session. Basics."

Edda's gaze stays on the red light. "You bring a bucket with no bottom," she says in Vikamál, pure and hard. "You think it holds."

"It's digital. It holds everything."

"It holds nothing. It repeats." She lifts a hand and draws a single vertical slash in the air, cut short. "*Slökkva á auganu.*" *Extinguish the eye.* The door slams.

Brynja exhales and turns back, already reaching for competence. "She's dramatic. We'll try again tomor—" She stops. The camera screen is black. A moment ago the battery read eighty-four percent; now it flashes empty red and dies, the lens retracting with a thin exhausted whir. "Dead," she says, popping the battery, touching the contacts. "Stone cold. It just drained."

“The circuit broke,” Rowan says, looking at the shut door.

“Bad cell. Grid fluctuations. I’ll charge everything tonight.” She slots a spare and the screen wakes at sixty-eight percent. She points the lens at her boots, the path, her own hand. The frame holds. She pans to the dark window and speaks into the microphone, level: “Test. Sound check. The sea is heavy.” The percentage drops as she speaks — sixty-eight, fifty-one, thirty-three — and it is the vowels that do it; Rowan watches the meter dive on the long open syllables and recover on the consonants, as if the cell is being asked to hold a note it cannot describe and is paying for the description in charge. Brynja tries again, in English this time: “The water is large. The water is wet.” Sentences with no agentive grammar, no force. The percentage holds at thirty-three. Stable. She powers the camera down before she has to admit what she has just measured, and packs up. Around them the curtains settle back into place. The village is not hiding from the lens because it is shy. It is hiding because once a thing is recorded it can no longer change its mind, and here, changing one’s mind is how you survive the weather.

• • •

Dinner is in the annex of the curing house, the beams low enough to graze a tall man’s crown, the air dense with boiled haddock and rye and wet wool, thirty people trying not to breathe too deeply. Rowan sits near the end of the trestle; Brynja sits mid-table, a bright singularity in a room of earth tones, talking fast — Ministry stories, funding loops, the absurdity of the paperwork — her Icelandic fluent and unbroken, nominatives and active verbs delivered like small declarations.

He watches the window behind her. It is old single-pane glass, wavy, cold, and it does not fog. Instead, along the black iron of the window latch and the nailheads that hold the frame, a fine white rime begins to grow as she speaks — salt, sweating out of the cold metal into the warm room, crystallizing in threads and hooks. It does not spread evenly. It builds on the long open sounds and pauses on the stops, a slow frost of salt writing itself along the ironwork in the exact rhythm of her sentences, and no one but Rowan is looking at it, and he cannot say whether it is a warning being written or a receipt.

Brynja laughs. “The funding model is circular. We apply for a grant to study the application process. It’s—” A fork clatters to the floor. The sound severs the room, and the silence drops instantly. Einar stands, his chair scraping back. He does not look at Brynja; he looks at the space in front of her mouth, as if tracking a thrown object. “My apologies,” he says, tight. “The air is full.” He leaves, and latches the door.

“Touchy,” Brynja murmurs. “I think he hates the funding talk.”

“He broke the sentence,” Rowan says. “You were about to give the water agency.”

"I was using a metaphor."

"Metaphors here act like instructions."

After the meal they step out into a cold that holds its breath, and walk to the tide pools by the breakwater, basins black and still, reflecting stars without a shimmer. "Let's get this on record," Brynja says, pulling out her phone, a red dot on the voice app. "Dr. Hale. The synthesis. What's the core mechanic?"

He hesitates. The pool reflects his face. "It's a system of avoidance," he says. "Grammar removes the speaker from the path of the subject." He hears the phrase twice — once from his mouth, once from the water. ...*path of the subject*... He freezes. The second voice did not come from the phone. It came from the pool. Concentric rings spread across the surface though nothing has struck it, and the voice rises flat and wet, perfectly timed.

Brynja laughs a little too fast. "Echo off the cliff. Wild."

"That's not an echo. The timing is wrong."

"It's acoustics." She steps closer. "Hello?" she calls. The pool ripples again. ...*Hello*... Identical. Not mimicry. The sound returned whole, unopened, as if it had been kept a moment and handed back. Her face loses its confidence for the first time, and she looks down as though the pool has grown an eye. "Okay," she says, forcing the smile back. "Let's check the video from today." She opens her gallery and plays the drying-racks clip. The edges smear where the compression failed; the villagers stand tense and unhappy; and behind them, blurred by the depth of field, other figures stand — pale, indistinct, like smudges on the lens that have somehow learned posture.

"Zoom," Rowan says. She pinches the image, and the figures mirror the villagers exactly, hunched shoulders echoed, crossed arms echoed. Not ghosts. Not people. Grammar given a body, the other half of the verb standing patiently in the frame, waiting to be conjugated.

"Glitch," Brynja says, too loudly. "I need to reformat the card." She shoves the phone away as if hiding it makes the image less true. "I'm going to the hall. I need to upload. I need signal." She walks off fast, not looking back, and behind her the pool repeats *signal, signal, signal* in smaller and smaller versions into the empty rock. Rowan watches her go, and notices, as she climbs, that the path behind her looks subtly flatter than the path in front, less textured, the way an over-exposed edge of a photograph loses its detail. Not gone. But edited.

• • •

Sleep is a hypothesis he cannot prove. The Annex is silent, but the silence presses, active and physical, and at a quarter to one he leaves the bed and steps into the night. Fog hangs low, bandaging the village. He navigates by his memory of

the ground, and one light burns on the north ridge: Edda's window. He stops at the dry-stone wall five meters from the glass. The curtains are drawn but not closed, a narrow slit showing candlelight, and Edda at her table — not the iron pillar of their first interview. She is trembling. Her hands are raised, fingers splayed, moving through complex tracing geometries, syntax drawn into the air. He recognizes the motions: the downward stroke, the enclosing circle. She is building a sentence to brace the room. Her lips move; he cannot hear the words through the glass, but he can see the effort, the jaw tight, the neck cords straining, the labour of lifting an invisible weight.

She reaches for the binding, the Sæfangi. Her hands move to form the knot. And she falters. Her left hand spasms; the circle breaks; she tries to retrace it and her fingers are stiff, arthritic, exhausted, overpowered. Her mouth shapes the long Á. Her breath catches. She collapses forward onto the table. The candle flame lengthens, turns blue, and snaps audibly sideways, as if pressed by a heavy hand. Edda does not rise. Her cheek is on the wood, her hands open. The sentence remains unfinished.

Rowan backs away and looks toward the sea. The tide is high — too high — lapping at the base of the ridge, meters above any mark that should exist. And it is not making the sound of water. It is making the sound of articulation. *Thhhh. Uuu. Mmm.* Breath through teeth, consonants grinding against stone vowels. The sea is rehearsing, trying to pronounce the thing it touches. He turns and walks faster toward the village, the gravel loosening underfoot as if definition itself were draining out of the ground, and passes the community hall, where light glows from the office, and stops.

Brynja is inside, hunched over a laptop in a nest of drives and cables, the blue screenlight hollowing her face, sweat shining on her upper lip. She is pressing Delete, over and over. He moves to the glass. The files corrupt on the screen, but not into random noise — the faces melt into long jagged lines that resemble the scripts carved into the schoolhouse beams. A frame freezes: the shoreline, but the rocks have rearranged themselves into text, the pixels declining into cases. Brynja's mouth forms a small sound he cannot hear, but he can read it: refusal, denial breaking. She scrubs the record as if scrubbing could undo the act of having looked.

Rowan stands between the two windows. Behind him the sea practices its new vocabulary against the ridge. To his left, the last speaker lies defeated by the grammar she spent her life holding. To his right, the archivist is being overwritten by the very data she came to save. There is no neutral ground on which to stand and watch. The translation has begun, and the language being spoken no longer requires a human tongue — though, he understands, standing in the cold between the windows, it would still very much prefer one.

XIV



The body of Magnús Jónsson lies on the shingle three meters above the high-tide mark, arranged in a posture of delivery rather than collapse, arms extended toward the village, palms open as if offering an explanation. The gravel around him is dry. The wool of his sweater is dry, still holding the smell of lanolin and stale tobacco. Even his boots — heavy leather workwear — show no darkening from brine. He has not been in the water.

Yet when Arnar kneels and presses two fingers to the sternum, the sound that comes from the open mouth is the gurgle of a rising tide. Arnar withdraws his hand and wipes his fingertips on his trousers. He does not close the eyes, which are fixed on the grey zenith of the sky, the corneas clouded with a white crystalline precipitate. “Full,” Arnar says. He does not say *he is full*. He leaves the subject out, keeping the condition from fastening to the man.

The villagers stand in a semicircle, heavy coats, silence, a wall placed deliberately between the body and the waterline. They do not look at the sea. Their backs are rigid barriers shielding the evidence from the plaintiff. They cluster tight, closing the gaps where a line of sight might slip through. Rowan stands at the periphery, observing the geometry. In any other jurisdiction this is a crime scene, or a medical emergency. Here it is a matter of contested boundaries.

He knew Magnús a little. Not well — no one lets an outsider know them well here — but he had sat across a table from the man twice, had watched him mend a creel with the same economy Arnar brought to a knot, had been given, once, a piece of dried fish and a nod that meant *you are permitted to be here*. Now he looks at the salt crust forming on the dead lips and finds that the clinical phrase will not come clean. He writes it anyway, because the writing is the last handhold he has. *Internal inundation. No external contact.* And then, because it is true and the true words are the local ones now, he writes what the village would write. *He was called, and the water in him answered.*

A gap opens in the defensive line, just wide enough for Edda. She moves with a friction that suggests the air resists her passage. Her stick — driftwood capped with iron — strikes the stones in a slow click. She stops at the body's feet, looks at Magnús, at the villagers, briefly at the horizon they are trying to obscure. She leans down, touches the salt on his lip, rubs the crystal between thumb and forefinger, testing the grit. "He was named," she says. Not a whisper. It lands like a gavel.

Arnar nods. "In the night. We heard nothing."

"The sea does not need to shout when it has the paperwork." She straightens, her spine locking into place with audible effort. "It found a handle. It called him, and the water inside him went to meet the water outside, the way a level finds a level."

Rowan steps closer, pulled by the logic of the pathology despite himself. "It filled him from the inside."

Edda turns her head. Her eyes are opaque, reflecting the dull dawn. "The water is not a substance, Dr. Hale. It is a location. Magnús was reclassified. He was moved to the location of the sea without his body leaving the stones." She looks back at the corpse. The death is not tragic to her because Magnús suffered. It is tragic because the boundary of the village has been successfully contested, and everyone standing here now lives a little closer to the edge than they did yesterday.

"The claim is invalid," Arnar says, though his voice lacks conviction. "He was on the roster for the winter shear."

"The roster is paper. The sea has precedent now. It has taken a subject without wetting the ground. If we do not answer the claim, it will take the next one by simply thinking of him." She taps her stick against the stones. One. Two. Three. "We must unbind it. The Aflending. Before the next tide makes the record permanent."

A ripple of unease moves through the cluster. The Aflending is not a prayer; it is a retraction, a dangerous maneuver that requires the speaker to stand in the void between noun and verb and hold it open. "Is the voice strong enough?" Arnar asks, his gaze flicking to her throat, the cords standing out like rigging under strain.

She does not answer directly. She looks at the water lapping innocently at the quay. "The voice is the tool we have. We do not ask whether the hammer is heavy. We ask whether it strikes." She turns her back on the body. "Cover him. Do not take him to the church yet. To bury him now is to accept the death as natural. We contest the cause first."

Séra Hjálmar has come down the shingle in a waxed jacket over his collar, and he stands at the head of the body with his hands at his sides, and he does not touch it and does not pray over it, and when Edda gives her instruction about the church he does not contradict her.

Rowan moves along the line to stand beside him. "You're not objecting."

"To what? She has not said he may not be buried. She has said not today." Hjálmar's voice is very low. "I have known Magnús Jónsson for nineteen years.

He mended my gutter twice and would not be paid. I will bury him properly on a day of my choosing and I will use every word of the office.”

“And in the meantime he lies under a tarp.”

“In the meantime he lies under a tarp,” Hjálmar agrees, “with stones on the corners, in the parish of which I am the incumbent, and I have been asked to allow it by a woman of eighty who has never once asked me for anything, and I have allowed it.” He looks at the covered shape. “You will want to know what I think happened.”

“I would.”

“I think a man died in the night and there will be a physical cause and a doctor from Húsavík will find it or not find it, and I think whatever he writes on the form will be true, and I think it will not be the whole of the truth, and I have no method for the remainder and neither does he.” A gull goes over. “That is not evasion, Dr. Hale. That is the actual position and I have held it for nineteen years and it is more uncomfortable than either of the two comfortable positions available.”

The villagers move at once. A tarp — heavy boat canvas — is drawn over Magnús, hiding the salt-filled eyes and the dry wool, and basalt rocks weight the corners, pinning him to the land, preventing any drift into the domain of the sea. There is no weeping. They are securing a perimeter. As Edda passes Rowan she smells of ozone and old paper, and she does not acknowledge him, but he hears her muttering, rehearsing, testing the tensile strength of the syllables she will need. “...unda... und... undi...” She ascends the path to the headland alone, and the villagers watch her go with the terrified hope of people who have handed a losing case to the only advocate they have.

• • •

The basalt shelf thrusts out into the grey slurry like a lectern, the rock slick with spray, black and geometric, a platform built for address. Rowan wedges himself into a fissure twenty meters back, hidden by dried kelp and rockfall, holding the recorder close, shielding the microphone with a gloved hand. The device is running. The levels are low, capturing the ambient hiss.

Edda stands at the edge. She does not raise her arms; she does not kneel. Feet shoulder-width, she braces against the drag of the current, a vertical line drawn against the horizontal mass of the water. She begins with no preamble. “*Haf... unda... straum... und—*” The sound is mechanical. It grinds. The suffix *-und* is a cancellation, a brake applied to the noun’s momentum, and she speaks it with flat percussive force, hitting the final consonant hard. “*Salt... unda... dýpi... und—*”

Rowan watches the water. It does not crash. It listens. The waves approaching the shelf do not break; they pause, the foam dissolving back into the dark mass, the

level at the base of the rock beginning to lower. It is not a tide going out. It is a margin being redrawn. The sea pulls back from the stone in a clean concave arc that mirrors the radius of her voice, and the wet rock dries instantly, the moisture sucked back into the body of the water as if ordered home. Edda presses forward, stepping onto newly dry stone, reclaiming territory. “*Nafn... unda... Magnús... und—*” She fixes the unbinding suffix to the dead man’s name, annulling the citation.

Her voice holds, but it lacks resonance now, metal on metal. The effort of holding the grammatical negative against the physical positive of the whole ocean is enormous; Rowan sees her shoulders shaking, not with cold but with load. “*Alda... unda... blá... undi—*” The water recedes further. A jagged reef, unseen for decades, breaks the surface, black mussels clicking softly in the air. The sea concedes the point, backing down before the precedent she cites.

Then fatigue arrives — not a stumble of the feet but a stumble of the tongue. She reaches for the compound *strand-lengja*, coastline, needing to unbind the coast from the claim. “*Strand—*” Her voice catches. The long vowel fractures. She tries to engage the suffix. “*Strand... un... daa—*” The rhythm breaks. The final vowel lengthens too much, the precise termination going soft, almost a question. The sea stops retreating. The arc of water freezes, holding its position, verifying the silence.

Edda knows. She tries to correct, to force the consonant back into place. “*Und. Und.*” But the structure has failed; the lattice that held the water at bay snaps under the fatigue of seventy years of maintenance. Her mouth opens and no sound comes. The muscles of her jaw work furiously, trying to shape the case, but the bridge between intent and execution is gone. The sea waits one beat, confirming the gap, and then resumes — water sliding back over the reef, covering the dry stone, filing back into the emptied space without hurry, approaching her boots. She stumbles back, her stick clattering, one hand to her throat, looking at the water with the confusion of a mathematician who has forgotten how to count. The water stops. It does not reclaim everything; it halts two meters short of its old high mark, conceding the immediate surge while keeping the jurisdiction.

Rowan stops the recording. Sickness rises in him, a sympathetic resonance with the failure he has just watched, and under it something worse: he has watched a woman spend the last of a voice, and he did nothing, and could have done nothing, and part of him was taking levels. Edda turns and sees him, or the shape of him in the rocks, and does not scold, and does not speak. She walks past, her gait uneven, her mouth slightly open. As she passes he hears her trying to whisper, trying to say *the water*, and cycling the endings, mismatching them, calling the water *waters*, calling it *to the water*, unable to find the subject. She has lost the ability to name the thing that defeated her. He stays crouched until she is gone, watching the sea settle into its renegotiated line, lapping against the stone with the soft wet sound of a page being turned.

• • •

The doctor comes out from Húsavík on the Thursday and is on the shingle for forty minutes and gives the cause as drowning, and on the evidence in front of him there is no reason to give any other, and Rowan — who stands at the edge of the examination with his hands in his pockets — would have written the same.

What Hjálmar does with it is the thing Rowan will remember.

He shows him that evening in the vestry, without being asked: the parish return, the same form filed in the first week of every January since 1732. A column for the year. Columns for baptisms, confirmations, marriages, burials. And a narrow column at the right, headed in an abbreviation four centuries old, for the circumstance.

“I will put him in the burials,” Hjálmar says. “That is a fact and I will state it.”

“And the circumstance?”

“I will leave it blank.”

Rowan looks up.

“I cannot write *drowning*,” Hjálmar sets the pen down. “He was dry. I was there. I looked at his boots and at the gravel under him and there was not one wet stone, and I am not going to put a word into a book that will sit in that cupboard for three hundred years and tell somebody in 2325 a thing I know to be false.” He caps the pen. “And I cannot write the other thing, because I do not know the other thing — and because if I write it, the diocese sends somebody. That somebody will be kind. He will conclude that a rural incumbent has become isolated. He will be gentle about it and he will be entirely wrong, and I will be replaced by a man who drives out on alternate Sundays.”

“So you leave a hole.”

“I leave a hole.” He turns the volume toward Rowan and puts a finger against the column. “It will be the fifth in two hundred and ninety- three years. There are four already. Seventeen eighty-three. Nineteen eighteen. Nineteen thirty-four. Nineteen ninety-one.” He takes the finger away. “I have looked at all four and I have looked hard. In every case the burial is recorded. In every case the circumstance is not. And in every case the hand is perfectly steady — no blot, no hesitation, no scratching out. Four men who knew exactly what they were declining to write, and wrote everything else beautifully.”

Rowan looks at the four years.

Seventeen eighty-three is the ash, and a harbour that walked east. Nineteen thirty-four is the winter Edda’s mother was nine and the village doubled. Nineteen ninety-one is Þórunn, and four syllables, and an eleventh stone that has been cleared and checked and repacked every month since by people who cannot speak to it.

He does not say any of this.

“I find I am not lonely about it in the way I expected,” Hjálmar says. “That

is the odd part. Four men across three hundred years, none of whom I can ask anything, and I know precisely what each of them was doing on the day he picked up the pen.”

Rowan looks at the space that is not yet blank because it is not yet written, and understands that he is watching this village’s record being kept the way everything else here is kept: not by what is set down, but by a three-hundred-year refusal to put the wrong word in.

• • •

The village contracts. Not a retreat — an editing. By noon the three families on the western perimeter, nearest the old salting sheds, begin to move. No trucks, no shouting. They carry boxes and furniture by hand, walking the centerline of the road toward the cluster of houses near the hall. A man carries a kitchen chair. A woman follows with folded linen. They do not look back. They do not speak of the house they leave; to speak of it would draw attention to a vacancy, and a vacancy is a space the sea can fill.

Rowan watches from the Annex window. As he watches the abandoned house, its edges lose definition. The roof gutter blurs into the sky. The corners soften, less stone than smudge. It becomes difficult to hold in focus; his eye slides off it, drawn back to the occupied houses at the center. The abandoned house is becoming a dropped subject, slipping quietly out of the village’s sentence.

Brynja sits on the hall steps in a triage of hardware — a satellite phone, a laptop, her mobile. He approaches. “The uplink is solid,” she says without looking up, her fingers hammering keys. “Four bars on the sat-phone. Everything works.”

“But no connection?”

“Oh, it connects.” Her voice is tight with the rage of an administrator denied a receipt. “It pings the satellite. The handshake initiates. And then—” She turns the screen to him. A single line: DESTINATION UNKNOWN. “It can’t route the call. Not a dead line. The routing tables can’t find Brynjavík. I tried emergency services. I tried the coast guard. The automated system asks for my location, and when I give the coordinates, it hangs up.” She dials again, listens. “‘Invalid format,’” she narrates, repeating the robotic voice. “‘Please enter a valid geolocation.’” She walks to the edge of the gravel, holding the phone up as if height could cure the problem. “We are right here,” she tells the device. “Sixty-four degrees north. We are on the map.” The silence from the speaker is absolute. “It’s a database error,” she snaps. “Some server in Reykjavík wiped the district codes. It has to be.” She lowers the phone and looks at him, pale, her makeup stark against her skin. “I can’t file the evacuation request if the system doesn’t recognize the origin point. It’s like we don’t exist anymore.” She says it as a clerical grievance. She does not hear

how accurate it is. She throws the phone; it arcs and thuds into the grass without shattering, the screen dark. “I’ll try the radio in the harbour master’s office,” she says, smoothing the yellow jacket. “Analog might bypass it.” She marches off, sure this is a procedure and not an erasure.

Rowan walks the new perimeter. The boundary has moved inward by fifty meters. Arnar kneels in the dirt near the path to the Annex, setting a stone into the earth, rough basalt, the face freshly chiseled. Rowan reads the carving: *-um*. The dative plural. “A new declension?”

Arnar packs soil around the stone. “We are shortening the sentence. The previous clause was too long. Hard to defend.”

“You’re ceding the outer ring.” Rowan looks past the marker to where the path that led to the western ridge used to be. It is not overgrown, not blocked. It is simply not there. The eye expects a track, a depression in the grass, and the grass is unbroken. The landscape has healed over the memory.

“We do not cede,” Arnar says, standing, testing the stone with his boot. “We punctuate. This is where the village ends now.”

“And what lies beyond it?”

Arnar looks at the space where the path used to be, at the blurred outline of the abandoned house. “There is nothing beyond,” he says. Flat, final. Not describing a void but enforcing one; to say *there is nothing* is to make it so. Rowan looks at the nothing and tries to retrieve yesterday’s sheep pen — grey wood, rusted wire — and cannot place it in the current terrain. The reference points are dissolving. “It is safer,” Arnar says, lifting his tools. “A small room is easier to heat. A short sentence is easier to speak.” He walks away, keeping strictly within the new markers. Rowan stares at the invisible line, then steps one foot over the stone, onto the grass of the nothing. The ground feels spongy, insufficient. The air is colder here, and a silence presses against his ears like deep water. He pulls his foot back, and retreats to the side of the stone that still has a name.

• • •

The desk lamp casts a cone of yellow on the blank page. Rowan grips his pen, meaning to write a summary of the morning. *The discovery of the body*, he writes, and stops on the word *body*. It feels insufficient — light, hollow, a shell with the meat taken out. It does not carry Magnús’s weight on the stones; it does not account for the salt in the lungs. He crosses it out. *The discovery of the vessel*, he tries. No — *vessel* implies utility, and Magnús was not used, he was misfiled. His hand hovers. A tremor starts in his wrist. He searches the whole of English for a word that means a container emptied of its self and filled with a hostile geography, and there is no such word. But there is a sound rising unbidden at the back of

his throat. *Sæfangi*. The sea-prisoner. The one held by salt. He writes it down. *Sæfangi found at 06:00*. The Icelandic characters look sharp and distinct on the page; the English around them looks vague, the ink bleeding into the cheap stock.

He tries to continue. *Edda performed the ritual*. His hand locks. *Ritual* is wrong; it implies symbol, and what happened on the rock was mechanical. He searches for the word for the legal retraction of a weather event, and it is *Aflending*, and the pen moves almost on its own. *Edda initiated Aflending*. He drops the pen and pushes the chair back, and the panic that arrives is not adrenaline but a slow cold understanding: the shield of English, the professional distance he came here wearing, is failing, because it cannot describe Brynjavík — it lacks the cases. And he is not surprised, and the lack of surprise is the most frightening thing of all, because it means some part of him always knew that English was a language he had chosen, and that underneath it, waiting, was a first language he had spent thirty years refusing to learn — a mother tongue, in the most literal sense, the tongue of a mother who kept her words behind a wall.

He paces. He needs an anchor. He needs to say one complex English sentence to prove he still owns his own mind. “The sociolinguistic parameters of the village are undergoing a rapid contraction,” he says aloud, and stumbles on *contraction*, the word going mushy in his mouth. “The — the shrinking,” he tries, and the Vikamál arrives with a physical rightness, clicking into the slot *shrinking* could not fill: *sam-drættir*, the drawing-together, the pulling-in of nets. The displacement is aggressive. The dialect is not merely vocabulary; it is colonizing his thought, replacing abstraction with the concrete and the ritual. He is no longer thinking *about* fear. He is thinking about vibration against glass, about a wall of salt writing itself along an iron latch.

He turns to the window. The night is not uniform; there are grades of blackness. At the property edge stands the turf shed where he keeps his bicycle, and he can see its outline, but the outline is flickering. One moment a solid block of shadow; the next, the darkness flows through it, uninterrupted. He blinks and tries to focus. *It is a shed*, he thinks, deliberately, in English, in the nominative. *The shed stands*. And the shed vanishes. No collapse, no fire. It simply ceases to be a reference point, the space it occupied continuous now with the empty field, the eye sliding over it without purchase. He gasps, and feels the hole in the landscape as a hole in himself. He backs into the desk and the notebook falls open to his scrawled notes — English stems weak and dying, Vikamál endings sharp and black and authoritative, a page at war with itself.

He needs to name it before he loses the ability to name it. “Linguistic erosion,” he whispers, forcing the phonemes, and his tongue rebels, curling back, refusing the soft Latinate flow, wanting the grinding consonants of the coast. He tries again. “Linguistic—” His mouth shapes the vowel, his throat constricts, and what comes out is deep and guttural and terrifyingly precise. “*Tungu-taka*.” The

Tongue-Taking. The word tastes of brine and resonates in his chest, vibrating his ribs, heavy and solid and true in a way *erosion* never was. He closes his mouth. He stands in the room's silence, feeling the vibration settle into bone, and he knows now that he is not observing the collapse. He is inside it. And under the fear, quiet and unwelcome, is something almost like relief — the relief of a man who has been speaking a foreign language politely for thirty years and has just, at last, been addressed in his own.

XV



The village of Brynjavík is smaller today than it was yesterday. This is not a trick of light, nor of fog pressing on the cliffs. It is measurable. The path to the northern ridge, once wide enough for a truck, now barely admits the width of Rowan's shoulders. The turf houses on the periphery have been edited out, their mass absorbed into the grey vacancy of the moor, and the remaining structures huddle together like teeth in a shrinking jaw. He walks up the incline with his eyes on his boots, measuring the distance between stones, because the geography is under revision and he no longer trusts it to hold still. To his left Arnar kneels in the mud, wrestling a boundary stone into a fresh depression five meters inward from where it stood, packing wet soil around its base with the flat of a shovel, punctuating the village, shortening the sentence to keep it defensible.

Edda's door is unlatched. It swings open with a weight that suggests the hinges are rusting in real time. Inside, the electric lights are dead; the room is lit by tallow candles set on the floor, their flames perfectly vertical in the still air. The iron stove throws intense heat, yet she sits in her chair wrapped in layers of heavy wool, and she looks like a bird dried in salt wind — light, brittle, made entirely of intent. She does not greet him. She lifts a hand, the skin translucent as parchment, and beckons him to the stool beside her. Her eyes are not cloudy. They are terrifyingly clear, stripped of nostalgia, the eyes of someone preparing to close an account.

"Sit," she says. The verb is stripped of courtesy, a placement command. He sits, and out of reflex reaches into his bag for the recorder, checks the card, sets it on the small table, presses power. The screen flickers and fails to wake. The red light pulses once, a weak starving heartbeat, and dies. He reaches for the backup camera. Nothing; the lens stays retracted, the shutter locked. The devices sit on the wood, inert. They have not broken. They have been dismissed. The room has narrowed its jurisdiction to exclude them, because they are not permitted to witness this, and so they cease to be witnesses.

“Leave them,” Edda says, not looking at the machines. “Paper cannot hold this. Silicon cannot hold this. Only the meat holds it.” She leans forward, smelling of old books and dried kelp, and catches his gaze and holds it. There is no affection in the look, only assessment — she is checking that the vessel is sound before she pours. “Before I give you the weight,” she says, “I will give you the reason. You have carried it long enough not to know it.”

She reaches into the folds of her shawl and brings out the envelope. His envelope. His mother’s hand on it, *for E.B. only*, the paper softened now from being held. She has kept it, all these weeks, unopened, against her skin.

“You slid this across my table the first day,” she says. “You thought you were being a scholar. You were being a son.” She turns it over in her fingers. “Elizabeth. Beth. She was Bryndís, before Cambridge, before she made her name flat enough to fit on an English door. She was born in the house that used to stand where the western nothing is now. She and I learned the grammar at the same table, from the same woman, in the same winter. We were not sisters. This place has no word for sisters that is safe to say near the water. But we were as close as two people are allowed to be named here, which is to say we were never named at all. We simply held the same silence for twenty years.”

Rowan does not move. The candle flames stand straight up. Somewhere under his sternum a door he has kept shut his whole life is being opened by a stranger with a key he did not know existed.

She is quiet a moment, gathering something that costs her.

“You have been asking the wrong question since the road,” she says. “You have been asking what this place is. You should have asked what it is the last of.”

Rowan says nothing.

“There were others.” Her hand moves on the arm of the chair, laying them out, one finger at a time, the way a woman counts stitches. “Not many. Six that were spoken of when my grandmother was taught, and she was taught by a woman born in 1851, so take it as six and do not press me on the number. Six harbours along this coast and the coast opposite, where the grammar was kept. Not the same grammar. Cousins of it. A speaker from here could have made herself understood at Vestrahöfn in a morning and would have needed a winter to be trusted.”

“What happened to them?”

“What happens.” She says it without weight. “One went under the ash in 1783 — not the fire, the ash; the ash came and the sheep died and the people walked east and the grammar does not travel, it is fixed to a water. One modernized. That is the word they used at the time and it is still the correct one. They put in a road and a cannery and a school that taught from the capital, and they were prosperous for forty years and the bay took them in a single night in 1934, and it is in the records as a wave, and it was a wave.” A pause. “One emigrated entire. Manitoba. Every soul. They wrote back for two generations and then they stopped, and what they

were writing by the end was Icelandic and not the other thing, so it does not matter when they stopped. And one — ” and here her mouth thins — “one simply put it down. No disaster. No emigration. A generation decided it was a superstition and their children agreed with them and their grandchildren did not know there had been anything to agree about. The place is still there. You can drive to it. There is a petrol station. The sea took the harbour wall in the eighties and they applied for a grant and rebuilt it and it went again, and they applied again. They are still applying.” She looks at him. “That one frightens me more than the ash.”

“And Brynjavík.”

“Brynjavík is the last one.” She says it flatly, without any pride in it at all, and that is what makes it land. “Not because we were faithful. Not because we were chosen. Nobody chose us and there was nothing to be faithful to — it is a maintenance schedule, Dr. Hale, not a covenant. We are the last one because we did not stop. That is the whole of the distinction. Five harbours had reasons to stop and took them, and every reason was a good one, and here we simply did not have a generation that had a reason good enough at the moment it would have counted.” Her hands go still. “It is luck. It is a hundred and fifty years of a kind of luck that looks exactly like stubbornness from the outside, and I have spent my life being thanked for it, and it is luck.”

Rowan thinks of the district survey with its cream void, of a library catalogue in Reykjavík listing seventeen holdings, of the six that could be pulled from the shelf. He had assumed, for weeks, that Brynjavík was an anomaly. It is a survivor. Those are entirely different objects, and he has been describing the wrong one in every note he has taken.

“The old grammar goes down through the women of one line,” Edda says. “It was to have been hers. She had the throat for it — better than mine. The teacher chose her. And she stood on that shelf one autumn, seventeen years old, and she looked at what the case does to the one who speaks it, at the hands, at the years, at the cost, and she decided she would rather have a life than a boundary.” Her mouth moves, not quite a smile. “She chose the wall over the net. She left, and she never came back, and she never wrote — except once.” She sets the envelope on the table between them. “She wrote this, and did not send it, because to send it would have been to admit she had a debt here, and she had spent her whole second life not admitting it. She raised you inside that not-admitting. You think you became a man who studies withheld speech by accident. You became it because you were raised in the purest example of it in the world.”

“Why did she keep it,” Rowan says, and his voice does not sound like his. “If she never meant to send it.”

“Because a debt does not disappear when you refuse to pay it,” Edda says. “It only waits for someone in the line to carry it back. She could not come. So she made you, and she wrote your vocation into you without telling you, and she died,

and you looked in a tin box and found a coastline you had never seen and thought it was your own idea to come.” She looks at him with something that is almost, but is not quite, pity. “Your mother sent you, Dr. Hale. Forty years late. She sent you to finish the sentence she walked out of.”

He should feel used. He waits to feel used. What he feels instead is the strange loosening of a knot he has been carrying so long he mistook it for the shape of his own spine — the first time in his life that his mother’s silence has had a reason he can hold in his hands, the first time the wall has had a door in it, even a door opening onto grief.

“You will not open it now,” Edda says, and it is not a suggestion. “You are not finished enough to read it. When you can hold the boundary alone, you will be able to hold what she wrote. Not before. Keep it against you.” She closes his fingers over the envelope with a hand like cold twine. “Now. Listen. This is the part the machines wanted.”

She begins.

The sentence starts in the nominative — a naming of the self, but not her self, the Speaker as a position, a location in the coastline’s geometry, the sound low and vibrating in the chest, establishing the subject that will bear the load. Rowan’s breath catches. He tries to catalogue the phonemes and they slide past analysis and hook directly into the nervous system. She moves to the accusative; the direct object is the coastline, and she binds the verb to the rock, defining the action of holding, drawing tension between speaker and land — not description but a bolt tightened, keeping cliff attached to earth. She shifts to the dative, the recipient, and hands the indirect object, the village’s whole debt, to Rowan, and he feels the pressure settle onto his shoulders, a sudden gravity that makes the stool creak. The genitive follows — possession, of the sea, of the storm, of the dark — defining what owns the village, the vowels lengthening, circling, enclosing him inside the claim.

Then the forbidden cases. The Aflending, the Unbinding, in which she speaks the cancellation of her own claim, dissolving the contract that has held her body in this chair for eighty years, the syllables sharp, cutting the threads that tie breath to lung. The Sæfangi, the Sea-Holding, the lock — a sequence of glottal stops and hard consonants that verify the boundary and seal the gate and place the key, not as metaphor but as grammar, in Rowan’s hand; he feels it turn shut somewhere behind his eyes. And finally the Hrimfall, Winterfall, the end of the cycle — the last syllable a whisper that carries the mass of a collapsing glacier, a full stop set at the end of a lifetime of sentences.

The room goes silent, instant and absolute. Rowan sits paralyzed, the whole sequence burning in him, not as words he could repeat but as instructions he cannot forget. He knows the shape of the sentence. He knows it is perfect. He knows it cannot be written.

Edda exhales — a long steady release, no rattle, no struggle. Her chest lowers

and does not rise. Her eyes stay open, but the intent behind them is gone. Her face is smooth; the lines that defined her, the furrowed brow, the set jaw, have slackened. She does not look like someone sleeping. She looks like a woman who has set down, at last, a weight she was never permitted to describe.

Rowan sits in the candlelight, the heat ticking in the stove metal, the envelope in one hand and the grammar in his chest, and he does not weep. He is too heavy to weep. He looks at the dead recorder and the dead woman, and he thinks, with a clarity he will spend the rest of his life failing to soften: she is the second woman he has watched pour herself out entirely so that a room could keep standing, and he is beginning to understand that the rooms are always kept standing by the ones who are used up, and that he is the one still breathing, and that this is not the same as being the one who was strong.

• • •

The basalt platform is a stage set for a tragedy the audience has watched too many times. The villagers assemble under a sky the colour of bruised iron. There is no coffin — Edda's body has been committed to the earth in the high cemetery — but the grammatical committal happens here, facing the plaintiff. Rowan stands at the rear and counts sixty-eight heads, and knows the figure without having to work it, because he has been counting this village since the road, and because the number that is not here is the one he counts by now: eighty-nine at Magnús's committal, sixty-eight at Edda's, and between the two only a season. No one has left by the road. They have left by the other door — the houses on the western perimeter that stopped being spoken, and then stopped being houses, and then stopped. They do not form the usual crescent at the cliff lip; they cluster near the path, leaving a twenty-meter gap between themselves and the drop. A tactical retreat. They know the defense has weakened.

Arnar stands alone in the buffer, in a suit that fits poorly, the fabric strained across the shoulders, the cuffs frayed. He does not have Edda's posture. He stands like a man expecting a blow. He begins the recitation, his voice rough, abraded by salt and sorrow, and he rushes the vowels, clips the long sounds the sea requires, a shorthand version of the rite, summary and not performance. *"From the bone... the salt. From the breath... the wind."* The villagers bow their heads and accept the abridgment. Arnar is a harbour master, not a speaker; he knows knots, not declensions. Rowan hears the error as a physical dissonance in his chest — Arnar uses the standard dative where the instrumental is required, treating the sea as destination rather than vehicle.

Arnar reaches the crux, the Sæfangi, the binding that keeps the name from being absorbed. He inhales, opens his mouth to shape the archaic guttural sounds Edda

spoke in the cottage. “*Hérna fer... Edda... til—*” He stops. His throat works. The silence stretches, taut and vibrating. The wind picks at his jacket. He cannot find the ending. The shape of the word is gone, washed out by grief, or by simple lack of capacity. He looks at the grey expanse and lowers his hands. “*Hvíldu í friði,*” he says. *Rest in peace.* Modern Icelandic, a card-shop phrase, no traction, sliding off the reality of the place like oil off water.

A ripple moves through the crowd. A woman clutches her shawl; a man shifts his weight, ready to run. They wait for the water to answer, for a wave to climb the cliff and erase the error. Rowan watches the bay. It does not rise. It laps gently against the rocks, rhythmic and indifferent. Hiss-thud. Hiss-thud. The sea does not strike. It accepts the modern phrase with a terrifying politeness, the patience of a creditor who knows that interest compounds. The lack of reaction is worse than a storm; a storm would mean the conversation was still going on. This means the sea has stopped negotiating and is content to wait for the default.

Arnar stands a moment, staring at the calm water, understanding the reprieve and its price. He turns his back on the ocean. “It is done,” he says, and the dismissal is instant. The villagers turn and walk away, heavy and fast, no lingering, no shared memory, evacuating the platform as if the air had gone toxic. Rowan remains, and watches Arnar climb, and the harbour master stops when he reaches him. He does not offer a hand. He does not say *I am sorry* or *thank you*. He studies Rowan’s face — the set of the jaw, the stillness in the eyes — looking for the mark of the sentence Edda passed on. He finds it. He nods, short and sharp, not approval, only the look a man gives when the heavy tool has been picked up by the one other person in the shop. *You have it now.* Then he walks past, toward the harbour, to check lines he knows will not hold forever, and Rowan stands alone on the rock, feeling the deferred weight of the ocean pressing at the back of his neck, the envelope stiff against his chest under two layers of wool.

• • •

The dream is not a narrative. It is a lesson. Rowan sits at a wooden desk that smells of pencil shavings and chalk dust. The room is the schoolhouse, but as it was meant to be — warm, dry, the windows sealed against draught, the charts on the walls intact and displaying the full declensions for tide and wind and silence. Edda stands at the blackboard with a piece of limestone chalk and writes a root word. *Haf.* Ocean. “Decline,” she says, not looking at him, looking at the word.

He opens his mouth expecting academic hesitation, the hunt for the suffix, and instead his tongue moves with a muscular memory he does not possess. “*Haf... Hafð... Hafinu... Hafsins—*” He moves through the standard four cases at the speed of breathing. “The binding,” she commands, tapping the board so that the

chalk snaps and leaves a white dot. “*Haf-und... Haf-ing... Haf-hrafn.*” He speaks the ritual cases and the sounds are not foreign; they fit his throat as if they had always been there. He understands that the Aflending lives in the diaphragm, the Sæfangi in the back of the palate, the Hrimfall in the teeth. He is not learning a language. He is learning where to place a sound so that it lands on a target that has no mass. Edda nods and erases the board. “The lesson is concluded,” she says. “The recess is over.”

He wakes. There is no confusion, no disorientation. He opens his eyes to the grey light of the Annex, the air cold and motionless. “*Frostið bindur gluggann,*” he says, and the sentence leaves his lips before thought. *The frost binds the window.* He lies still, listening to his own voice — the pronunciation perfect, the vowel length exact — and feels no thrill, only a dull acceptance, the way a man accepts that he has walked with a limp his whole life and that the bone has finally, quietly, set.

He sits up and looks at the window. It is only fogged, unremarkable. But on the sill outside, and along the top of the boundary stone he can see from the bed, and creeping up the whitewash of the Annex’s northern wall, salt has bloomed overnight — not the ordinary crust of spray but a fine ordered growth of crystal, looping and interlocking into a lattice of sharp angles and closed curves. It is the Sæfangi ending. The Sea-Holding case, written in salt across the skin of his own house. The sea acknowledging the new signatory, laying its counter-signature on the stone.

He dresses quickly. The buttons feel different under his fingers; he is aware of the verb of buttoning, the noun of the cloth, the world resolving into grammatical components. He steps outside. The gravel is wet, the fog rolling in from the bay and erasing the horizon, and he looks toward the spot where Brynja parked her jeep. The space is empty. Tire tracks score the mud, deep and frantic, spinning and veering, leading away toward the coastal road. He follows them with his eyes. Fifty meters up, they reach the point where the road was edited out, and they do not stop, and they do not turn. They fade into heather and moss. Mud becomes grass; impression becomes texture. Brynja did not crash. She drove out of the sentence and the narrative let her go.

He understands, dimly, why it could let her go. She had spoken Reykjavík standard the entire time she was here — clean nominatives, active verbs, no ritual cases. The village never declined her. To its grammar she was a foreign substance, never grafted in, only suspended in the text like an unincorporated quotation, and a quotation can be lifted out without tearing the page. She was never bound, and so the cases that would have held a villager in place had nothing to grip. It is not a consolation. It is the opposite. Because he knows he is no longer in her category. Somewhere in these weeks his own speech began to take the local endings, and now she is the third — Edda, Sigrún, and the granddaughter with the yellow jacket, three

women gone from the sentence by three different doors — and he is the one still standing in it, and the thought arrives cold and exact: the village keeps whoever it has managed to bind, and it has bound him, and being kept is not the same as being spared.

He turns back to the village. The fog thickens, swirling around the eaves, and he feels the pressure building behind the mist, an accumulated memory pressing on the thin membrane of the land. He walks to the boundary stone Arnar planted and places his hand on the cold basalt. There is a vibration in the rock, a low hum, a question waiting for an answer. Rowan stands at the edge of the text, no longer a reader. He inhales, holds the air in the center of his chest, and waits for the first line of the storm to be spoken.

XVI



Rowan packs the Annex with the detached precision of an archivist closing a wing of a library that no longer receives visitors. He does not rush. To rush would be to admit a fear that requires a verb of motion, and he is holding himself, this morning, in the nominative. He places the recorder — its screen dead and grey — into the padded compartment of his bag. He stacks the notebooks, the early ones full of clean English syntax, the later ones scarred with the heavy angular script of Vikamál, and slides them into the main pocket. He checks the room: the bed stripped, the desk clear, the space anonymous again, a vacuum waiting for the next noun to occupy it. He shoulders the bag. The weight is significant, a physical reminder of the data he tried to extract and could not translate. Against his chest, under the wool, the envelope. He has not opened it. He is not finished enough to read it. He believes her.

He steps out into the morning. The fog hangs ten meters from the door, a white wall that swallows the world's context. He walks north toward the coastal road that once connected Brynjavík to the arteries of the continent. His gait is steady. His boots find purchase on gravel that feels disturbingly loose, as if the stones were merely resting on the surface rather than set into the earth. He passes the marker stone Arnar planted, the rune for boundary wet with condensation, and steps past it.

He expects resistance — wind rising, mud deepening, a wave thrown across the track. There is none. There is only absence. Ten meters past the stone, the gravel road stops. It does not end at a cliff edge; it does not wash out into scree. It simply thins into the texture of the moor. One meter: road, graded and defined. The next: the vague general idea of ground. He stops, the toe of his left boot on gravel, the toe of his right hovering over moss that looks poorly finished, its colour a flat unshaded green. He steps onto the moss. It holds his weight, but it feels sponge-like, insufficient.

He walks forward, searching for the bend in the road that skirts the headland. He remembers it. He has driven it. He has seen it on the map. He looks up to find the headland, and it is there, a dark mass against the white sky, but it is wrong — the profile smooth, lacking the jagged fractures he documented on the day he arrived, like a shape sketched in and not yet given its detail. He blinks, and when he opens his eyes the headland has shifted, its peak now to the left of center. He turns to check the coastline, and the sea is a flat grey plane, no waves, no texture, a field of colour with no incident in it. He looks back at the headland. It has settled into a low ridge.

His heart hammers, but his mind stays coldly analytical. The land is relying on his attention to keep its shape, he notes; where no one looks, the geometry lets go. He takes another step and the ground ripples — not an earthquake, an uncertainty — moss becoming slate and then moss again, cycling through the terrains it might be because no one has committed the surface to a final form. He scans for the tire tracks of Brynja's jeep and finds a rut that ends abruptly, the earth smoothing over as if the vehicle had simply stopped displacing matter. She did not crash. She drove until the world stopped describing the road, and she followed the silence out.

He turns in a circle. The landscape is fluid, sickeningly pliable. A boulder in the middle distance elongates, stretching upward like drawn taffy, then snaps back to a sphere when his gaze settles on it. The horizon bends inward, unable to hold the illusion of infinite distance. This is a place that was held together by being spoken, and out here no one is speaking it, and so it is coming untied, the way a knot comes untied when the tension leaves the line.

He looks back. Brynjavík stands in the fog — small, huddled, monochrome — but it is sharp. The rooflines are distinct. The wall stones are counted and fixed. Smoke rises from Arnar's chimney and obeys the wind, dispersing in a plume that behaves. The village is rendered in hard edges because it is still being spoken, sustained by the grammar of the few throats left in it. Rowan stands at the edge of the unwritten world, looking at the blur of moor where a sheep appears and dissolves into white, and then at the village, where the walls are hard and the consequences are fatal. He does not feel relief. He feels the cold administrative weight of a decision with no good option. To stay is to be held inside a dying sentence. To leave is to become a smudge in a deleted draft, like the granddaughter, unmourned because unnameable.

He adjusts the strap of his bag. He turns his back on the fluid, uncommitted horizon and walks back toward the gravel, toward the boundary stone, and when his boot hits the road the sound is crisp — a clean, defined crunch, a grammatical sound. Rowan Hale returns to Brynjavík not because he is brave and not because he is resigned. He returns because it is the only place left where he still has a name, and because his mother left the debt unpaid, and because he has finally understood that the envelope against his chest is not a letter to a stranger. It is a forwarding

address.

• • •

The church is on his way, and he does not intend to stop, and he stops.

It is a small white timber building with a red roof, of a design repeated four hundred times around the coast of Iceland, and it is warm inside, and it smells of paraffin and old wood and the wet wool of a congregation that left an hour ago. Séra Hjálmar is at the front, gathering hymnals off the pews and stacking them in the crook of his arm, and he does not look up when the door opens, because in nineteen years no one has come through that door whom he needed to look up for.

“Dr. Hale.”

“I wanted to ask you something before I go up.”

“You are not going anywhere, though.” The pastor sets the stack on the front pew and straightens, and his face is kind and entirely unsurprised. “Forgive me. Arnar came by at seven. He said you had walked out to the road and come back. He did not say it as gossip. He said it the way a man tells you the tide is in.”

Rowan takes the hymnal off the top of the stack and opens it to page nine and holds it out, and does not say anything, because the question is on the page and they both know what it is.

Hjálmar looks at it for a moment. Then he sits down on the pew, heavily, like a man who has been waiting a long time to be asked and has not enjoyed the wait.

“*Verði að þínum vilja*,” he says.

“Every book in the village. Including the ones bought in Reykjavík.”

“Including the one on my own shelf that my mother gave me at my ordination, in Selfoss, in 2001, which read *verði þinn vilji* when she wrote in the front of it, and which reads what it reads now.” He says this without drama, as a fact he checked years ago and has had to live beside since. “I did not do it. My predecessor did not do it. It is not done. It is what happens to the sentence when it is kept here.”

“Why that line?” Rowan sits down across the aisle. “There are twenty lines in the prayer. Why the will?”

“Because it is the only one where something other than a man is permitted to want something.” Hjálmar folds his hands. “Think about what you have been doing all autumn, Doctor. You have watched this village spend a thousand years teaching itself one rule, and only one: that a will in the nominative can act. That is the whole of it. That is the entire theology of this coast, and it is not a theology, it is a load rating.”

And it arrives, all at once, the way the true reading of a difficult line arrives — not as a discovery but as a thing that has been legible for weeks and merely unread.

The rule cannot make exceptions. That is what makes it a rule. If the congregation of Brynjavík stands up on a Sunday morning, eighty voices, half a kilometre

from the water, and says aloud that a will — any will, even and especially the highest one — may stand in the nominative and be done, then they have not made a statement about God. They have made a demonstration. They have shown the listener, in chorus, weekly, for four centuries, that the case is available. That it works. That a thing which wants may be a subject.

And there is something in the bay that has been listening to every service since 1732, and it does not know theology, and it does not care whose will it is. It only learns the grammar.

“You demoted Him,” Rowan says. “To keep the rule airtight.”

“We did not demote anyone.” Hjálmar’s voice does not rise, but something in it hardens, and Rowan understands that he has just heard the pastor’s one point of pride. “That is what a man from Cambridge would call it and I would ask him to consider whether he has understood what he is looking at. We did not make God smaller. We stopped shouting His name across the water.” He turns the hymnal on his knee. “There is no difference, Doctor, between *thy will be done* and *let it be done according to thy will*, except one. In the second, the will is still perfect and still sovereign and still the thing the whole world bends toward. It simply is not standing up where the sea can see it.”

He hands the book back.

“I say it that way,” he says. “I have said it that way for nineteen years, in front of a font, in a cassock, in a church of the Evangelical Lutheran Church of Iceland, and I have never once felt that I was lying, and I have never once written to the bishop about it, and I am not going to. He would send someone. Someone would correct the books.” A long breath. “And then, one Sunday, eighty people would stand up in this room and say the other thing.”

Rowan looks at the altar, at the plain wooden cross, at the numbers still up on the hymn board from the morning.

“Does it trouble you?” he asks. “Not knowing which one holds this place up?”

“It troubled me for eleven years,” Hjálmar says. “Then I buried a child, and I said the burial over her, and I meant every word of it, and afterward I walked up the hill and stood at the back while Edda said the other thing over her, and I meant that too.” He stands, and picks up his stack of books. “One of them tells her mother why. The other one keeps the ground under the churchyard. I have stopped requiring them to compete. I would recommend it. It is late in the season to be sorting your convictions into the correct boxes.”

At the door he says, without turning: “There will be a service on Sunday. There is always a service on Sunday. You do not have to come and you would be welcome.” And then, quieter, in the tone of a man setting down something he has carried: “Hold the line well, Dr. Hale. I will hold mine. Between us, perhaps, the two of them will hold each other.”

• • •

He does not return to the Annex. He walks past the darkened windows of the guest house, his stride measuring the remaining pavement, and goes directly to the shoreline, to the basalt shelf that juts into the bay like a tongue of hardened lava. The wind has died. The silence is not empty; it is expectant, pressing on the eardrums, waiting for an input. He climbs onto the platform and stands where Edda stood, where Arnar failed. He does not set down his bag. He does not clear his throat or close his eyes to center himself. He looks at the water.

The bay is high, swollen with the grey mass of the Atlantic, lapping inches from his boots, confident, having already claimed the margin. Rowan opens his mouth. He speaks.

“Hér stendur maður.” Here stands a man. The nominative. He places himself as subject. He does not shout; the volume is conversational, the tone of a surveyor reading a coordinate aloud. He shifts to the accusative and addresses the boundary. *“Ég bind steininn við landið.” I bind the stone to the land.* His voice is different now, not the borrowed accent of a Cambridge academic imitating a dialect but something produced deep in the chest, resonant and flat, the consonants striking the air like flint. He moves to the dative, the giving. *“Ég gef þér salt, en ekki blóð.” I give you salt, but not blood.* The water at his feet ripples — not a wave, a shudder, as if its surface tension had changed. He feels the grammar lock into place, not magic but engineering, a sea-wall built out of syntax. He reaches for the genitive. *“Hafsins er dýpið, en landsins er brúnin.” The deep belongs to the ocean, but the edge belongs to the land.* Separation. Ownership defined.

Then the forbidden cases. He does not hesitate. He steps into the structures Edda died teaching. The Aflending, the unbinding: *“Aldan skal unda. Straumur skal undi.”* Forward momentum cancelled, the suffix applied, and the water flinches, the bay pulling back and sliding smoothly off the basalt, no crash, no foam, a retreat like a heavy curtain drawn across a stage. The Sæfangi, the sea-holding: he raises his hand and traces the shape in the air — the hook, the loop, the slash. *“Nafnið er fast. Staðurinn er hér.” The name is fixed. The place is here.*

As he speaks the locking clause a shadow moves at the edge of his vision. Arnar steps onto the rock, quiet, his boots silent on the wet stone. He does not look at Rowan with awe. He looks with grim recognition, the expression of a man watching another soldier pick up a live grenade. He stands two paces behind, to the left, and does not take the lead. He waits for the gap in the syntax. Rowan initiates the final case, the Hrimfall, Winterfall, the contract sealed. *“Ísinn kemur—”* he begins.

“—og þögnin geymir,” Arnar finishes. *The ice comes... and the silence keeps.* Arnar’s voice is a low rumble, ballast under Rowan’s line, reinforcing the structure. Where Rowan defines a wall, Arnar mortars the joints. Together they speak the

new coordinates. They do not ask the sea to leave; they concede the outer fields, abandon the western ridge, surrender the memory of sheep pens and old drying racks. The circle tightens around the village's core. "Hér er markið," Rowan says. *Here is the mark.* "Og ekki lengra," Arnar adds. *And no further.*

The sea responds with a massive hydraulic concession. The water level in the harbour drops two meters, exposing the black slime-slicked wood of eighteenth-century pilings, revealing the stone foundations of boathouses lost in the storms of the 1920s. The revealed structures are not ruins; they are entries. The sea has kept them catalogued in the dark, and now it lays them bare on the mudflats, wet and black and smelling of ancient decay, as proof that it remembers everything and forgives nothing without being asked in the correct case. It is not a victory. The sea has not fled. It has accepted the edit and agreed to the margin, for now.

Rowan stops speaking. The silence that follows is instant and concrete. The vibration in the basalt ceases. The air feels thinner, sharper, cleared of the static that has hummed in his ears for days. Arnar exhales and takes the tobacco pouch from his pocket, and his hands shake, but he rolls a cigarette with practiced muscle memory. He does not light it. He holds it, staring at the exposed ribs of the old pier. "The western wall will need pointing," he says, his voice raspy. "Since we are keeping it."

"The geometry holds," Rowan replies. He is drained, heavy as wet rope.

"It holds," Arnar agrees. He looks at the village, huddled and small beneath a vast indifferent sky. "It is a small room. But it has a floor." They stand together on the wet rock, two men holding a heavy door shut against a gale, neither celebrating the survival nor mourning the loss of the view.

And standing there, spent, Rowan lets himself think the thought he has been holding at arm's length since the cottage, because he owes it to the three of them not to look away. He is on this rock because a woman poured out her voice and died, and because another woman before her poured out her nerve in a schoolhouse and was folded into a cairn under her own withheld name, and because a third drove out of the world unnamed carrying a card full of images that curdled into script. He inherits the stewardship not despite the fact that they were used up but because they were — the net is woven from the ones who were spent thin. He is the man left standing, and the village will call it strength, and it is not strength; it is only survival, and survival here has always been paid for by someone else, and always, so far, by the women. He does not know how to carry that. He decides only that he will carry it awake, that he will not let it become one more thing held at a distance and re-labelled, that whatever else the boundary costs, it will not cost him the honesty of knowing who paid for it before him.

• • •

Night does not bring darkness so much as a suspension of light. Rowan sleeps in the Annex, his body motionless, his breath shallow and synchronized with the draught whistling through the keyhole, and he is not in the Annex. He is in the schoolhouse. The dream is high-contrast, etched in the stark black and white of a woodcut. Sun streams through clean windows, the glass free of grime and condensation, the dust motes in the beams not debris but pollen, potential life. Edda stands at the blackboard — not the dying woman, nor the corpse on the platform, but the teacher, her spine straight, her hand steady as the chalk drives across the slate. She writes the endings. *-und. -ing. -hrafn*. The classroom is full. The children of Brynjavík sit in rows — not the children who left for Reykjavík, but the children who are always here, the potential, the memory, the future tense, in wool sweaters, with attentive eyes.

“Again,” Edda says. “*Sæfangið bindur*,” the children chant, their voices a single harmonic chord. *The Sea-Holding binds*. Rowan stands in the doorway — not seated at a desk, no notebook — leaning against the frame, arms crossed, watching the lesson. He understands the hierarchy. He is not here to learn conjugation; he is here to keep the classroom standing so the lesson can go on. Edda looks up from the board and sees him and does not smile. She nods, a single sharp depression of the chin. The handover of the chalk. “The margin is set,” she says to the class, but her eyes are on him.

Rowan wakes. The transition is gradual, a rising from the dream’s depth to the surface of a grey and cold morning. He lies still, feeling the dream recede, but the weight of the chalk remains in his hand. He flexes his fingers. The stiffness is gone. The tremors that plagued him, the somatic symptoms of a body being asked to hold a grammar it was not built for, have vanished. He looks at the window. The pane is frosted, and it is not random fernwork; the ice has crystallized into a rigorous geometric structure, a perfect lattice of intersecting lines and hooks and closures. The *Sæfangi* case. The ending he spoke on the platform.

He throws off the quilt. The cold bites, but it feels bracing rather than hostile. He walks to the window on floorboards that are solid under his feet, the house settled, its joints quiet, its foundation gripping the earth. He raises his hand and presses his index finger to the glass and traces the frost, following the binding rune, warm skin sliding over cold ice, and the sea has answered — its counter-signature written on the glass. Accepted. The ice melts beneath his touch and a drop of water runs down the pane, cutting through the pattern, erasing the sign, and it does not matter, because the sign does not need to persist. The agreement has been made.

He steps back. He does not say *I am the guardian*. He does not think *I have saved them*. He adjusts his stance — feet widening slightly, center of gravity lowering, shoulders rolling back, settling the village’s weight into the architecture of his spine, heavy but balanced now, because he knows at last how to carry it. He looks out at the village as the fog lifts, revealing black clouds stacked over the

ridge and the narrow safe streets between the remaining houses. The world has snapped into a smaller, harder shape. There is less of it, but what remains is real. Rowan breathes in. The air is cold and tastes of salt, and he holds it a moment, feeling the grammar of it in his lungs, then exhales, ready to begin the long work of maintenance.

XVII



The dawn dilutes the grey dark just enough to distinguish water from rock. Rowan Hale stands on the basalt shelf, his feet finding the same two depressions in the stone they found yesterday and the day before, the leather of his boots long since molded to the geology. He is no longer a visitor standing on the surface of the place. He is a fitted part of the platform. He begins the morning maintenance.

He speaks the nominative of position, and the sound that leaves his throat is not smooth; it is textured, roughened by salt air and repetition, ground by thousands of utterances into something harder and more fibrous than the voice he arrived with. “*Hér er steinninn.*” *Here is the stone.* The water at the shelf’s edge, which has been creeping upward with the stealth of rising damp, halts and accepts the definition. He shifts his weight, and his left knee clicks, a dry popping sound that marks the slow erosion of the joint, and he does not wince. The pain is a kind of information. It confirms that the cold has settled deep enough to be respected.

He moves to the genitive of boundary. “*Vatnsins er djúpið.*” *The deep belongs to the water.* He extends his right hand, the skin of the fingertips thickened, the ridges of the prints worn nearly smooth by years of stone and wood, and traces a horizontal line in the air, a cut severing the rising tide from the vertical cliff. The sea obeys, sliding back to expose a strip of black algae that glistens like wet oil, the retreat precise, exactly to the line his voice prescribed. There is no negotiation this morning, only the execution of a standing agreement. The ocean is not an enemy to be fought. It is a great volume of water that must be spoken to, in the right case, at the right hour, forever.

He has stood eleven Great Keepings. He does not think about them the way he thought about the first, that midwinter, when he walked the whole perimeter in the dark with sixty-odd people and four hurricane lamps and braced himself all night for the reading of the names to be the terrible thing a season in Brynjavík had taught him to expect. It was not terrible. It took four hours. A woman beside

him complained quietly and without interruption about her hip, and a boy was sent home at the halfway stone for laughing, and someone had brought a flask of coffee that had gone cold by the second hour and was drunk anyway.

He understood something that night that he has never been able to put into a sentence a colleague would have accepted, and has therefore never written down, which is now his standard test for whether a thing is true. The names are not said to the water. They are said in front of it. There is a difference, and the difference is the entire practice, and it is the reason a village can stand on a cliff in the dark and speak aloud, for four hours, every name it has, and be safe — and the reason that a single man, saying a single name, in the wrong case, at the wrong hour, is not.

Behind him the village waits. It is smaller than it was in the time of the buses, but the contraction is not violent; there are no heaps of rubble where the western farmstead stood, only moor, green and spongy, quietly reclaiming the ground where a kitchen once was. When a house loses its speaker, it loses its right to displace the air; the fog moves in, the definition blurs, and one morning the grass is simply uninterrupted. Rowan turns from the water, satisfied with the margin, and walks back along the path toward the cluster of remaining structures. He passes Bjarni, seated on a plastic crate mending a net — Bjarni, who was hauled off the harbour wall by a rope because no one could find the case that would have let them use his name, and who came back up the steps with a vowel in his throat he has never quite put down. He has a daughter now — small, grave, better at the boundary walk than her father was at twice her age — and he does not talk. Whatever the water taught him on the way under, he has kept it the way this place keeps everything, which is to say completely and without reference. The two men nod once to each other, downward, a shift change acknowledged, the perimeter held. Further along, Einar sits in the lee of the curing house with the glass eye turned to the weather and the good one on his hands, and lifts two fingers off the twine as Rowan passes, and that is the whole of the morning's conversation, and it is sufficient.

He reaches the cottage that was Edda's and is now the mechanism that is Rowan. The hinges are greased and silent. Inside, the air is dry, kept so by the stove he feeds with regulated turf, and he hangs his coat on a peg, the wool stiff with salt. In the corner his academic notebooks are stacked, the pages yellowing and curling — theories of linguistic drift, diagrams of isolation, publication dates that have stopped meaning anything, the drawings of a machine made by someone who never once had to run one. He ignores them and picks up a chisel.

The roof's main beam, a massive length of driftwood pine, is covered in carvings. Near the ceiling are Edda's marks, sharp angular runes that handled the storms of the nineties; below them are Rowan's own additions. He runs his thumb over a fresh gouge. Yesterday the wind tested the north gable, seeking a weakness in the accusative, and he felt the draught and knew the verb was too weak to hold

it. He sets the chisel and carves the correction into the infrastructure of the house. “*Styrkja.*” *Strengthen.* He taps the handle — *tak* — and the wood curls away, and resin fills the room, a necessary scent, a binding agent, and he cuts the suffix *-ur*, locking the strength into the noun of the house. His hand cramps, the muscles seizing into the shape of the tool, and he waits, breathing steadily, until the spasm passes. The body wears down. The tool wears down. The grammar holds. He surveys the lexicon on the walls — not a history but the wiring of a house that will fall if he stops carving, dissolve if he stops speaking. He is not preserving a culture. He is keeping the rain out. He sets the chisel down and pours water from the kettle, and his reflection in the dark window shows a face eroded by the same weather that strips the cliffs, the hair gone grey, the eyes flat, become instruments that no longer look for meaning, only for fault lines. He drinks. The heat soothes the throat that will speak again at dusk.

• • •

The schoolhouse does not hold heat; the radiators are cold iron ribs, dead since the oil route was struck from the district map. Rowan comes here because the last fragments of the curriculum remain, and because Sigrún is here. She sits at a child’s desk by the window, wrapped in a blanket that smells of mothballs and damp wool, her skin gone the yellow of the parchment maps on the wall. She does not cough. The decay is silent, a slow unbinding at the level of the cell.

He sits opposite and sets a tin of dried fish on the desk. She ignores it. “The wind has changed,” she says. “North-northwest. The declension must shift.”

“I’ve been using the dative. Giving the wind to the hill.”

She shakes her head. “Too heavy. Give it all to the hill and the hill slides. Split the load.” She lifts a hand, the fingers crooked, the joints swollen, and breathes on the cold slate of the old blackboard beside her until a patch of fog forms on the stone. Into the fog she draws a hook that loops back on itself, the knot used to secure a boat in a gale. “The *Sæfangi*,” she murmurs. “Only the first clause. Don’t draw the second.”

“If I don’t close it, the loop stays open.”

“Yes.” Her eyes are sharp, lucid within the ruin of her. “Leave it open. Let Einar speak the second clause. Or let the silence speak it.” She withdraws her hand, and the breath-fog holds the hook a moment on the slate before it fades. “Edda tried to hold the whole bay,” she says. “She tried to be the wall. Walls crack. You are not a wall, Rowan. You are a net. Nets have holes, and the holes are how they hold.”

“Distributed grammar,” Rowan says, the academic term surfacing like a phantom limb.

“Spread the load,” she corrects, in the plain English she has scavenged from some old manual. “Carry everything yourself and you fail. Carry it together and

the failure of any one throat is only a hole, and a net survives holes.” She closes her eyes. “Go now. The lesson is done. I need to save my breath.” He leaves her in the grey light, her finger resting near the fading hook.

The next morning the chair is empty. There is no body, no sign of struggle, the blanket folded with its edges squared to the grain of the desk. On the blackboard, written steadily in white chalk: *Gengin*. Gone, or Walked. The damp air has already erased the lower halves of the letters.

The village convenes at the edge of the schoolyard — not to mourn but to re-sort the register. They stand in a triangle, Rowan at the apex, Einar to the left, old Halla to the right, and the sea before them is flat, a perfect mirror, waiting. Rowan speaks first. “*Sigrún var hér.*” *Sigrún was here.* He steps back. Einar steps forward. “*Við kveðjum hana.*” *We release her.* He retreats, and Halla steps up. “*Til moldarinnar, ekki til hafsins.*” *To the earth, not the sea.* She leaves the final vowel unresolved, and the silence carries the rest of the sentence, the grammar thinned deliberately across three throats so that there is no single point that can fail. The sea scans the phrasing, finds no amplitude to challenge, and stays dormant. The water laps against the rock. Hush. Hush. The books balance — this once, and Rowan lets the old word come, because Sigrún would have used it, because she died correcting his arithmetic, because a debt that closes cleanly deserves, for one morning, to be called by the name she would have given it.

• • •

The perimeter tightens again. The outlying sheds lose their standing in the sentence and the moor absorbs them, and the distance from one end of the village to the other shortens by subtraction, month by month, until a man can cross the whole of Brynjarvík in the time it once took to walk to the quay.

Arnar lasts the winter. The friction of it wears him down; his movements go segmented, each one costing him a visible sum, and when the spring tide rises he does not come back from the harbour. Rowan finds him at low water, curled like dried kelp between the pilings, one hand extended — not clawing, offering. “The bollards,” Arnar whispers. “The third one. Loose.”

“I’ll fix it.”

“No. Speak to it. The iron is tired. Use *festar*.” Metal fatigue, given its true case. A wheeze, and something that on another face might have been humor. “And the moon — lie to it. Tell it the boats are stone.” His hand drops, and he becomes an object, and the sea does not gloat, and does not hurry. Rowan closes the pale eyes and lays his own hand on the loose bollard. “*Þú ert berg,*” he says. *You are rock.* The metal vibrates once and settles, and the maintenance continues, because the maintenance is the only thing that does not end.

Summer brings a few visitors, blown off course, arriving by accident because Brynjavík is no longer a place a person can mean to go. A doctoral candidate finds her way down the ruined track one bright afternoon, a recorder blinking red in her hand, her gaze hungry in a way Rowan recognizes with a sorrow he did not expect. “A linguistic time capsule,” she says, delighted, looking at the carved beams, the truncated speech.

“It’s a dam,” Rowan says.

She does not understand him, and he does not try again. He gives her sheep words and fish words, the safe currency, the vocabulary a language leaves out on the counter for strangers.

She is packing the recorder into its case when she says, conversationally, that she should thank the woman who pointed her this way in the first place — a producer at the council, media side, very organised, drove her out to the junction herself and drew the last part of the route on the back of a receipt because the satnav would not take it.

“Þórhallsdóttir,” the candidate says, hunting the name. “Brynja something. Do you know her? She said she’d been up here once, years ago.”

Rowan holds very still. “Where is she now?”

“Hvalsker.” The girl zips the case. “Small place, further round the coast. She moved out there after the divorce, I think. Very pretty. They have a lovely harbour — well, they’re rebuilding it again, apparently. Third time. She was funny about it, actually, she said the whole village does nothing but write grant applications for that wall.” She laughs. “Anyway. She was lovely. She said to say hello if I found the place.”

“Did she,” Rowan says.

“She said — ” and the girl frowns slightly, retrieving it with the mild puzzlement of someone repeating a remark that had struck her as odd and then stopped mattering. “She said, *tell them I did get out, if there’s anyone left who’d know what that means.*” She shoulders the bag. “I assumed it was a joke about the roads.”

Rowan says nothing. He walks her to the car, and shakes her hand, and watches her go.

She is alive. She is well. She lives in a bright house in Hvalsker, which is the harbour that put the grammar down two generations ago because a sensible people decided it was a superstition, and where the sea has taken the wall three times in forty years, and where they are still applying, and where they will go on applying until the applications outlive the applicants. She got out. She drove through the part of the world that had stopped describing the road and came out the other side into a country that had never heard of any of this, and she is fine, and she has a job and a divorce and a view, and once a year or so she says a thing at a party that makes people look at her strangely, and she has learned to say it as a joke about the roads.

She escaped into the exact future Brynjavík has spent a thousand years refusing.

And she is right. That is the part Rowan makes himself hold. She was right to go, and she is happier than anyone here, and the price of her being right is only that the wall at Hvalsker will go again in the spring, and that nobody there will connect the two facts, and that nobody there will have to.

He watches the dust of the candidate's going settle back onto the track. The disappointment he sent her away with is a mercy. His relief is the relief of a man who has kept someone out of a machine that would have taken her fingers. And under it, unwelcome and exact, is the thing he has spent years not looking at: that he could have gone too, and that the difference between him and Brynja Þórhallsdóttir is not courage and is not virtue. It is that she was never bound and he was, and being kept is not the same as being spared.

The light shifts. The grey returns, as it always returns. Rowan stands on the basalt, his hair white now, his hands stained with the grain of the wood he cuts. He is not the linguist who arrived. He is the operator of a thing the linguist could only describe. He speaks into the dusk. "*Hér erum við.*" *Here we are.* Plural — because he is not alone now, because Einar holds the second clause and Halla the third, because Sigrún taught him that a net is stronger than a wall precisely where it is full of gaps. "*Sjórinn bíður,*" he says. *The sea waits.* "*Landið stendur.*" *The land stands.* He traces the Sæfangi in the air, the motion mechanical, functional, worn to a habit, and the wave hesitates, reads the syntax, and recedes. Rowan stays, the sentence left open, the verb still active, the loop unclosed and held by other throats. The boundary holds tonight. Because it holds tonight, and because the grammar is distributed now across more than one failing body, it will hold tomorrow.

XVIII



The light that bleeds into the sky above the North Atlantic is a negotiation. It bargains with the dark water for the right to lay itself across the wet black stone of the coast, and on the basalt shelf that juts from the broken jaw of the land, Rowan Hale stands as the mediator. He is not the man who arrived with a recorder and a waterproof notebook; that man has been edited out of the narrative, his softness abraded by salt, his academic curiosity replaced by the heavy rhythmic necessity of maintenance. Rowan is thinner now. The cables of his neck stand against the collar of a sweater that smells of lanolin and woodsmoke, and his hands, hanging at his sides, are maps of the terrain — the knuckles swollen with cold, the skin thickened into a hide that resists the stinging spray.

He breathes. The air is frigid and tastes of iodine and ancient decay, and his exhalation is a white plume that drifts a moment before the wind takes it and disperses the heat of his body into the vast indifferent cold. Behind him the village huddles, smaller than it was a year ago, its geography revised — the outer farmsteads, the rotting fences of the sheep runs, the connector road that once wound toward the pass, all of them not ruined but simply absent, the land healed over them, smooth and green and amnesiac. The village has contracted to its grammatical core, a few cottages that still hold warmth, the smoke rising from their chimneys in vertical lines of defiance, the silence between the walls doing the work of mortar. Rowan does not look back at what has been lost. To acknowledge an absence is to invite the void to expand. He keeps his eyes on the water.

The ocean is restless. It heaves against the stone shelf, a grey muscular mass that does not answer to the tide tables but to the logic of memory, slapping the rock, hissing, testing the perimeter, seeking a lapse in the syntax, a stutter in the sentence that decides where the land ends and the water begins. Rowan plants his feet in the two smooth hollows worn by the boots of Edda, and her mother, and the speakers before them, and his feet fit the mold, and the stone grips him. He raises his hands, the movement stiff, the cold long since settled into the joints as a permanent ache that serves to remind him of the stakes: if he stops, the pain stops, because the body stops.

He waits for the trough of a wave, because the word must land in the silence between crashes or the meaning will be drowned before it can set. The water draws

back, sucking at the shingle with the sound of a thousand small stones inhaled, and Rowan speaks.

“*Hafið man.*” *The sea remembers.* The nominative, the naming of the subject. He does not shout; shouting suggests panic, and panic is a weakness the grammar cannot support. He projects from the diaphragm, resonating the vowels in his chest so that they leave him as hard distinct objects. He names the water not as a body but as a consciousness, granting it subject status, because to hold a thing you must first admit that it exists and that it has a will. The Atlantic answers — not with a surge but with a subtle, terrifying reordering of its surface. Ten meters out, the foam on the crest of a dark swell does not scatter at random; the white arrests its own decay and drifts together against the wind, forming lines and curves on the black canvas of the trough, spelling back the echo of his claim, transcribing the input. It acknowledges the subject.

He holds his stance while the wind tears at hair gone the colour of surf, feeling the vibration of the acknowledgment travel up through the soles of his boots, the platform humming, the entity in the water accepting the call. He does not relax. The acknowledgment is only a handshake, the connection made and the argument not yet won. The sea remembers, yes; it remembers everything — the valley before the lava, the breath of the men it took last winter, the taste of the wood of the pier it swallowed. Now he must tell it what to let lie.

• • •

He shifts the grammar, moving from subject to object, from naming to command. “*Landið gleymir hafinu.*” *The land forgets the sea.* He pushes the direct object away, placing the water in the position of the thing forgotten, and the logic is brutal in its simplicity: if the land forgets the sea, the sea cannot touch the land, because memory is the bridge and forgetting is the chasm. The effect is hydraulic. The water at the base of the platform does not merely flow back; it recoils, shoved by the invisible hand of the case, the tide withdrawing three meters in a single smooth motion, sliding off the rock as if the stone had turned white-hot. In the newly exposed seabed, stones that have not seen air since the last high tide shine like wet eyes, and a tangle of black kelp lies steaming in the cold dawn.

He does not pause; the vacuum must be filled with the next case before the water understands the trade. He steps forward, his toes over the lip, and offers the tribute. “*Hafinu skilum við orðum.*” *To the sea we return words.* The dative, the giving. He feeds the bay’s hunger with syllables so that it does not feed on silt and foundation stone, and the water ripples in perfect concentric rings that spread from the point beneath his face, flattening the incoming swell, and he feels the drain of it — the dative takes, it takes warmth from the blood and moisture from the throat, and his

skin tightens as if the water in his own cells were being offered up along with the nouns. He persists, reaching for the genitive, the root of ownership. “*Minninga er málfræðin sköpuð.*” *Of memory, all grammar is made.* His voice loses its human rasp and takes on the timbre of the basalt itself, grinding and deep, asserting that the structure of the world belongs to memory and therefore to those who remember. The shadows on the rock elongate and snap back into hard pools of black; the light itself seems to struggle to hold the world steady between the fluid chaos of the ocean and the rigid order of the sentence, and cold sweat runs down his spine and freezes at his waistband, because the genitive is heavy, and it requires him to hold all of it in his mind at once — every drowned sailor, every lost ship, every word spoken in Brynjarvík for a thousand years — to hold it and to claim it.

Then the precipice. The Aflending, the unbinding. This is the case that broke Edda: the impossible one, that unbinds a force by naming its freedom and, in the same breath, binds it to a limit. His hands tremble as he raises them high, fingers splayed, cutting the sigil into the grey air — the hook, the slash. “*Með aflendingu...*” he begins, and his voice shakes, the syllables like glass in his throat. “*...und... unda... við höldum.*” *By unbinding, we hold.* He speaks the suffixes that cancel motion — *-und*, a dull impact, a dead stop; *-unda*, the echo of the stop — and the sea answers with a violence held in check. A swell rises in the middle distance, a wall of water dark and smooth as obsidian, higher than the platform, rolling forward in silence, gathering mass, meaning to crush the syntax and wash the speaker off the rock and edit him into the past tense. Rowan does not flinch. To flinch is to break the case. He holds the suffix, grinding it through his clenched jaw, imposing the limit, and the wave hangs — cresting, never breaking, suspended ten meters out, a monument to potential energy held in place by the invisible wire of the grammar. It trembles with the desire to fall. But the word holds it, because the Aflending has unbound it from the urge to strike. Edda died because a doubt let the weight of water into her lungs before the water ever touched her. Rowan has no doubt left. He burned the last of it as fuel a long time ago. *Stay*, his whole body says. *You are unbound from the shore.* The wave groans, a deep tectonic sound of water displacing air, and then, slowly and grudgingly, it subsides, collapsing not forward but downward, melting back into the flat plane of the bay. Air rushes into his lungs. He has survived the cancellation. The boundary is still fluid, but it obeys the rules, for now.

• • •

The ocean is subdued, not tamed. It waits, heavy and sullen, for the final locks, and Rowan must finish the sequence, because to leave the sentence incomplete is to leave a door unlatched in a gale. He summons the Sæfangi, the Sea-Holding

— not a negotiation but a definition, an anchor. His voice drops an octave; he abandons projection and adopts a crushing flatness, mimicking the sound of the horizon line itself. “*Með sæfanga...*” He draws the circle in the air with his right hand, the movement stiff but exact. “*...nöfnin lifa.*” *Through sea-holding, names remain.* He engages the continuous present, the state that does not decay, riveting the names of the village — house, stone, path, self — to their coordinates. The water undergoes a change of phase: the restless chop and the interfering waves and the chaotic texture all vanish, and in a perfect semicircle fifty meters out the Atlantic becomes grey glass, unnaturally flat, reflecting nothing, a zone of stillness made purely out of the density of a word. The silence deepens as the wind slides over the flattened water without friction enough to make a sound. Rowan sways; the energy required to enforce stillness is greater than the energy required to move; his knees buckle, the cartilage grinding, and he locks them, because he is the bollard now, the stanchion, the fixed point.

One more. The seal. “*Hrimfall.*” *Winter-Falling.* “*Í vetrarfalli...*” He looks at the grey glass and speaks to the temperature of the universe. “*...tíminn sefur.*” *In winter-falling, time sleeps.* The raven ending, the one that flies and lands and does not move again. The air snaps; the moisture in it freezes instantly; frost blooms along the water’s edge, the grammar overriding the thermometer, white crystals racing across the wet basalt and locking the liquid margin into a solid lattice, a rim of ice forming on the lip of the sea, a fragile white border marking the exact limit of the ocean’s permission. It is done. The sentence is closed. The full stop is set.

Rowan exhales, and the sound is a ragged tear in the quiet. His chest heaves against the wool. He lowers his hands, which hang numb and curled, and he stands in the silence of his own making, the boundary holding, the village behind him safe for one more rotation of the earth, the sea agreed to its terms. He turns to go, the movement slow, the turn of a heavy thing on a worn pivot, meaning to walk back to the cottage and the kettle and the chair where he will sit and wait for the light to fail so that he can sleep and do this again.

• • •

But this morning, before he goes, he does the thing he has not done in all the years he has stood on this rock. He takes the envelope from against his chest, where it has ridden through every storm, softened now almost to cloth, the ink of *for E.B.* only faded to a watermark. He is old enough now. He can hold the boundary alone, or nearly — he can hold it with a net of other throats, which Sigrún taught him is the same as holding it well — and so, by Edda’s measure and his own, he is finally finished enough to read it. He slides his thumb under the flap. The old glue gives without resistance, as if it had been waiting to be let go.

Inside is a single sheet, folded once, in his mother's hand — not the cramped English hand he knew, but an older hand, rounder, the hand of the girl on the black coast, a hand he has never seen and recognizes anyway. It is short. It is not an explanation; he understands, reading it, that his mother was constitutionally incapable of an explanation, that she died as she lived, in the locative, placing things near the truth without ever letting the truth take a subject. He does not read it aloud. Some of it is only for the woman it was addressed to, who kept it against her own skin for a season and gave it back unopened, and he honors that. But two lines he lets his eyes rest on for a long time, there in the wind, and they are these: *I could not stand where you are standing. Forgive me the leaving; I have paid for it every day in a country with no word for this coast.* And below, smaller, the way a person writes the thing they most mean and least want to be caught meaning: *If it ever comes back to you through me, hold it more gently than I could.*

He does not weep, because he has forgotten how, the way one forgets a case one has stopped declining. But something in his chest, a knot he has carried so long he took it for the shape of his own spine, eases by a single degree, and he stands with the letter open in his cracked hands and understands, at last and completely, that he did not come to Brynjavík to study a dying grammar. He came to finish a sentence his mother walked out of forty years before he was born into the middle of it. His whole life — the ear for what is withheld, the tools built to translate a silence, the career he told his department was an accident of interest — all of it was the debt taking the only route home it had. He is not the one who inherited the boundary despite the women who were spent for it. He is the one his mother made, in advance, out of her own refusal, to carry back what she could not. The inheritance was never mechanical. It was the most personal thing that ever happened to him, and it happened before he could speak.

He folds the letter along its old crease and puts it back against his chest. He will not carry it much longer; he can feel that. But he will carry it the rest of the way.

• • •

Then he hears it — a sound on the wind, thin and high and distinct. Not a gull; gulls scream, and this articulates. He freezes, his hand finding the stone, and listens with nerves dulled by years of surf. Again: a whisper, a syllable. He scans the horizon, and the line between sea and sky is empty, no boat, no wreckage, and the moor to his left is fog and green nothing.

He looks down at the patch of sand that gathers in the lee of the platform, a small sheltered drift of shell and grit. There is a footprint in it. Fresh, the edges sharp, the sand compressed and dark, a heavy-soled boot, the heel dug deep, and it points toward the water. He looks at his own boots, planted on the stone. He has not stepped in the sand today, nor for weeks.

He looks back at the print. And beside it, half a stride off, where he had not looked before, there is another — smaller, much smaller, the tread a shallow waffle of the kind stamped into the sole of a child's rubber boot, the sort sold in every hardware shop in the north in four sizes and three colours.

He knows the tread. He has seen it in the mud outside the hall on the fourth Saturday of every month since its owner was old enough to walk the boundary, and he saw it most recently at the north gatepost, where she stood with her grandfather's hand over her hand on the cold stone and got the dative wrong twice and right once and was told she was clever, and went pink, and pretended she had not heard.

Sóley Bjarnadóttir. Eleven years old.

The two prints face the same grey water. Neither leads out of the village and neither leads into the sea. They simply exist, two impressions of weight arriving from nowhere, side by side, as if two people had stood here in the dark and considered the work and then gone back to sleep to be ready for it.

He does not go and ask her. He understands, standing over the sand with his hands hanging at his sides, that if he went to the house and knocked and asked her whether she had come down to the rock in the night she would look at him with her father's flat grey eyes and say no, and would not be lying.

Rowan looks at the sea. The grey glass holds still, but beneath it, deep in the dark, he feels attention. The sea is watching him look at the prints. It is patient. It knows he is finite, that his grammar is made of meat and bone and that meat and bone fail. But the grammar itself — the rules, the cases, the need to speak — endures, and it will find throats to live in, and it does not much care what shape those throats come in, or whose, or how old. When his voice finally cracks, when the Affending fails at last on his tongue, the station will not be abandoned. The sea ensures its own audience.

And the prints in the sand, he understands, are not a threat. They are a roster.

He told himself on this rock, the morning he took it up, that he would carry the knowledge of who had paid for the boundary before him awake, and would not let it become one more thing held at a distance and re-labelled. He has kept that. Through Sigrún, through Arnar, through every winter since, and he has been quietly proud of it in the way a man is proud of a discipline nobody asked him for.

He looks at the small print in the sand and understands that keeping it awake is not the same as being able to do anything about it. That was the last consolation and it was never a consolation, only a better grade of looking. The village will not choose her. Nobody will choose her. There will simply come a morning, eight or twelve or twenty years from now, when his voice fails on the third case and hers does not, and the thing in the bay will note which throat finished the sentence, and the matter will have been settled without one person having decided anything.

Her father was twenty when the water got a handle on him. He has spoken perhaps four hundred words in the years since, and he has never in that time said

his daughter's name where the bay could hear it, and one of the four hundred — patiently, twice, at a gatepost, on a Saturday, in the rain — was the dative.

“Someone else,” Rowan says to the cold air, and then, correcting himself, more quietly, in the plural the language keeps for the things that must be shared to survive: “*Einhver önnur. Fleiri en einn.*” *Some other. More than one.* He turns his back on the two footprints and begins the long walk to the core of the village, leaving the marks in the sand to be read by the rising tide, and carried, and passed on.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Elían Voigt writes literary and speculative fiction concerned with language, memory, and the labor of stewardship. *Declensions of Dark Water* is the third novel in a sequence of works set along the threshold where grammar meets the physical world.

COLOPHON



This book was set in EB Garamond, a contemporary revival of Claude Garamont's sixteenth-century romans, designed by Georg Duffner and Octavio Pardo. The display ornament is the Aldine leaf, a printer's mark dating to fifteenth-century Venice.

FORMÆTRIX